

EXECUTIVE

PREMIUM PROFILE



16Personalities

What's in This Profile?

This profile is designed to cover all the main aspects of Executives' personality as it affects different areas of their life, including Executives' key strengths and weaknesses, relationships, academic path, career and professional development, as well as their communication and friend-making skills, parenting tips and advice, and much, much more. It combines personality type theory with practical, real-world advice from other people who share the Executive personality type.

Personality types have been the topic of many discussions, some of them dating back to ancient times. It's wise to draw from this source of knowledge and experience, especially when unsure of how to handle a specific situation. This kind of knowledge offers the power to control and understand oneself. As Aristotle said millennia ago, "The hardest victory is the victory over self." Consider this profile a plan for success.

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Who is “The Executive?”



Throughout this book, we'll discuss how Executives' traits manifest themselves into a complete personality type. The interactions among the traits result in a unique set of behaviors, and we'll examine the effects on personal growth, relationships, and academic and professional development. The following paragraphs are a brief overview of the Executive personality type, and subsequent chapters will explore each area in much greater detail.

Personal Growth

For Executives, the bedrock of a healthy life is a sense of order, tradition, and stability. Like other members of the Sentinel type group, they feel a strong need to belong – whether to a family, a community, or some other social group. Born leaders, they often step into positions of responsibility and authority to organize people and ensure that best practices are followed.

Thanks to the combination of Observant and Judging traits, these types live in a concrete world of facts, data, and clear-cut boundaries. They have a firm sense of right and wrong, and given their honest, direct natures, feel compelled to share these

views. Driven by an inner sense of responsibility, Executives have a strong work ethic and tend to do everything in their power to fulfill their duties and deliver on their promises. Social mores and conventions matter to people with this personality type, informing the standards they set for themselves and others. As a result, Executives often grow into “model citizens,” serving as pillars of their communities.

Even if everyone turns against them, Executives stick to their principles. This trait is admirable in many circumstances, but if it manifests as plain stubbornness or intransigence, it can hold them back. People with this personality type may find themselves resisting new ideas or perspectives, particularly those that threaten established ways of doing things.

Given their firm convictions, Executives run the risk of imposing their values on others. When others don't meet their high standards, they won't hesitate to share their disapproval. They may express irritation or even wrath toward those who can't match their prodigious work ethic, attention to detail, or loyalty. Executives are willing to make personal sacrifices to meet their obligations, and it frustrates them when the people in their lives won't do the same.

Friends, Family, and Relationships

As Extraverts, Executives love connecting with other people. They're drawn to active roles in traditional, respected institutions, such as civic organizations or faith communities. In their free time, they may find themselves nurturing these connections and participating in related events, from fundraisers to board meetings. These types hate to let people down, so they develop reputations for being straightforward and reliable, never skipping a meeting or flaking on a commitment at the last moment.

That said, they take care not to let their social responsibilities compromise their family lives. Many Executives consider family among their top priorities, and strive to ensure a stable, orderly life for their loved ones. Given their respect for all that’s time-honored, they can also be trusted to carry on traditions from one generation to the next.

Practical and efficient, Executives aren’t prone to grand gestures or great shows of affection. Instead, they show how much they care through acts of service. Rather than buying flowers or writing poems, they might take care of a loved one’s car or clean the kitchen. What they lack in emotional expression, Executives make up for in consistency, loyalty, and devotion. They show up on time, deliver on their promises, and stand by the people who matter to them.

Unfortunately, Executives tend to struggle to recognize and honor their feelings, let alone those of others. Given their rational, concrete mindsets, they may be put off by the irrational and sometimes messy world of emotions. To deepen and sustain their relationships, they must learn to accept their feelings and respect other people’s emotional needs. Luckily, Executives keep a cool head in charged situations, and this trait can help them communicate clearly in the heat of the moment.

Academic and Professional Development

Thanks to their integrity and clear convictions, Executives tend to excel as leaders and managers. Whether they’re coordinating group projects or managing teams, they lead by example, creating cultures that value hard work and discourage cheating or cutting corners. Rather than grasping blindly toward the future, Executives learn from the past, identifying and sticking to best practices and proven protocols.

Unlike Intuitive types, they focus on concrete facts and data. Patient and detail-oriented, they make excellent administrators and decision-makers in many different environments. As students, they're self-motivated, attentive, and remarkably efficient, capable of balancing a heavy course load with significant extracurricular obligations. Whether in the workplace or the classroom, Executives find it easy to assess and implement various action plans. Given their focus and dedication, they may make executing even the most complex projects look like a walk in the park.

Executives respect rules and guidelines, and their loyalty and sense of duty make them reliable, productive employees and students. They can be trusted to pay attention to detail and adhere to rules and procedures, even when it would be easier to do otherwise. Not surprisingly, people with this personality type gravitate toward careers in institutions with strong traditions and explicit hierarchies, such as public service, law, and the military. Executives feel compelled to meet deadlines and deliver on assignments, so they may need to protect themselves from people who try to foist extra work or obligations on them.

Strong-willed and decisive, these types aren't afraid to defend their opinions. This may put them at odds with their colleagues, teachers, or fellow students, particularly those who are sensitive to conflict or criticism. To reach their full potential, Executives may need to learn how to communicate diplomatically and acknowledge other viewpoints. That said, Executives' dedication often makes them irreplaceable, and their self-sufficient desire to build diverse skill sets can lead to achievements in multiple areas.

On That Note...

While we’ve explored what distinguishes people with the Executive personality type from the rest of the population, a brief introduction can’t do justice to the full scope of their strengths and gifts, let alone how they can counterbalance their weaknesses. In the following chapters, we discuss these areas in detail, providing deeper insights as well suggestions and resources for improvement. Understanding one’s personality type is incredibly valuable, and we hope the following information proves useful.

Theory Overview

Five Personality Aspects

Introverted (I) vs. Extraverted (E)

People have long noted that some among them are more outgoing and comfortable interacting with their surroundings, and others are more at ease remaining in quiet solitude with their thoughts. You can see the two types in almost any home, office, or classroom. In our first scale, we focus on the difference between Introversion and Extraversion, which we call the Energy scale.

The Energy scale describes how we see and approach the outside world, including people, objects, and activities within it. There are significant links between this scale and things like willingness to volunteer, boredom, thrill seeking, motivation, and romantic assertiveness, to name just a few. The links may not prove one causes the other. However, it does hint at a relationship.

Introverted People: Attuned Inwards

More Internal: Introverts ground themselves more easily in solitude and derive energy from their own thoughts.

More Selective: Introverts are careful when choosing the people with whom they spend time and prefer a quieter environment when they have a choice.

Slow to Offer Opinions: Within reason, Introverts like a little time to process their thoughts and ideas and are slow to offer opinions, fearing they may be too rash.

Extraverted People: Outwardly Engaged

More Outgoing: Extraverts tend to be outgoing both socially and in their willingness to interact with new and interesting environments.

Energetic: Extraverts have an energy that is almost replenished by its expression. They are energized by being energetic and putting themselves in stimulating situations.

Quick with Opinions: Extraverts are generally more comfortable with a flurry of opinions that typically are a part of casual conversations. It's almost like brainstorming ideas on the spot while saving the editing for later.

Intuitive (N) vs. Observant (S)

The second scale in our model is called Mind and addresses Intuitive and Observant styles. Each trait determines what kind of information we focus on and how it is used. It's the foundation on which all the other approaches are built.

All personality types include either those who favor the Intuitive style or those who prefer the Observant style. But before we start, it's important to say that this has nothing to do with how they take in information. The word "Observant" might suggest it does. But Intuitive and Observant types use their five senses in the same way. Rather than how they absorb information, these qualities show how each of these traits manages it once it's received.

Intuitive People: Living in the World of Ideas

Focus on Ideas: Intuitive people are fascinated by the world of ideas and love to discover the connections between various concepts and realities.

Are Deeply Curious: Within the realm of ideas, Intuitive individuals have a strong curiosity that leads them to somewhat adventurous discoveries.

Highly Imaginative: Those who prefer this trait typically stretch concepts to include possibilities beyond the obvious. “What if this not only means... but what if it could also mean...”

Observant People: Feet On the Ground

A Practical Focus: Observant people are more in touch with the concrete world and work within it. They favor consistent actions and measurable results.

Facts Over Theory: These individuals leave theorizing and brainstorming to others, preferring to effectively apply established facts.

More in the Moment: While Observant individuals have a respect for the past and the future, they see them through the lens of what they can do now. The task at hand is always the most important.

Thinking (T) vs. Feeling (F)

The Thinking and Feeling traits determine how we decide matters and cope with emotions. While we all have feelings, there are significant differences in how we react to them and what role those feelings play in our lives. This then influences several other areas, mostly related to our interactions with other people. This is what our third trait, Nature, focuses on.

Thinking People: Where Reason Rules

Rational and Objective: Thinking individuals are most comfortable dealing with things that come from rational thought and involve proven principles.

Logic Over Feelings: While these types often feel quite deeply, they typically place their rationality and logic above any emotional responses.

Constantly Assessing: Thinking people constantly scan ideas and actions to decide whether they make sense or not. They can be valuable in any process that requires any level of critical thinking.

Feeling People: Those Who Follow Their Feelings

Lead from the Heart: Feeling types listen to their feelings, care about how others feel, and are unafraid of sharing this perspective.

Focus on Morals and Ethics: People and their welfare are usually prioritized above any other consideration with the individuals who exhibit the Feeling trait.

A Different Kind of Rationality: While the Feeling type's way of choosing a direction may not always be totally objective, that doesn't mean that they lack rationality. There is practical wisdom in including feelings and consideration for the well-being of oneself and others in the decisions one makes.

Judging (J) vs. Prospecting (P)

The Tactics scale – Judging and Prospecting – is about how people plan and deal with the options they have. But this definition doesn't just concern what individuals write in their day planners. It's much broader. These traits answer questions like, "Do you

prefer spontaneity or certainty?" "Do you feel more comfortable acting only with all your ducks lined neatly in a row? Or does a certain amount of flexibility or chaos excite you and prove motivating?" "Do you need more choices or fewer?"

At its core, this scale determines our attitude toward certainty and structure in our lives, both at mental and physical levels.

Judging People: A Steady Hand

Predictability Rules: Judging types are most at home when there is a clear-cut, well-considered plan that provides sure steps and promotes certain outcomes.

Work Hard: Judging individuals tend to work hard, perhaps seeing strong effort as a way of ensuring predictability.

By the Book: Individuals with this trait usually like to do things by the book and respect reasonable protocols, established techniques, and duties. They sometimes see doing things any other way as "reinventing the wheel."

Prospecting People: Possibilities in the Moment

Relaxed Spontaneity: Prospecting types tend to deal with life and all its opportunities as it comes at them.

Creative: This trait can promote "coloring outside the lines." This can lead to discovering new creative solutions.

Serial Passions: Prospecting individuals may find themselves passing quickly through many interests in their lives. Because of these experiences, they can possess a broad array of knowledge and ideas.

Assertive (-A) vs. Turbulent (-T)

Assertive and Turbulent – the Identity scale – measures how confident one is and how that confidence influences all other traits. The degree that people move more boldly or more timidly affects the way they make choices. It determines how they express their skills. Whether one is too confident to accept criticism or puts too much weight on the criticism of others because they lack self-confidence can make a major difference. The caution or lack of caution people apply to the things they do can color everything.

Assertive People: A Confident Approach

Confident Style: People with the Assertive identity are self-confident and resist stress.

Often Success-Oriented: Because these individuals don't spend hours fretting, it might be assumed they aren't interested in results. For many of them, nothing could be further from the truth.

Responsive and Proactive: Assertive people may jump into a task quickly, not being as burdened with the need to think endlessly about what may go wrong.

Turbulent People: Always Improving

Useful Worry: Turbulent people often worry and engage in self-doubt. While that might sound negative, the flipside of the coin is that it fuels much of their drive and productivity.

Driven to Succeed and Improve: Turbulent individuals are constantly seeking to do better and be better. This pushes them to put great effort into life.

Problem Spotters: Because of their cautious nature and tendency to worry, those with the Turbulent trait often spot problems early and are able to contain them quickly.

Type Groups

Now you know what each type consists of. But how do they fit together?

In our system, we group personality types in two different ways:

- **Roles** determine our goals, interests, and preferred activities.
- **Strategies** reflect our preferred ways of doing things and achieving our goals.

You can think of Roles and Strategies as two ways of organizing personality types into categories. These two categorization methods each highlight different facets of the types. For examples, Roles can show us why certain types share similar interests, and Strategies can explain why certain types approach socializing the way they do.

We discuss Strategies in depth at the end of this e-book, in *The Puzzle of Personality*. With that in mind, let's explore the importance of Roles.

Roles

There are four Roles, each of which groups together four personality types.

- The **Analyst Role** includes Architects (INTJ), Logicians (INTP), Commanders (ENTJ), and Debaters (ENTP).

- The **Diplomat Role** includes Advocates (INFJ), Mediators (INFP), Protagonists (ENFJ), and Campaigners (ENFP).
- The **Sentinel Role** includes Logisticians (ISTJ), Defenders (ISFJ), Executives (ESTJ), and Consuls (ESFJ).
- The **Explorer Role** includes Virtuosos (ISTP), Adventurers (ISFP), Entrepreneurs (ESTP), and Entertainers (ESFP).

So, why do we organize the types in this way? To put it simply, Roles help us to recognize important common ground between personality types.

The types within each Role all share the same Mind trait – either Intuitive or Observant. As you might remember, this trait is incredibly important because it determines how we view the world. As a result, the types within a given Role are alike in a very important respect: they share similar ways of understanding the world and their place within it.

In addition to the Mind trait, the types within a given Role also share the same Nature trait (Thinking or Feeling) or the same Tactics trait (Judging or Prospecting).

Does this seem like information overload? If so, don't worry. To help you get a better grasp of the Roles, let's go through them one by one and find out what makes them tick.

Analysts: Intuitive (N) and Thinking (T)

The personality types in the Analyst Role – Architects, Logicians, Commanders, and Debaters – are known for their irreverent curiosity. Thanks to the Intuitive trait, these types are rarely satisfied with the status quo. Instead, they'll go deep in their search

for ways to make things better, more efficient, and more effective. Meanwhile, the Thinking trait means that they value rationality over emotionality.

Analysts' greatest strengths include:

Driven to learn. Analysts want to know how the world works. In their quest for knowledge, they push the boundaries of their understanding. The result? Their expertise in certain areas can be remarkable.

Questioning natures. Analysts rarely accept things at face value. Ever questioning, they look beyond superficial appearances. This enables them to come up with deep, unexpected insights.

Intellectual energy. Full of fresh, counterintuitive ideas, Analysts know how to spark a lively debate. Conversations with these candid, sharp-witted types can be a breath of fresh air.

Born to improve. Analysts are relentless self-improvers. Once they've recognized a flaw, they apply all their rationality, imagination, and ambition to make it right.

Analysts' forceful imaginations, when trained and focused, enable them to achieve incredible results. But, like anyone, these types can have their Achilles heels, such as:

Lost in thought. Thinking up great ideas gives Analysts a rush. As a result, they're at risk of staying in the realm of thought, never acting out their ideas.

Ever the critic. In the same vein, some Analysts are more comfortable thinking about and critiquing other people's work than jumping into the fray themselves. In time, these types may be frustrated to find themselves outpaced by people with real-world experience.

Hunting for flaws. If taken too far, Analysts desire for improvement can have them hunting down the flaws in everything. As a result, they may undervalue the people and opportunities they encounter.

Emoti-what? Analysts feel more comfortable in the realm of thought than the messy world of emotions. But like anyone, they need to develop emotional literacy in order to deepen their relationships and fully understand themselves.

Fortunately, Analysts have enough creativity and ambition to move beyond these stumbling blocks. When they take action, look for the positive, and train their curiosity on the realm of emotions, these types can grow into their full potential.

Diplomats: Intuitive (N) and Feeling (F)

Diplomats – Advocates, Mediators, Protagonists, and Campaigners – tend to be warm, caring, and generous. Bringing together the Intuitive and Feeling traits, they shine in their understanding of emotions – both their own and other people’s. This ability helps them shine when it comes to diplomacy, counseling others, and communication in general.

Diplomats’ gifts and talents include:

Emotional literacy. Even when it’s far from obvious, Diplomats can often perceive how others are feeling. From the outside, this might look like mind-reading. But in truth, it’s a combination of self-reflection and radical compassion that helps Diplomats understand others’ emotional states.

Only connect. Diplomats don’t use their people skills to manipulate others. Instead, they aim to nurture genuine connections with the people they encounter. Moreover, many Diplomats feel called to serve others however they can.

Do no harm. Deep down, Diplomats want what's best for everyone. For them, causing someone else distress would feel like a wound to their own psyche. As a result, these types aim to promote cooperation and harmony rather than conflict.

Creators at work. Profoundly creative, Diplomats are always on the hunt for inspiration. Whether or not they take up artistic pursuits, these types tend to enjoy self-exploration and self-expression.

Diplomats have high ideals. For them, kindness and altruism burn as brightly as a fire on a chilly winter's night. But if left unchecked, this idealism can have its downsides, including:

Impractical magic. Tempering passion with cold practicality is a challenge for Diplomats. These types are often reluctant to make tough decisions – especially if those decisions require them to compromise on their ideals or hurt someone's feelings.

Beautiful ideas. Diplomats have the best of intentions, and they have countless ideas about ways to help people. They're at risk, however, of staying stuck in the realm of ideas instead of taking action and sticking to a plan.

Taking on too much. In their efforts to make a difference, Diplomats may overcommit themselves – emotionally, physically, or even financially. If they don't deliver everything they'd hoped, they may feel overwhelmed or disappointed in themselves.

Easily hurt. Sensitive to criticism and rejection, these types may react strongly if other people question the value of their ideals. Disagreement and conflict can leave Diplomats feeling discouraged and hurt.

In all their actions, Diplomats crave a sense of meaning and purpose. Specifically, they feel called to cultivate positive change and gentle beauty in the world around them. Motivated by intangible rewards felt in the heart and soul, these types have a conviction to serve the greater good.

Sentinels: Observant (S) and Judging (J)

Sentinels – Logisticians, Defenders, Executives, and Consuls – are cooperative and practical. This grounded approach helps them feel comfortable with themselves just as they are. Steadfast and hardworking, these types pride themselves on their character and competence.

Here are some of the ways that Sentinels contribute to their homes, workplaces, social circles, and beyond:

Loving duty. These types feel a deep responsibility for those they care about. Specifically, Sentinels feel duty-bound to keep their loved ones safe and to help them lead good lives.

Always on time. Sure, Sentinels might occasionally fall behind schedule. But most of the time, they pride themselves on being unfailingly reliable. As a result, friends, loved ones, and coworkers can trust that Sentinels won't flake on their commitments.

Keepers of tradition. Sentinels work hard to maintain the ways things are done. In their home life, this means they love to continue family traditions. At the workplace, these types keep track of and defend best practices.

Unwavering diligence. Sentinels aren't afraid of hard work. On a daily basis, they practice their virtues of consistency and persistence, refusing to take shortcuts or

stop before their work is done. And in situations where someone needs to step up and take responsibility, Sentinels can be counted on to come through.

Sentinels feel bolstered by having reliable people in their lives, and they make it a priority to hold up their end of the bargain. But even these dependable types can have their challenges, including:

Resistance to change. For Sentinels, trying new ways of doing things can feel wrong – almost like breaking an unwritten set of rules. These types can be skeptical of change, and they may stick with suboptimal choices on the grounds of “that’s how it’s always been done.”

Stubbornness toward others. Similarly, Sentinels may feel personally affronted when other people upset the status quo. What someone else might describe as “experimenting with new ideas” may seem reckless or disrespectful to Sentinels. As a result, these types might dig in their heels, even if that means forestalling progress.

Imposing their values. Sentinels love to give advice and shepherd people toward better lives – at least, what Sentinels consider better lives. It may be hard for these types to accept that not everyone holds stability, tradition, and respectability among their core values. And when other people don’t follow their advice, Sentinels may want to judge them harshly.

Sentinels’ loyalty and steadfastness shine in many situations. When they balance their firm convictions with curiosity and openness, these types can become nothing short of inspirations to the people in their lives.

Explorers: Observant (S) and Prospecting (P)

Explorers – Virtuosos, Adventurers, Entrepreneurs, and Entertainers – are self-reliant and quick-thinking. They're always ready to tackle a challenge or act on the spur of the moment. This spontaneity doesn't only help them solve problems – it also enables them to find opportunities for enjoyment in their everyday lives.

Here are a few of Explorers' notable strengths:

Surfing the waves. Many people struggle with change, but not Explorers. These types can adapt to new situations with minimal regret or second-guessing. In fact, they often enjoy change and appreciate breaks from routine.

Socially dynamic. Because of their openness, many Explorers enjoy meeting new people and trying out new social experiences. This helps them to build a network of diverse and interesting friends and acquaintances.

Getting things done. Explorers don't overthink things. Instead, they leap into action and get the job done. These types spend their energy on taking concrete steps, only pausing to consider abstract ideas or nitty-gritty details when it's absolutely necessary.

Picking up techniques. Utilitarian in their way, Explorers love to master new tools and techniques. Whatever their hobbies and passions, these types enjoy the challenge of building their skills and picking up new ways of doing things.

Explorers enjoy being free of obligations, where they can indulge themselves or their interests on their own time. Like most traits, this has its upsides and its downsides. Here are some tendencies that Explorers may need to counteract:

Losing interest. We all lose interest in our activities from time to time. But Explorers often run out of motivation as soon as a project no longer feels fun, novel, or exciting.

What planning? Explorers prefer to deal with challenges on the fly rather than plan ahead. Alas, sometimes an ounce of planning really is worth a pound of cure.

Risky business. Explorers are drawn to pleasure, risk, and – sometimes – risky pleasures. As they grow and mature, however, they often learn that some risks simply aren't worth taking.

Explorers connect with the world in a way that's almost childlike in its wonder and sheer fun. It can be a challenge for them to work for things with a distant or unexciting payoff, but when they harness their passion and administer just enough self-discipline, they can move heaven and earth.

Now, let's talk about you.

Personal Growth



Exploring Possibility

Executives have excellent practical skills and use them effectively in leadership roles. Traditional values, like a strong work ethic and duty to familial and community responsibilities, form the framework by which these types live. As Extraverts, they not only live by these rules, they also want others to live by a certain code, for the good of all. Obligations are everything to Executives, and “Duty” is their middle name.

Duty, Dependability, and Fairness

Executives who want to improve themselves have several resources to draw on. A need to fulfill their duty (however they see it) motivates them to carry out their work, whatever it may be. Dependability is another fundamental element of the Executive personality – they don’t dodge personal accountability and want others to perceive them as people on whom they can rely. They believe that no one is above adhering to a certain set of standards, least of all themselves. It’s this definition of fairness that they can use as the baseline for personal improvement.

Motivation and Development

Executives can consider personal growth in five closely related, but distinct, areas. The first three relate to the internal development of self-regard, and the latter two are more about tactics to engage more fulfilling lives.

Motivation

- **Self-esteem** speaks to how much Executives like themselves. Accepting both their flaws and strengths creates a base of internal appreciation that enables change motivated by desire instead of shame.
- **Self-respect** speaks to their sense of worth. People with this personality type value rational logic, and when they live their beliefs and values, a balanced sense of pride in who they are follows.
- **Self-confidence** is the energy source that moves Executives forward in life. When belief in their abilities is confirmed using their skills, Executives are driven to make steady progress.

Development

- **Self-evolution** describes processes of conscious growth that Executives take on to realize their potential. Knowing when to assess and expand themselves enhances their abilities and happiness.
- **Self-responsibility** is taking charge of their lives by accepting accountability for what they can do to improve things. Being conscious of their behavior and direction in life helps them guide their own progress instead of letting fate dictate a path.

Attending to each of these five areas can promote successful, fulfilling lives, while a lack of attention can serve as a source of persistent difficulty. For example, when Executives (and many other types) feel a lack of self-respect, they may engage in intellectually aggressive behaviors that compensate for their insecurity – not often a path to objective learning and growth.

Moving Forward

Conscious personal growth is about more than feeling obligated to change. When inspired, these types seek new ways to be happier and more successful – including an independent and personal definition of success. The goal is to spur their inner drive with ideas, encouragement, and gentle guidance for possible problems along the way.

In the following sections, we'll first examine Executives' characteristics in their most beneficial forms. Using these motivational components in "balanced" ways helps these types lead fulfilling, productive, and happy lives.

Next, we'll describe "unbalanced" tendencies that can emerge – departures from healthy, productive motivation strategies. We'll also explain some adverse effects Executives may experience as a result.

Finally, we'll discuss what Executives can do to improve or "rebalance" each of the motivational components, and provide exercises, reflection, and actions to aid in personal growth and development.

Self-Esteem

Self-esteem involves Executives finding value in themselves. When their self-esteem is low, they feel they lack purpose. With high self-esteem, their sense of value is firmly intact, and they believe they're living up to the high standards they set for themselves. These standards are grounded in the written and unwritten rules of family, culture, nation, religion, profession, or other community-based expectations, and guide Executives as they make their way in the world, giving them a rubric by which to measure themselves. The closer to the mark they see themselves, the more satisfaction these types feel, but it's a matter of perception: self-esteem can be reflected in their external achievements, but, ultimately, it's an attitude that must come from within.

Balanced Self-Esteem

Finding Purpose in Protocol

Executives have great respect for structure and organization, which they see as a way of bringing order to the chaos of life. In adhering to the laws of the land or the rules of a contract, they show their deference to the wisdom of something greater than themselves.

For these types, rules are meant to be obeyed, but only because following the rules is often the best approach. If there seems to be a flaw in the rules, Executives may question it, but only at the proper time, and through the proper channels. However, when in doubt, they're more likely to stick to the script than play the part of renegades.

Finding Satisfaction in Effort

Wise Executives, however, soon discover that rules are something to aspire to more than something to realize. No one can follow any creed with absolute dedication, and these types must accept their fallibility. By the same token, Executives must accept that they can measure gains in life only according to the effort they've exerted, not in the gains themselves.

Every day, Executives wake up with the knowledge that for every success they have, failure is waiting just around the corner to take it away. Rather than paralyzing them, however, this knowledge energizes them to leap out of bed and start attacking problems. And, every night, they go to sleep satisfied not with the number of problems solved, but by the effort expended in solving them. Executives with balanced self-esteem rest easy knowing that while they aren't always right, they try as hard as they can to get it right, every day.

Unbalanced Self-Esteem

No Excuses

Even Executives realize that there are times when rules have extenuating circumstances, but those whose self-esteem is unbalanced often have trouble seeing where these exceptions might apply. They may adopt a "no excuses" policy for themselves and others, but this attitude seldom proves as productive as it might seem.

The Effects on Others

Even the best-laid plans can go astray, but failure isn't an option for Executives whose self-esteem is unbalanced, and they may refuse to settle for even an iota short of

perfection. Such aggressive perfectionism can lead to burnout on their part as well as low morale – or even mutiny – on the part of those who suffer under their reign. Such Executives may see these effects as simply the price to pay to gain results, no matter how incremental.

This perfectionism can take a personal toll as well, exhausting even these energetic types. As they chase impossible standards and drive others away in the process, they may find themselves alone, separated from people who would otherwise freshen their outlook and efforts. Executives suffering from unbalanced self-esteem can sustain this for impressive amounts of time through sheer force of will, but their bodies and minds eventually give out. When it comes to self-worth, without balance, they risk losing everything for which they've fought.

Relentless Perfectionism

Executives who have become too driven to perfection may win a few allies who respect their unswerving dedication, but none ever truly live up to the impossible standards they've set. While Executives may feel that those who can't live up to their unbalanced standards are simply not worth keeping around, people are more complex creatures than a simple unbending set of rules can dictate.

In some cases, individuals are indeed toxic, and Executives are wise to steer clear of them. But when these types become toxic themselves – demanding more than those around them can (or should) reasonably give – then these guardians of community may soon find themselves without communities to defend. Having lost the trust – the confidence – of the people whom they once claimed to serve (albeit in a leadership role), Executives may see their confidence erode. A leader is nothing when there's no one to follow.

Rebalancing Self-Esteem

Good Enough

Perfectionism naturally simmers in the background of Executives' lives, with all their standards and rules to maintain. When their self-esteem is out of balance, they may need to guard against allowing fastidiousness to take over. While it's hard for these types to embrace the idea that sometimes "good enough" is, indeed, good enough, finding ways to do so gives them a more balanced sense of self, and a more realistic understanding of their strengths and weaknesses.

The world is more forgiving than these stringent perfectionists allow themselves to imagine. Catastrophes happen – and, at times, we can avoid them. However, there's a difference between preparation and overpreparation, and smart Executives learn when to tell which is which. If they've taken all *reasonable* precautions (and not all *possible* precautions) when catastrophes strike, at least they can rest assured they did their due diligence in preventing them.

Taking Breaks to Gain Perspective

The best cure for misconceptions is a dose of reality. Executives who despair that all their efforts may come to naught have only to look at other people to see that, while they may not have all their bases covered, they do cover more than most. Those who become too insulated in their bubble of responsibilities may soon lose touch with the obstacles others must overcome to pursue their goals. Here are some steps Executives can take to reacquaint themselves to life outside their busy agendas.

- A few minutes to touch base with an acquaintance or two is often all it takes for Executives to gain a newfound appreciation for their capabilities, which they can be too quick to take for granted.
- During these breaks, it's important for these types to listen to better understand those around them. Often, people express problems in ways that are difficult for Executives to relate to. They're bold and rational, but not everyone shares these traits. Emotional perspectives can leave Executives wondering why others don't just run through the facts, and issuing complaints without wanting solutions can be downright frustrating.
- By taking a step back to exercise the patience and clarity they ask of others, Executives provide individuals with opportunities to make themselves heard and understood. Sometimes people need to get their feelings out before they're ready to address issues. When Executives exercise this skill, they find themselves more respected and admired by those around them, boosting their sense of self-esteem.

Self-Respect

Simply put, self-respect is about liking who one is, rather than who one wants to be. While similar to self-esteem in that it's a motivator, self-respect is less about having an overarching sense of worth and more about approving one's actions. It asks the question, "Do I like myself because of the way I conduct my life and the way I express myself in the world?" Executives whose self-respect is balanced are satisfied with not only what they have, but with what they must do to get it. For them, the only thing more important than getting things done is getting things done right.

Balanced Self-Respect

Doing Good by the Rules

Executives attain self-respect through their positive drive to make the world effective for themselves and those for whom they care. Unlike many who might see rules as somewhat arbitrary, these types sincerely believe that set standards are essential to the world being a better place. When safeguarding these standards, Executives see themselves as contributing to the well-being of themselves and others – a very respectable thing to do.

It wouldn't be accurate to say that these types demand unthinking obedience of themselves or others. The reverence they have for rules comes from an in-depth knowledge of them, and the maturity to understand that impulses must be guided by reason – with a set of rules providing the reason that may otherwise be lacking. Rules are a restraint, and though restraints can be confining, they can also be freeing, if they free people from making adverse decisions that would only serve to limit them in the end. “Nothing good happens between midnight and daylight,” Executive parents may reason, and therefore see curbing such behavior with a curfew as a restriction that only frees their teenage sons and daughters to pursue activities that ultimately contribute to their well-being.

Diligent Attention

These types strive to maintain standards and make sure people do things as they should – “should” being their culture's established standard. Their need for self-respect motivates Executives to oversee their work with careful attention to protocols and expectations, and to raise their families and live their private lives dedicated to upholding conventional principles for living.

As these types mature, their understanding of these principles typically develops as well. Young Executives may look for older role models who exemplify the traits that appeal to them – stability, integrity, achievement – and find commonality in a shared set of standards they appear to hold. Reasoning that those who keep similar convictions achieve comparable success, Executives may pattern themselves after these exemplars. As time goes on, however, they're sure to see that where there are rules, there's division, and even the clearest rules must be interpreted. In deciding which interpretations of these rules to follow (or how to interpret the rules for themselves), Executives take the first steps in becoming less slaves to tradition and more masters of their destiny.

Unbalanced Self-Respect

Doubling Down on Standards

When Executives see a disconnect between the standards they hold for themselves and their actual adherence to them, their internal need for coherence may manifest externally in increasing demands for order in the behavior of those around them.

Unfortunately, this can awaken a zealous rigidity. As unbalanced self-esteem manifests itself in perfection, stiffness plays a similar role for Executives seeking self-respect. They can take an asset and allow it to “overheat” to make up for what ground they believe is lost.

Being a stickler can be a good thing. It's admirable to get things reasonably right. Being too much of a stickler, however, can overwhelm people. This can result in attempts to remove any human element, like emotions, from Executives' endeavors. Communicated in a severe tone, statements such as, “We must work harder and let the rules guide us exactly as they're written,” can be dehumanizing. Executives might

reason that eliminating such distractions as exhaustion and dissatisfaction in the pure pursuit of profitable goals isn't only good for them, but good for others as well. Unfortunately, different types of people have unique ideas about the qualities that contribute to their self-respect. In such cases, Executives may simply come across as overbearing and domineering, rather than the noble companions and colleagues they could be otherwise.

The Dark Path of Surrender

Executives who pursue this rigidity to the point of misery and failure for themselves or others may surrender to a darker impulse: an “all or nothing” mindset. If trying too hard makes things ineffective, they may throw up their hands and declare that any degree of trying is simply useless.

While Executives certainly have a deserved reputation for being hardworking, even they have their limits, both physically and emotionally. If their time-honored tactics of planning, consensus-seeking, and follow-through fail, it's probable that their motivation may disappear along with their lack of success.

Rebalancing Self-Respect

Time is Precious (and Passing By)

When we don't like who we are, it's primarily because we don't like what we do. By focusing on concrete actions, Executives move beyond abstract virtues and into quantifiable values. It's hard to say, for instance, who among a group of people is the most honest, or the most reliable, or the most hardworking. But if these individuals were to explain where their time went – to whom, and for whose benefit – then a clearer picture would begin to emerge.

In the end, time is the most unrenowable – and therefore, most valuable – resource. When time is spent on things, or on people, it shows they're valued by those who place their own irrevocable value within them. Executives who squander their time squander their worth, and it's often only when they see clearly where their time has gone that they can begin to recover the self-respect they foolishly expended on fruitless endeavors. To do this, Executives can try this activity.

- Executives who want to reevaluate their self-image may find it helpful to make two lists – their “pros and cons,” so to speak.
- On the first list, they can write down all the ways they add value to others' lives. Even at particularly low points, they're sure to find instance after instance where they have helped other people get where they're going in life – and where they continue to do so.
- To deal with any concerns they have with liking themselves, Executives can create a list of the ways their actions benefit others. Their effect on others may be direct and personal, but it's just as likely to be indirect and involve supporting a system. The methods don't matter; all that matters is, due to some action on their part, someone they value saw a gain.
- On the second list, Executives should list their “cons” – all the ways that they've failed those around them, subtracting value rather than adding it.
- Though less pleasant than the previous one, this list may be far more instructive, highlighting those areas where these types should most seek change. Not that change is always possible, or even desirable – sometimes the fault isn't with us, but with circumstances. Still, Executives owe it to themselves and to the people around them to make a change if the fault does lie in their hands.

Help from Objective Others

After taking a personal inventory, it might be helpful to compare notes with a trusted acquaintance. The objectivity that comes from an outside perspective can be invaluable in helping Executives come to more realistic appraisals of their strengths and weaknesses. Objective others might be all too willing to add items to Executives' "pros" list, remembering the positive effects that might have escaped their notice. At the same time, truly objective others can be just as quick to burst Executives' bubbles who claim too much credit or ignore the unintended consequences of their decisions.

When looking at the second list – the "cons" – objective others might be even more valuable. Together, they can assess tactics, helping Executives escape any counterproductive ruts they might have fallen into.

Self-Confidence

Self-confidence concerns trusting one's abilities. When self-confidence is lacking, every decision is shrouded in doubt and hobbled by hesitation. Self-confident Executives, on the other hand, act swiftly and decisively. They know they aren't always right, but infallibility is an impossible standard. To be the best, they need not be perfect, only better than second best.

Balanced Self-Confidence

Confidence from Reliability

Reliability refers to how Executives see themselves as people who can always be called on as either a first resort or a last resort to do what must be done. They're ambitious, but only because of their self-image as the most capable defenders of

everything they hold dear. In their minds, if they fall down on the job, there's no one else to do it, or do it nearly as well. Executives work hard to ensure that whenever they're called on, they're able to perform at their peak.

These types are team players, not lone wolves, however. They may seek leadership positions, but happily serve capable leaders themselves, and may even insist that, "Everyone has a boss." Even if Executives see themselves as their team's most valuable asset, they still recognize that five, ten, or a hundred folks working in coordination can often accomplish more in a short period of time than any one of them could in an entire lifetime. If they want to be perceived as reliable, it's because they want to have relationships with other reliable people whom they can trust, whether in business, romance, or simple friendship.

Pride in Achievement

Executives take pride in their accomplishments, which they see as merely the consequent rewards of living successful lives. Medals and trophies are concrete representations of the countless invisible hours of hard work athletes and other competitors sacrifice to be the best. In much the same way, the manicured lawns and well-kept automobiles of Executives tell the world that they're sacrificing, too – though they don't see it as a sacrifice, only their duty as productive members of society. Nice houses and cars aren't mere luxury goods for them, but concrete ways of showing the world they work hard for what they have, and they spend their money with more prudence than extravagance.

After all, talk is cheap. People can claim to be caring spouses, supportive parents, or industrious workers all they want, but Executives have the goods to back up their claims: well-dressed families and well-kept homes are all the evidence they need of

their efforts. Those with balanced self-confidence know their success is apparent, leaving them with no reason to restate the obvious by bragging about it.

Unbalanced Self-Confidence

Making Unreasonable Efforts

Executives who become too determined to prove their worth to others may begin to lose the ability to distinguish between reasonable efforts to fulfill their obligations, and heroic efforts that are out of proportion to the size of their original commitments. Their insecurities may also drive them to tear down the achievements of others, particularly if they appear more successful in some way: wealthier, more attractive, more content. In both cases, Executives with unbalanced self-confidence are looking elsewhere for reassurance, when it's instead their internal perception of themselves that's flawed.

Over Commitment

In most cases, Executives realize that their time is finite, and keep their schedules busy but manageable. But when these types feel their accomplishments don't match their self-image, they may compensate by sacrificing more time for others than they can truly spare. Those with unbalanced self-confidence may assume that they're more capable than they really are and promise more than they can reasonably deliver. Executives with multiple commitments may be forced by changing circumstances to re-prioritize, leading to broken promises and damaged trust on the part of all involved.

Little is more harmful to Executives' self-image than the inability to follow through on their commitments. They may attempt to shore up their self-confidence by being

harder on themselves – taking on more responsibilities at the expense of losing precious free time. This vicious cycle helps no one, as increasingly burned out Executives only become less and less capable of fulfilling even their original obligations, not to mention any new ones they take on.

Insecurity through Envy

These types pride themselves on their ability to do anything that needs to be done as well as, or better than, anyone else, so failures – even the most understandable ones – can make them uneasy. Executives who feel they aren't living up to their internal standards may compensate by minimizing the achievements of others to draw focus away from their own lack of success.

Professional setbacks may lead Executives with unbalanced self-confidence to cast aspersions on their coworkers or professional peers. They may claim that any advantages coworkers possess are due not to differences in ability or effort, but instead to favoritism or other extraneous political factors. This attitude doesn't only come into play at work, of course – Executives with shaken self-confidence may lash out at their romantic interests' exes or other potential partners, for instance. But the attitude in every case is the same – when their self-confidence is unbalanced, Executives see others' accomplishments as threatening because they always have the nagging thought, "What has this person done, that I have not, to achieve something that I want in life?"

Rebalancing Self-Confidence

Hard Work and Fair Play

For Executives, hard work and fair play are all it takes to succeed in life. When they perceive that peers – or worse still, younger individuals – are experiencing greater success, these types tend to reach one of two conclusions: either those people work harder, or they have hidden advantages. While there's often some truth in both conclusions, Executives who dwell too long on what others are doing are only ignoring their own unique contributions and strengths.

Managing Obligations

Little disturbs Executives' sense of self-confidence more than failing to live up to their obligations, which only becomes more likely as the number their obligations increase. Although Executives are skilled at managing busy schedules, they tend to leave little space in them for themselves, and even less when they feel they must prove themselves. Here are some ideas these types can try to bring some balance back to their obligations.

- Thinking twice before taking on new obligations is always helpful, but in addition to being more protective of their time, Executives would do well to remember that obligations are a two-way street. The people who rely on them can be counted on in turn, and smart Executives know when to ask for favors, as well as when to repay them.
- Not that they should keep track of every good turn they do for others, or for every courtesy done for them, but Executives would be wise to have a general

sense of the balance of obligations in their relationships. When they tip too heavily in someone's favor, it might be time to re-adjust.

Accounting for Individual Differences

When Executives look at successful contemporary role models, or those from their past, they're often quick to discount any inherent advantages that may have contributed to their success. After all, if certain things aren't under their control – such as circumstances of birth and upbringing – then there's no use dwelling on them. However, if it becomes apparent that someone has accomplished much more than these types have, their beliefs in the power of persistence, and integrity trumping luck and duplicity, are tested.

It can be tempting for Executives to try to ignore the disproportionate success of the fortunate and the wicked alike, perhaps by pointing out their flaws in unrelated areas, or by imagining the dire consequences that can befall them as soon as their luck runs out – or their lack of character catches up with them. These approaches only fuel the envy that's so damaging to Executives' self-confidence. Instead of looking at others, they should pay more attention to what separates them from others – such as the satisfaction they get from applying the principles of hard work and fair play in their everyday lives. There's always someone who has more, whether acquired fairly or not, but mature Executives retain their self-confidence because it's predicated not on a belief in their own superiority, but in the knowledge that living according to their principles gives a life of satisfaction, even if success happens to elude them for the moment.

Self-Evolution

Self-evolution is the power that Executives possess to change as circumstances change around them. As much as they prize their steady, unswerving attitude toward life, they know that too much determination can lead to an unproductive rigidity. They may use tried-and-true methods, but they also continue to test them as time goes on, keeping only the ones that remain useful.

Balanced Self-Evolution

Strength through Continuity

The power of Executives comes from their mastery of tradition, and those whose self-evolution is balanced use this mastery of the past to solve the problems of the present. In looking at the past, they search for patterns of success, which they then seek to perpetuate into the future. The accumulated wisdom of the ages rests in the traditions that guide Executives' decisions, and those who balance their self-evolution respond to it as they would respond to the advice of older mentors: with a respectful ear, not blind obedience.

Conditions change, and sometimes methods must change with them. Executives have a broad view of tradition, seeing it as a living thing that, like themselves, grows, matures, and develops over time. They adjust, but they adjust for the better, and always with certain constants underpinning all they do.

Addition from Subtraction

While it's true that Executives prefer to use established methods, they continue to test them as time goes on, keeping only the ones that remain of use. If a method provides a suitable rate of return, then they use it unaltered. Even when a method

begins to fall apart, Executives prefer to change it as little as possible. Rather than throw out the entire rulebook, these types simply edit out the more troublesome rules.

By subtracting the weakest parts of a system, Executives add to its strength. But it's only by careful observation of where a system breaks down that they can determine where the weaknesses are. Executives know where to adjust, and what to leave unchanged.

Unbalanced Self-Evolution

The Challenge of Change

People with the Executive personality type view change with skepticism more than disdain. Tradition has the weight of iteration behind it – years, decades, or centuries of people who, repeatedly faced with similar problems, devised a method for solving them. Others could then successfully copy the method without alteration. Though changing circumstances may call for altered methods, Executives prefer to see the tested method fail before introducing an untested one, no matter how promising the latter might be. Indeed, even one failure may be written off as a failure of execution – human error – rather than a flaw in the method itself.

With balanced self-evolution, Executives can recognize the difference between a flawed method and a flawed execution. However, those with unbalanced self-evolution may simply repeat formerly successful behaviors, no matter how unsuccessful they now are.

Rebalancing Self-Evolution

Using Tradition as a Guide

Famed author W. Somerset Maugham once said, “Tradition is a guide and not a jailer.” This aphorism can serve as a powerful insight for Executives. Using it as a guide, they won’t diminish their respect for tradition, but they also won’t enslave themselves to it, either. Here are some steps these types can take toward rebalancing their traditional approach.

- Accepting the inevitability of change can be the first step.
- Learning to blend the old with the new can help these types create a more balanced view.
- Spotting the difference between maintaining stability and being stubborn can also help them better navigate a changing world.

Self-talk and self-examination, such as, “Am I offering helpful insights into how things work, or am I just finding change difficult to handle?” and similar questions may help.

Self-Care Supports Taking Care of Business

A well-maintained machine functions better than one that’s neglected, and Executives who take care of themselves are better at taking care of everything else. Self-care, then, isn’t an indulgence, but an investment – the time that they spend on family vacations or long coffee breaks isn’t wasted, but comes back to them in increasing dividends.

At times, these types can become so focused on fulfilling their obligations that they lose sight of the reasons that they do the things they do. Taking time to remind themselves of the inherent value of the things they cherish most – the communities

that they draw their strength from – can renew their resolve at the times that test them most, allowing them to act as the bold, resilient leaders they are.

Self-Responsibility

Executives' sense of responsibility derives from their need to honor their rational approach to tradition and accepted principles. Their personal sense of responsibility and obligation to society can't be entirely separated – they take care of themselves when they take care of the world. Fulfilling their sense of responsibility can help them achieve healthy self-esteem, self-respect, and self-confidence.

Balanced Self-Responsibility

Seeing Things Through

For these types, self-responsibility refers to the need to fulfill the obligations they've set for themselves. When Executives take on duties, their self-image becomes linked to their ability to see them through. While this principle is true of even small tasks – running an errand for a spouse, or picking up a friend at the airport – the overarching obligations that constitute their lives are what drive them from day to day. Whether at home or work, they seek security – and fulfilling obligations, for them, is an effort to cultivate it in their lives.

When they do their part to hold up their end of a deal, they gain assurance that others can feel compelled to do likewise. Those who can't be relied upon shouldn't expect to rely on others, either; this isn't only a watchful defense on Executives' part, but a proactive search for threats to squelch and opportunities to seize. These types aren't risk-averse, but risk-aware, and careful to ensure that any gambles they take are smart ones. They're willing to risk investments – of time, money, or feeling – if the

rewards are promising and the odds are weighted heavily in their favor. Executives don't like to lose, but they know that to win, they must play: nothing ventured, nothing gained.

Masters of Organization and Standards

Organization comes naturally to Executives. They know what to do and who to call to make things happen smoothly, and tend to have all-encompassing resources they become familiar with and achieve mastery over. This helps them organize efficiently. At home, at work, and as parents, they're likely to have just as much of a command of resources.

Their widespread attention to detail isn't for its own sake, as Executives connect it to responsibility and accountability. Life for them is often a series of rubrics, arranged and linked to provide an organized, consistent path.

The Value of Persistence

These types enjoy the gifts of patience and focus. Valiant in their ability to endure hardships, they sometimes take on more onerous tasks than necessary simply because they know they can do them and gain more than they lose, whether regarding character building or more concrete rewards. The most mundane work is no problem for Executives if they grasp its rational purpose, if it fits a paradigm they're familiar with, or if it's paired with a powerful sense of obligation.

Executives' persistence presents value in many ways. While they may not always find motivation from within, once engaged, they're finishers, and the idea of something left undone if they don't finish is a strong motivator. People with the Judging trait find

satisfaction in chapters that are completed and closed. Being persistent enough to finish a task reinforces their sense of reliability and, consequently, their self-esteem.

Unbalanced Self-Responsibility

Growth occurs when Executives use their sense of responsibility and dedication to move forward in life. However, as with all good things, diligence can shift from a powerful tool to a demanding tyrant if not properly balanced against other considerations.

Too Little Self-Care

Executives build their self-responsibility upon their successful execution of personal obligations and upholding established standards. When they aren't feeling great about themselves or their lives, their sense of responsibility may go into overdrive as they search for a more positive sense of themselves. Instead of integrating self-care and rest into their plans, they may feel an urgency to go in the opposite direction, pushing themselves – and others – relentlessly.

At such times, these types may forget the softer side of dealing with people, including themselves, the side where gentle coaxing is more effective than harsh mandates. Executives aren't always in touch with their feelings. Those who are too driven to accomplish a task may appear unreasonable to people with other priorities or methods.

Even Executives, who tend to be stalwart, become stressed when tension from their overbearing attitude breaks down the morale, willingness, and effectiveness of the very people they depend on most. Such breakdowns can start vicious cycles where they're disappointed in their performance, feel stressed about it, and then go deeper

into burnout. The personality type who always knows what to do can find itself without a solution.

Rebalancing Self-Responsibility

Making Realistic Assessments

Executives who find themselves suffering from taking on too much responsibility may need to assess who they are, what their duties are, and why they feel the need to push so hard. They also might want to decide if their relentless efforts are paying off or not. Working exceedingly hard may appear to be the right thing to do at times. But it can also exact a toll on individuals. Matching the cost to the benefit is essential.

These types typically choose action over ruminating over things. However, this go-to tactic may not be helpful when doing too much is the problem. Learning to prioritize activities that have proven to be important, and balancing them with downtime and relaxation, can make this tactic more responsible. Burnt-out shells of Executives are less effective than those who take the time to restore themselves. Asking, “Why?” instead of pursuing less considered action can help set clearer paths – especially when their need to feel responsible begins to “overheat” and results in an explosion of activity.

Managing Stress

Stress can be a good thing – like a heavy weight, the more it’s handled, the stronger handlers become. But the dangers of handling too much stress are much the same as the risks of lifting too much weight: snapping under the pressure. And though Executives are often adept at handling stress, they have their limits, too. Extraverted Executives might find that stress relief is often less about finding a peaceful place in

their lives as it is about getting frustrated energy out in healthy ways. Here are some ideas that can help.

- A night on the town with a few friends, or a pick-up ball game in the park, may be more effective than a quiet evening with a book or a lazy afternoon in a hammock – although of course, even Executives need rest sometimes.
- When they do need a more sedate outlet for stress relief, there are countless methods available, including deep breath meditation (in which someone sits still and focuses their entire, exclusive attention on the in and out of their breath), respectful life planning (in which busy Executives identify reasonable timelines and priorities, rather than pushing for what could be done, an unreasonable long-term strategy), or simply planning in some time to relax with family and friends, or even alone.
- Everyone needs a break, including busy Executives who see themselves as indispensable. True, they often find themselves – or more accurately, intentionally place themselves – in positions of extreme responsibility that aren't so easily abdicated. Then it becomes an additional responsibility for them to find people who can take over so that the responsibility doesn't always have to fall squarely on these types, who may not complain, but inevitably suffer under the burden.
- This is true as well for unforeseen circumstances – all it takes is one power outage or faulty engine part to keep even the most diligent Executives from fulfilling an obligation.

Learning to turn off their phones and laptops occasionally can help Executives exercise responsibility for themselves by setting aside their responsibility for everyone else. If they've delegated wisely, they should have no trouble leaving their

children in the care of capable babysitters, or their businesses in the care of capable administrators.

Conclusion

Reconciling the Heart with the Head

The emotional and rational sides of human nature are often presented as antagonistic to one another – if individuals are rational, then emotions only cloud their judgment. For Executives, who pride themselves on their discernment, emotions must be an obstacle – something to be considered, perhaps, but only in the sense that one must know an enemy to defeat it. Yet where do they get their motivation from, if not the feelings of pride, honor, or love that are reinforced when they act according to their principles, and are injured when they don't live up to their own self-image? Emotions, while messy and unpredictable, aren't enemies, but an integral part of human nature. Though Executives don't need to indulge in them, ignoring them – pretending that they don't exist, or are irrelevant – is just as foolish.

In some cases, these types might want to be more cognizant of their emotions as a safeguard against their irrationality – leaving decisions or otherwise delegating work to others, if the emotional stakes would be too high for Executives personally. For the same reasons that surgeons are typically forbidden from operating on their own family members and attorneys rarely represent themselves in court, Executives should look to their own biases to see situations where others might be more impartial, and more effective. (Having said this, though emotions can inhibit people, they can also free them, and motivate them to be better than they are.)

Finding the Self in the System

Executives thrive when they find effective systems to thrive within. However, systems have a way of swallowing up individual elements, and these types, more than most, may have trouble maintaining their identities under pressures to conform. After all, they feel little intrinsic pleasure in doing things “just to be different,” so in the absence of a compelling counterargument, Executives may find it easiest to go along with the crowd – at least superficially, until such a counterargument arises. On certain issues, they may stand their ground no matter what. But when it comes to something like disagreeing with a corporate dress code or homeowner association lawn care policies, Executives may see compliance as a smart compromise. Community standards may at times conflict with individual expression, but when the alternative is sheer anarchy, there really is no alternative at all.

Executives should nevertheless be prepared to fight, however, for “community standards” are at times only a thin veil for the personal prejudices of a small group of people rather than legitimate compromises done for group harmony and efficiency. When their self-determination is balanced, they have no problem complying with or even enforcing sound, logical rules – but they’re also able to see when a rule works, and when it doesn’t. Though they may have their own principled way of rebellion – resigning from a position rather than following an improper order, for example – Executives are under no obligation to champion rules or methods that don’t measure up to their personal standards.

Additional Tools and Tests

Want to dig even deeper into your personal growth? If you have access to the toolkits area of the website, we offer a variety of additional tools and tests to help you explore.

[Locus of Control Test](#)

Dig deeper into who or what you feel is responsible for your life satisfaction, happiness, and level of fulfillment.

[Emotional Intelligence Test](#)

Find out how good you are at understanding your own emotions as well as paying attention to the emotions of others with this test.

[Confidence Test](#)

How much do you believe in your competence and ability to successfully follow through on the choices you make? Let's find out.

[Dark and Light Side Test](#)

Your moral choices may not be as simple as you think. This test asks you to go deep and take an honest look at your attitudes.

[Resilience and Grit Test](#)

Some people are hard to knock down; some find it easy to get back up; and some are both or neither. Which group do you belong to?

Coping Styles Test

There are four primary ways to cope with crisis. This test explores the dominant and secondary techniques you're likely to turn to.

Optimism and Pessimism Test

This simple test measures your levels of both optimism and pessimism in a novel way. Find out where you fall in each of these areas.

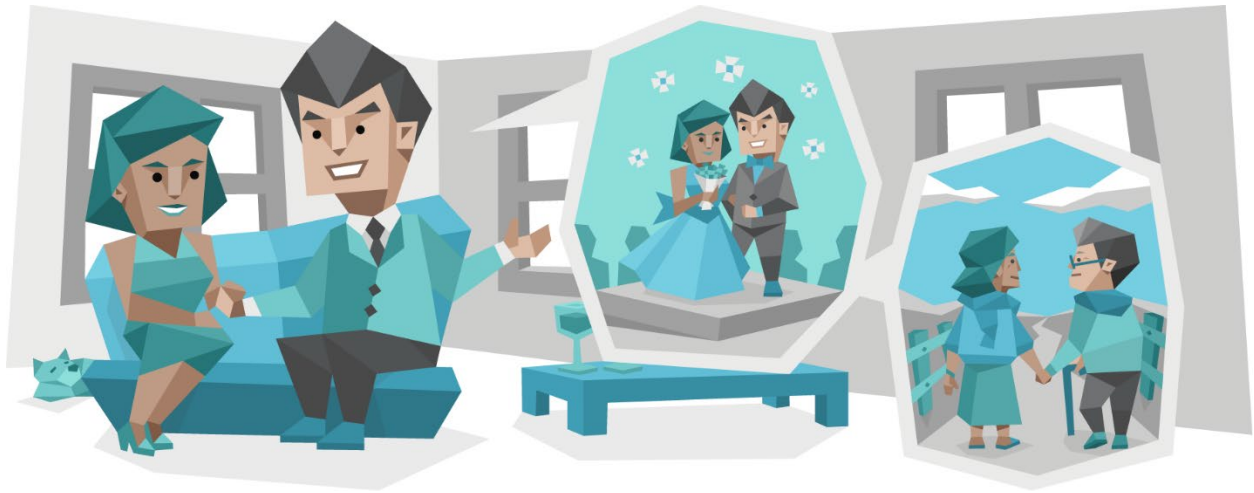
Imagination and Magic Beliefs Test

How does your imagination work? What is your belief about magic? Explore the role of imagination, magic, and belief in your life.

Traveling Preferences Test

This simple test delves into your preferred choices during those times when you leave home to explore the world.

Romantic Relationships



Productivity and perseverance are common personal objectives for Executives. Romantic partners who respect these goals are needed for these types to feel happy in relationships. For them, tradition and security enable love to grow, and they want longevity. They're unabashed about their exacting requirements when establishing such commitments, though, and finding someone to love is a deliberate process for them.

However, it would be a mistake to oversimplify Executives' rational natures as cold or unloving. Status is very important to these individuals, and finding love falls within their broad social ambitions. Executives want others they can trust and share emotional connections that are so difficult for them to master on their own. Though outgoing by nature, being deeply connected to others isn't easy for them. They find that loving relationships enhance their lives by fulfilling a fundamental human need they might struggle with.

Executives' love comes not merely from emotion, but from a desire for advancement. When these types meet others who attractively reflect their values, they see them as

components of more complete lives. They tend to be motivated and self-sufficient, but quickly find that lovers who complement them are major assets. Love brings a sense of stability that strengthens Executives' efforts in life – one way or another, having a partner moves these individuals forward.

They approach love confidently, and as a serious matter. While not fluent in subtle emotional understanding, they're dedicated once they commit. These types don't appreciate those they see as unreliable, but they welcome into their lives people who impress them. When someone also meets Executives' deeper criteria and enters their hearts – which isn't an easy thing – they gain special status among all others.

Once real partnerships form, Executives work hard to make them prosper. This doesn't mean such relationships are invulnerable. They can still succumb to the things that destroy couples, especially if these types can't find a way to be sensitive, honest with their deeper feelings, and compromise their strict views. However, romantic relationships are unlikely to crumble because Executives fail to apply enough effort.

Dating and the Single Executive

If someone attracts Executives romantically, it's usually because they've had time to appreciate that person's qualities. "Love at first sight" can happen, but they often form a romantic interest in deliberate ways. They aren't reluctant to socialize, and are quite enthusiastic about branching out and meeting new people. Executives rarely let physical attraction overcome their strict standards, but once others catch their eye, they're unreserved in their pursuit.

These types prefer traditional dating practices, typically finding potential romantic partners in places where they first become acquainted with them casually, such as

work, school, or meeting through mutual friends. Novelty isn't necessary – in fact, spontaneity may feel like a distraction to Executives when they're first getting to know someone. They strongly prefer planned activities where they can focus on a partner without a lot of surprises, and are usually the ones planning their dates.

Someone who is too spontaneous can disenchant Executives, who often interpret it as irresponsibility. These types are confident, but prefer structure and rules, and making emotional connections is hard enough for them without disorganization in the mix. Not everyone they date may embrace their strict codes, however, and Executives may repel or reject otherwise perfectly good romantic partners by judging this too harshly.

If they don't get past what they may initially see as someone's flaws, they miss the chance to know their admirable qualities, and a growing relationship might end. Astute Executives quickly realize that pushing themselves to be more open-minded keeps them in the prime waters of the dating pool. However, if the pursuit of a potential mate consistently takes them outside their preferences, Executives can lose patience. Once they decide against something, they're often quick to remove it from their lives.

Executives in the Bedroom

To put it in perhaps unromantic terms, Executives' natural drive to do a good job extends to sex, as they're goal-oriented and focused. Their performance is somewhere in their consciousness during physical intimacy, as well as a sense of responsibility to their partners. Having strict personal boundaries, these types aren't particularly sensitive or open-minded in the bedroom, but ideally, they want to please their partners.

Their firmly resolved nature can create conflict if their beloveds show an interest in experimenting, as many do to keep their sex lives fresh. Depending on their background, they may have narrow personal definitions of acceptable sexual behavior. If this is the case, being pressured to be experimental can provoke sharp refusal from Executives.

Despite being very outspoken, it's rarely easy for Executives to understand and express their deeper feelings or vulnerabilities. Learning to communicate honestly and unreservedly about sexual matters is essential for them, and a wise priority to address early in sexual relationships.

Taking Failure to Heart

Executives like steady, predictable advancement in life, and breakups are assaults on those goals. They go against everything Executives prefer in relationships, and feel like personal failures. These individuals assume they should be able to repair a troubled romance with a calculated solution and vigorous effort, but logic and energy aren't always enough. They get frustrated when their direct approach doesn't gain traction in subtle matters of the heart.

When these types think they see an end coming, they may terminate a romance preemptively with unapologetic swiftness. It may seem callous, but they prefer to save themselves – and their sweethearts – from protracted pain. If there was ever a “rip the bandage off” type, it's Executives. This is also an attempt to maintain control over their lives. Despite a sense of failure, they may judge it to be the best way to restore stability and progress. Even in love, their practical rationality wins out.

After breakups, Executives are wise to seek the company of friends and family. Social contact energizes them, and it helps remind them that a bad experience with one

person doesn't diminish their ability to connect with someone else. Executives are more emotionally detached than most types, and a breakup can push these individuals into unbalanced states of cynicism and selfishness. However, that same emotional detachment allows Executives to see experiences for what they were in a balanced way, and avoid irrationally painting future romances with past frustrations.

Potential Role Pairings

Bold and decisive, Executives love to create structure, but people aren't like puzzle pieces that fit together consistently, nor can they be forced into alignment. Executives can relax their vigorous, exacting approach a little when pursuing love. Healthy relationships aren't tasks to be accomplished, and other people generally don't like to be controlled.

The Right Approach

While romance is far from an exact science, Executive lovers understand that putting their best feet forward achieves the best results. With so many personality variables in play, this often means proceeding into the unknown with an open mind, knowing that while they can't control other people's behavior, maintaining a balanced, positive, and accepting attitude brings out the best in others.

The information presented here can help Executives build and navigate successful relationships. Knowledge of other personality tendencies enables Executives to do what they do best: decide and execute. These types excel at working toward success, and since true love is unlikely to be found in a perfect package, they must correspondingly work toward some flexibility of mind if they want to succeed.

With this in mind, we'll offer a helpful look at some of the ways Executives and other types are likely to interact, and insight to help them maximize their chances for happiness by creating fulfilling and balanced relationships with those types.

Executive–Analyst Relationships



Executives and Analysts both approach finding partners with some degree of calculation. On some level, most people employ a mental checklist when they meet potential romantic candidates, but for these types, those checklists are more deliberate and conscious. This systematic approach reflects their rational way of avoiding expected problems, and is helpful if not taken too far or relied on entirely.

Balanced Executive–Analyst Relationships

A Romantic Mental Checklist

Executives' checklist involves strict standards, personal traditions, and the desire to craft stable lives, while Analysts have extremely specific likes and dislikes based on their ideas and ideals. Neither are likely to be unsure of their preferences, and both approach relationships with a sense of mental negotiation. Honestly communicating

the “must-haves” on their respective checklists sets up foundations that increase their potential to build mutually satisfying love.

Effective Together

Although they might express it differently, both partner types in these couples appreciate efficiency and accomplishment. For Executives, it's real-world and practical – they like things hassle-free and secure, and have the energy to ensure these preferences. For Analysts, it concerns more theoretical ideas about progress and improvement. They enjoy finding innovative and unconventional procedures that wring the greatest benefit out of life, albeit it's sometimes complicated. If these lovers tap into each other's strengths, they make formidable couples.

Executives are impressed by Analysts' penchant for solving life's puzzles – if it's not overdone. They find Analysts' optimal solutions to be highly useful, and Executives appreciate little more than usefulness. In return, Analysts find a helpful dose of realism in Executives' cool, decisive rationality. The fact that they don't get lost in ideas stabilizes ever-imaginative Analysts, something especially needed by those with the Prospecting trait.

Both these types enjoy longevity in relationships. Executives want reliable partners that create a sense of continuity, and Analysts, ever logical, fulfill this need. In turn, Analysts find that having sensible, energetic Executive sweethearts as constants in their lives allows them to focus on bigger issues. These two types agree that drama and chaos aren't good uses of energy, and finding others to love who make sense to them is rare for both, so they treasure the accomplishment.

Unbalanced Executive–Analyst Relationships

Competing Priorities

When Executives want traditional approaches, and Analysts want to re-engineer everything, it can lead to frustration. Their sense of satisfaction comes from different things: Executives find satisfaction in being anchored and accomplishing specific goals, and Analysts find it in exploring ideas and working on ever-evolving projects.

Executives quickly lose patience with Analyst lovers always engaging myriad possibilities in an unbalanced manner. If Analysts insist on perpetually experimenting, or worse, spending time and energy on ideas that go nowhere, Executives become irritated. These types invest heavily in keeping their day-to-day lives in order, and individuals can easily become overly critical in an unbalanced way when Analysts lose themselves in ideas that seem irrelevant to daily life.

Unfortunately, Analysts are deeply hurt when Executives dismiss matters they care about. For Analysts, trying to master larger concepts is important, and having their inspiration marginalized is a serious affront. Analysts can argue for their ideas well beyond the balanced boundaries of logic, and being dismissed out of hand only inflames them further. Arguments of principle versus practicality can quickly get out of hand, causing serious damage to their relationships.

Active Minds, Closed Hearts

Both Executives and Analysts tend to live through rationality, and they very likely experience a “meeting of the minds” that draws them together initially. While this can lead to a spark of something deeper, both types often have difficulty establishing or maintaining emotional connections. Executives and Analysts can have unbalanced,

yet functional lives together – even sexual relationships – and yet markedly lack intimacy and emotional openness. Talking about their feelings might seem confusing or unimportant to types who prize logic, and Executives and Analysts may even see discussing feelings as some kind of admission of personal weakness.

In ongoing love affairs, this is likely to become a problem. Executives and Analysts have plenty of emotions, and when discomfort with those emotions prevents them from expressing their feelings, they can't effectively resolve unbalanced issues. The frustration that even healthy, loving people occasionally feel with each other quickly becomes dangerous when ignored or suppressed. Both types tend to focus on fixing apparent problems with a rational approach, leaving inner emotional issues continually festering.

A lack of emotional openness doesn't just harm Executive–Analyst couples' ability to work through problems – it tragically decreases some of the most rewarding things that loving couples can share together: warmth, reassurance, joy, childish excitement, tenderness, and physical affection. Such things are rarely foremost in either type's mind, but they appreciate them just the same. In unbalanced relationships, a lack of emphasis on these intimate behaviors diminishes the quality of life for these lovers, and gradually diminishes the spark between them as well.

Rebalancing Executive–Analyst Relationships

Respecting the Needs of the Moment and the Future

Executives can respectfully point out to their Analyst partners that constant exploring and experimenting not only bothers them, but it also consumes significant resources within their relationships such as time, attention, and personal energy. Analysts can remind themselves of their responsibility to manage their shared resources, even

intangible ones, in a way that's acceptable to both types. This means reigning in their imaginations now and then to focus on present needs in their lives. They can show respect for their Executive partners by turning some of their creative energy toward the major long-term advancement of their relationships, as well as new ideas.

In turn, Executives can practice giving Analysts some respectful latitude. Analysts can't be happy ignoring problems or ideas, and are compelled to innovate, sometimes learning much by creative failure. When Analysts demonstrate responsible contributions to their relationships, they also earn the right to put time and energy into their ideas and projects, no matter what anyone else thinks about the merits. However, just because wise Executives indulge Analysts' intellectual exercises, it doesn't mean they need to participate or hear about them constantly.

Cooperation, Together or Individually

These couples can agree to manage certain aspects of their shared lives independently. For example, forward-thinking and imaginative Analysts could take the lead in finding clever investments or shopping for deals on big purchases. Any area where new or changing information must be evaluated appeals to their ability to explore and optimize. In turn, Executives can organize and manage everyday matters like ensuring bills are paid on time, and their schedules are kept, assuring the stability of their shared lives.

These lovers may simply also have to compromise at times. These types are smart to model their differing perspectives not as arguments, but as rational proposals. Whether pushing for change or tradition, each must prove the benefits of their method to the other. It logically follows that each type must also stay open to the other's ideas. Writing out benefits and costs can help Executive-Analyst couples

discuss compromises reasonably. Rather than wasting time endlessly debating, a little hands-on demonstration with an open mind can also efficiently help them decide what works best.

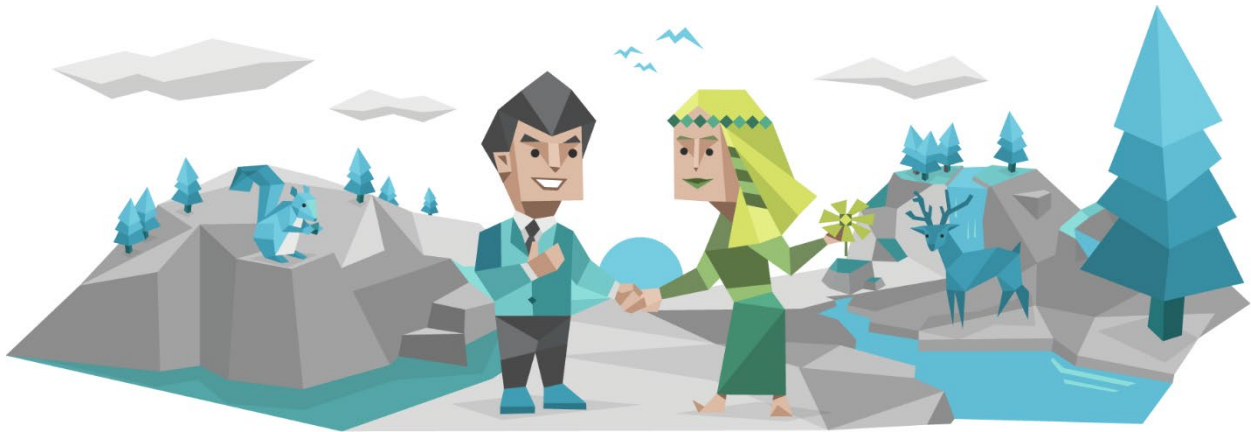
Keeping the Spark Alive

Emotional honesty is often hard for Executives, who want to simply force life to cooperate without a lot of introspection. Emotional candor may feel like weakness to them, as if exposing any vulnerability invites chaos. Analysts are similarly reluctant, relatively ignorant about their inner emotions or those of others despite their active imaginations. However, Executives and Analysts seeking to rebalance a lack of intimacy must be open about their needs and feelings. This can start simply enough with sharing their emotional states with their partners on a regular basis. Instead of just discussing facts, partners can make a point of saying how they feel. Here are some ways these couples can broach the subject.

- Saying, “I feel angry at what was just said,” is a fair way to give partners an opportunity to make immediate amends before problems deepen.
- Or, if one arrives home from work stressed and frustrated, they can say so, and their partner can offer support: “You do sound frustrated, want to talk about it?”
- These types naturally fall into problem-solving together, but making a conscious effort to also take care of each other on an emotional level helps keep their sense of intimacy alive.
- Resolving issues with each other is important, but it’s just as critical for these types to share positive emotions and experiences with each other. When one is feeling happy or appreciative of the other, it’s important to take the time to express it clearly.

- Improving intimacy isn't just about supporting each other through challenges, it's also about sharing pleasurable, easy, and satisfying moments in life together. Whether it's cooking a special meal on a Friday night, celebrating a professional triumph, or sharing a cozy massage, participating in the sweeter parts of life alongside each other affirms strong, loving relationships. For Executives and Analysts alike, it may take some conscious effort to focus on these sentimental intangibles, but the gains are tremendous.

Executive-Diplomat Relationships



Executives and Diplomats aren't always easy romantic pairings, but while having a great many differences, they share the ideal of dedication to the ones they love. Diplomats feel their loved ones' emotional states as if they were their own, wanting to support their partners' growth and happiness. Executives stride forward in life, seeking to create a secure, prosperous environment for themselves and those they love. Even though they develop their standards in different ways, both strive to be instrumental in creating harmony.

Balanced Executive-Diplomat Relationships

Dedicated Couples

While Executives may not be overt with their feelings, they can give Diplomats the steady support they need make functional progress. When Diplomats get lost in their imagination or worry about what might happen, Executives pull them back to the good things that already exist between them.

In return, Diplomats remind Executives that they can be loved for themselves, and not just what they accomplish. Executives put a lot of pressure on themselves to succeed and be recognized. Diplomats recognize them for who they are, putting the well-being and happiness of their sweethearts above any material successes. To Diplomats, the strengths and virtues of Executives' character are just as worthy of praise as their accomplishments. This might seem revolutionary to these practical types, but it feels wonderful. Executives derive deep security from the fact that they needn't be always perfect to receive the warm devotion of their Diplomat lovers.

Dreams and Reality in Balance

Executives' emphasis on practical accomplishment is the perfect supplement to Diplomats' focus on intangible development. Diplomats are inspired dreamers, and Executives offer a pragmatic hand that counterbalances their airy ideas. Where Diplomats might avoid life's mundane details in favor of dreams, Executives help them power through everyday responsibilities. Ultimately, Diplomats find this helps make their dreams a reality, and love their Executive partners even more for helping them grow.

Diplomats, in turn, try to help Executives grow beyond mundane routine. Executives are highly goal-oriented, but the ambitiousness of those goals can be limited by their focus on convention. Diplomats lovingly show them an expanded view of their potential, inspiring Executives to new levels of success. Where Executives might revel in achieving a high management position, Diplomats might ask, “Why not start your own company, babe?” Through the supportive, idealistic love of Diplomats, Executives discover exciting goals that they might not conceive on their own, yet are within their reach.

Strong, Distinct Values

While they may arrive at their values very differently, these are both values-based types. Executives settle on strict, tradition-oriented values through experience and logic. Diplomats form values through philosophical exploration and a deep empathetic connection to all life. Executive–Diplomat couples respect that they both embrace balanced personal codes because they truly believe they’re the best way to live their lives.

These couples can refine and update each other’s values. Executives may be so focused on personal achievement that they fail to consider the advantages of integration, dismissing anyone who doesn’t share their exact values. Diplomats are all about universal harmony, though, and can help Executives develop their personal status in balanced ways that connect to progressive, diverse, modern values – more open doors mean more opportunities to advance.

On the flip side, Diplomats focus so broadly on moral and idealistic values that their own lives often suffer. Executive lovers remind Diplomats that achieving great things for themselves builds a strong foundation to express their dreams for the world.

Prosperity and personal power aren't sins against humanity, and Executives' values empower Diplomats beautifully. When these types each take a page from the other's book of values, they're better off for it. Executives who are connected to their humanity easily achieve noble status, and Diplomats with the tools to focus and bring their ideas into reality are a benefit to the world.

Unbalanced Executive–Diplomat Relationships

The Practical Clashes with the Ideal

Executives and Diplomats loving each other is a wonderful thing, but these partnerships don't always unfold in balance. At first, Executives find that Diplomats' focus on ideals appeals to their sense of rightness – they honor their tradition-based values just as strongly. However, once the novelty wears off, they may wonder how practical Diplomats are, and if they can turn talk into results. Diplomats, meanwhile, may begin to feel that Executives lack imagination, and wonder how such partners can truly understand what matters to them.

Executives want their sweethearts to become more grounded with time, as achieving stable and prosperous lives together is always on their minds. However, Diplomats often embrace continuous change rather than settling down. Their grand visions for the future can seem to belittle the more realistic goals Executives work so hard for, baffling these determined, practical types. For Executives, everything worthwhile happens because someone dutifully follows a planned course of action, something easily lost to Diplomats' focus on things like politics, social justice, or personal creativity. Often struggling to follow through on their big ideas, Diplomats can just as easily forget to buy milk on the way home. Executives can be unforgiving of this kind of failure, even in minor matters.

Executives are unlikely to see Diplomats' grand-scale worries and dreams as pertinent to their shared welfare. They perhaps can even see them as risks. These types tend to be realistic about their concerns, and after a cursory appreciation of Diplomats' perspective, they may reject all the "what ifs" as an inefficient waste of time and energy – nothing realistically actionable. Diplomats can be hurt by this curt appraisal, often considering their open-ended thinking loftily superior, and may allow this pain to deepen into unbalanced contempt for partners who "don't get" their high-mindedness.

When Emotions Confuse

Diplomats are far freer with their emotions than Executives, who prefer to control or even hide their feelings. They may be in similar emotional states, but their styles and degrees of expression are quite distinct. Diplomats' freer feelings are often quite confusing and troubling for Executives, who almost always prefer controlled steadiness over openly expressed emotions. Likewise, Diplomats are confused by Executives' unbalanced refusal to emote, often worrying that it's somehow a reflection on them. Consequently, Diplomats may try to force Executives' feelings out, becoming even more upset if they can't. Executives' responses are likely to be something unbalanced and unsympathetically practical along the lines of, "Get over it."

Executives don't enjoy exposure to strong emotions, even by someone they love. They may regard too much emotion – even their own – as weakness or self-indulgence, and may respond in an unbalanced, callous way. Even worse, if emotional pressure continues unchecked, it can begin to feel like a threat to the stability of their lives. They may create distance as a form of self-defense, and Diplomats sense this with dismay, further widening the gap. This is absolute poison

to loving relationships, so bringing emotional communication into balance is of critical importance for these couples.

Rebalancing Executive–Diplomat Relationships

Open-Minded Dedication

Executives aren't known for open-mindedly embracing change. Similarly, Diplomats frequently ignore facts that contradict their ideals. For such couples, it goes beyond, "We should do this," versus "We should do that." Balance starts with respectful compromise, but also includes being truly open to each other's points of view. Appreciating that contributions to their relationships need not be similar to be valuable requires both these types to loosen their strict priorities and consider each other's very different needs and virtues.

What this looks like on a day-to-day basis is asking how they can support each other, expressing their needs honestly, and making a sincere effort to do whatever it takes to make their time together happy, yet functional. In specific terms, Executives must patiently acknowledge that Diplomats have a right to their less tangible concerns and interests, even if they seem wildly impractical. If there's one thing that Executives understand, it's the transactional nature of achievement, and achieving fair and mutually fulfilling romantic relationships requires that they invest hard work, just like any worthy goal. Here are some tips these couples can take to heart.

- Whether it means attending a political rally, taking a painting class, or learning to meditate, Executives can understand that sincerely engaging in things outside their norm are ways to make fair contributions to happy lives together with Diplomats.

- These practical types may also be surprised to find their interests expanded – everything they love was also new to them at one point, and Executives are rarely shy about engaging opportunities.
- If they can't find any enjoyment in one thing, they can try something else, as it's the effort and openness that Diplomats appreciate.

In turn, Diplomats can understand the limits of their Executive partners: they can only handle so much novelty and mystical openness without rolling their eyes.

Respecting Everyday Goals

In balanced relationships, Executives' need for order, practicality, and advancement in life aren't only respected, they're supported. This requires Diplomats to sometimes focus their energy on mundane goals and methods instead of grand ideals. If they're not always taking an equal role in day-to-day responsibilities, Diplomats can at least allow Executives to handle those things their own way. Diplomats can be grateful to have lovers as rational, decisive, and dauntless as Executives planning workable paths forward for their lives together.

Some days, instead of trying to push Executives to do something fun and inspired, Diplomats can roll up their sleeves and join their partners in the routine trenches of everyday life. This might mean mowing the lawn, deciding on a new investment, or simply providing Executives with lunch and support while they figure things out. Working hard on the practical priorities of the moment is a challenge for Diplomats, but love for their sweethearts gives them a reason to try. A stable foundation and progressive direction are both possible when these couples balance their time, thoughts, and energy between ideal possibilities and current responsibilities. It's not easy, but the results of such balance are stunning.

Emotion and Logic in Proportion

Glorious potentials aside, reconciling Executive-Diplomat couples' respective tendencies to function through either logic or emotion is an ongoing challenge. It's critical that each type recalibrate their expectations of the other – frustration happens when expectations are out of touch with reality. Executives get out of touch by having unforgivingly strict standards, and Diplomats by having hopelessly imaginative ideals. However, Executives can't reasonably expect Diplomat partners to be coolly sensible all the time, nor can Diplomats reasonably expect constant emotional sensitivity from Executives.

With realistic expectations in mind, these partners can respect each other's unique ways of expressing themselves. Executives rarely give Diplomats the lush, emotional feedback they crave, but they express their love and commitment through sincere dedication and tireless effort. Diplomats can appreciate the way their Executive partners enhance their shared lives with prosperity and security.

In turn, Executives understand that loving relationships include profound and honest emotional connections. Diplomats can encourage them toward further openness by ensuring that sharing emotions is a non-volatile experience. Both these types grow as individuals and build stronger relationships by imitating qualities of the other. Executives can work to explore and share their own emotions, and Diplomats can practice judicious self-control of emotion.

In everyday terms, Executives can make themselves talk about what they feel, and Diplomats can pause to really think before sharing. Both types can also take a hard look together at the chain of events that led to any emotional issues between them. Talking it through step by step gives them a chance to spot false assumptions, explain

themselves, and clear the air of overreaction. Making efforts to bridge each other's level of emotionality doesn't mean sacrificing their unique natures, but it allows these types to come together with true understanding and honesty.

Executive–Sentinel Relationships



Couples sharing many core traits have an easier time understanding each other, so these pairings are often comfortable matches. Relationships between Executives and other Sentinels thrive on their sense of duty, commitment, and mutual constancy. While the specifics may differ, each understands the other's desire to build useful foundations and maintain the traditions that define their worlds. They both appreciate a clear path forward, and try to proceed sensibly and smoothly without complicating things. Diligence might be the first quality they notice and admire about each other, beyond initial physical attraction.

Balanced Executive–Sentinel Relationships

Consistency

From the moment they decide to commit, things are quite serious between Executives and other Sentinels in love. Both types feel a strong pull toward stabilizing

things. They both like to focus on building better, more secure lives, and having significant others with the same goals satisfyingly reinforces their momentum. When they feel sure of their lovers being “the one,” plans are made in clear terms and engaged briskly. When two Sentinel types merge, genuinely responsible mutual caretaking can develop that’s unsurpassed by other personality types.

Sharing a Down-to-Earth Approach

Executives love Sentinels for their hands-on practicality. Together, they embrace established wisdom and understanding rather than conjured theoretical musings. That’s not to say their relationships are devoid of imagination, but they find that putting their energy into practical matters and proven methods tends to be more productive. Their sensible attention to immediate needs assures them that their lives can improve steadily. When they dream of a better future, it usually happens, as they embrace reasonable, achievable goals.

Unlike those who feel rewarded by dreaming itself, these couples feel a sense of purposeful satisfaction when they accomplish practical goals for themselves. They may have differing ways of engaging the world, but their respective approaches lead to the same destination. These couples work well together from an early stage, with Executives contributing a vigorous, logical sensibility and Sentinels adding their own unique forms of prudence and perseverance. They have little trouble seeing each other’s functional virtues, so fairness and cooperation are likely within these love affairs.

Comfort with Differences

Because Executives and other Sentinels share some key ways of approaching life, balancing other trait differences is also more approachable. For example, Executives

in love with Consuls can comfortably enjoy the warmer side of social experiences. Their partners' energy and boldness match their own, but with added levels of empathy and charisma right at the surface.

Romances with Consuls or Defenders give Executives chances to connect through emotions while respecting their focus on convention. Where Diplomats might try to pull them too far afield, these Sentinels draw them close into reassuring, loving nests, with Defenders especially placing great importance on their private lives as couples. Within the personal traditions they build with these types, Executives find it easy to open their hearts, relax their logic, and grow in balanced ways.

When paired with Logistician partners, Executives may begin to see the virtues of reserved contemplation versus swift action. While both types tend to be logical and sensible, Logisticians place even more value on carefully making the right decision, and aren't afraid to take the time to do so. Their caution is a good balancing element for Executives' often brash, forceful manner when confronted by life's challenges.

Unbalanced Executive–Sentinel Relationships

Too Much of a Good Thing

When individuals with similar traits fall in love, such combinations can also result in too much of a good thing. Even tradition-bound Sentinels pass through stages of change, and may become bored or frustrated with the very routines that once made them happy. There's a difference between satisfaction and joy, and these types may become so focused on stability that joy drains from their lives, leaving only predictable routines in its place.

Not only may these couples find that satisfaction alone eventually becomes insufficient, but the danger is even worse if both Executives and other Sentinel lovers don't share the sense of stagnation. When one type questions the direction or quality of their life and begins to desire change, and the other doesn't, it can feel like an abandonment of everything they've built together. Judgmental and bold, Executives may be especially unforgiving in unbalanced relationships, regardless of which side they're on. They don't take kindly to those who threaten the desired course of their lives, and if their partners push too strongly for change or try to hold them in unhappy routines, Executives can forcefully resist in unbalanced ways.

Missed Opportunities

Even if they never disagree on aspects of their lives together, such couples may become insulated inside the worlds they know. Executive–Sentinel couples in unbalanced relationships don't pay much attention to anything outside of those spaces, possibly ignoring highly beneficial opportunities that seem too risky. When they reinforce each other's reliance on the status quo, these significant others never discover their options, much less reach out to them. Executives are far from immune – while they don't hesitate to surge toward their goals, those goals often show a lack of broader vision. All their energy and willpower doesn't guarantee awareness or acceptance of new potentials, especially if their Sentinel partners are also focused only on what's already known.

Personal growth, success, and prosperity almost always entail a measure of risk. However, Executive–Sentinel partners in unbalanced relationships support each other's security rather than growth. Trying new paths may seem pointless when a perfectly good situation already exists – especially one they worked so hard to create together. If these types reassure each other that change isn't needed, they hold each

other back. Worse, they may dislike change so much that they deliberately ignore circumstances that desperately need improvement.

Certainty, or Tyranny?

The Judging trait inevitably contains a degree of certainty, an intrinsic way of thinking for both partners in Executive–Sentinel relationships. However, this in no way assures common preferences between the pair – one may like chocolate, the other, vanilla. The only thing they may agree on is wanting it their own way. Once Executives decide something is correct, they expect to move forward with it, and their blustery, autonomous decision-making can rankle their lovers.

Executives can be too pushy, but it may not occur to either of these types to ask their partners before making “obvious” choices if they’re sure they’re proceeding correctly. Such unbalanced high-handedness, even with the best of intentions, can be very damaging to their Sentinel lovers’ sense of worth. Controlling behavior is truly the dark side of willfulness, and is the opposite of the practical compromise that all Sentinels embrace in balanced relationships. When one type dominantly overshadows decisions, long-term happiness can’t prosper because freedom isn’t shared.

Rebalancing Executive–Sentinel Relationships

Venturing into Something New Together

Individuals in balanced relationships undertake necessary adaptive behavior to get through life successfully. In this spirit, Executive–Sentinel couples can shake things up occasionally to find new opportunities and joy. Improvement is, by definition, a type of change, and must be sought consciously. A foray outside their routines is the

first step to their achieving greater prosperity, strength, and happiness within their relationships. Fortunately, once these determined types engage something together, that decision alone provides shared motivation, as neither type commits lightly or gives up easily.

The key is in agreeing together to make an ongoing effort to expand. Emphasizing accepting new things into their lives cures notable flaws in these romances, such as stagnation and narrow vision. Partners in Executive–Sentinel couples might periodically ask themselves, “How can I improve my life?” and then ask their lovers to join them in testing the waters, be it trying a new restaurant, taking academic or recreational classes, or even researching and planning major things like a new career. Contemplating and engaging changes together takes much of the trepidation out of the experience, as these partners have each other’s reliable support.

Compromise is Necessary

The Judging trait, with all its certitude, doesn’t have to serve as a lock on the mind. When it does, however, the heart provides the key. When these couples disagree, they must remind themselves of the deep appreciation they feel for each other’s presence in their lives. The love they share motivates compromise. Fairly supporting each other’s preferences doesn’t require either type to change their own, just that they trade off supporting what the other prefers, some of the time. The following are some things these couples can keep in mind.

- Executives can make a special effort to support their Sentinel partners’ needs and desires. They almost reflexively enforce their own views and methods, and while this may sometimes enhance practical aspects of life, it has no place when it comes to matters of personal preference.

- No matter how certain Executives are that pumpkin is the proper type of pie at the holidays, their partners' tastes deserve respectful inclusion, not dismissal. To do any less is to say their partners aren't equally worthy, and won't allow balanced relationships to prosper.

Always with an eye on their chosen goal, Executives place the success of their romances above differences within their balanced relationships, and give as much as they get.

Executive-Explorer Relationships



Executive-Explorer couples are frequently an odd combination, but such pairings can be quite serviceable for both. As Observant types, both tend to be hands-on and present-minded, but in different ways. Executives manage matters at hand responsibly to assure long-term success, living in the present but planning for a stable future. They consider consequences and then act decisively. Contrarily, Explorers regard every moment as an opportunity for immediate satisfaction or accomplishment, and future concerns aren't as important to them. This allows them to be flexible, and they're often able to get around restrictions to achieve their goals. This is helpful, as those goals are likely to change often.

Balanced Executive–Explorer Relationships

Opposites Do Attract

Opposites do attract. In fact, being vastly different can generate wonderful relationships because it offers balance. Attraction between Executives and Explorers sometimes happens because wise Executives realize they could use some unconventional inspiration to help them meet their goals. Explorers bring plenty of that, often spontaneously attacking and completing tasks that interest them. Executives find such fresh, effective productivity very attractive, indeed, and can jump in with Explorers, bringing their own energy to the party. On the other hand, when Explorers tire of the practical difficulties of living spontaneously, Executives may seem like a very appealing stabilizing element. Executives offer support that keeps Explorers' lives functioning, which ultimately enhances their ability to explore.

Completing Each Other

Executives tend to create a secure space for themselves that's tightly defined and all about functional and efficient order. Being alone in that safe, stable world can make their lives dull, though. Adding Explorers to their lives is a way of creating unexpected opportunities that cure dull routines. Explorers bring options aplenty, and Executives can maintain their energetic common sense while gathering knowledge through diverse hands-on experiences with these lively lovers.

When Executives and Explorers combine their lives, it can result in very real and satisfying unions. There may be some utilitarian symmetry in such relationships, but these types can learn a lot from each other. They can each give essential, but very different, kinds of support that help them both mature and grow. In balanced

romances, Explorers' curiosity amends their partners' rigidity, and Executives' judiciousness tempers their sweethearts' exuberance.

How Executives find rewarding relationships with Explorers varies as much as Explorers themselves. Adventurers and Entertainers offer attentive sensitivity, with the former always conceiving new ways that these couples can engage life together, and the latter offering active social lives that appeal to Executives' ambition.

Being capable and attaining goals is something Executives respect, and Virtuosos' focus on mastering specific areas of skill is just such a quality. Likewise, the gainful effectiveness of Executive–Entrepreneur couples is amazing; they might build empires for themselves. If Executive–Explorer couples regard their differences as beneficial counter-balancing assets and maintain a healthy degree of tolerance, they can create outstanding bonds and much success together.

Unbalanced Executive–Explorer Relationships

Roles that Grow Old

Differences can bring about balance, but Executives and Explorers can also easily fall into roles with each other that become so distinct and repetitious that they create separation instead of unity. Executives tend to take on roles of organizing, planning, and meeting obligations, and Explorers are likely to be the more unrestrained, fun-loving members of these duos. These roles can work well when each feels the benefits of the other's approach, but quickly grow tiresome and oppressive if taken too far.

If these couples aren't careful, their relationships might start to resemble that of parents and children. It's burdensome for Executives to take all the responsibility

while Explorers enjoy a carefree existence, and Explorers resent being controlled by rules they don't understand the need for. Executives aren't likely to be patient with this imbalance for long, so these patterns can become severely problematic if unaddressed.

Stability and Spontaneity in Conflict

Executives are usually deliberately set in their ways, while Explorers adapt their opinions or interests easily. This arrangement can easily frustrate Executives' need for a sense of reliability in their partners. In turn, Explorers may see their beloveds' unwillingness to change as a hindrance to their free expression. Explorers are independent and have a great deal of difficulty with commitments that they find confining. They rankle at rules and direction, two fundamental things to Executives' way of thinking.

In contrast, rules help make Executives comfortable, and in their relationships, they're likely to insist on defining commitment early on. Unfortunately, Explorers' independence often makes them resist signing on to a committed lifestyle, at least right away. They can demonstrate great longevity in love, but not if stressed with too many strict demands, as that kind of pressure just pushes them away. If one type seeks commitment while the other yearns for freedom, the early stages of any romance proceeds with great difficulty.

Rebalancing Executive–Explorer Relationships

Respectful Communication

The key to balancing tiresome relationship roles is viewing the issue as a matter of respect. Executives can respect themselves enough to reject the burden of being

solely responsible in their households. If they're playing the "parents" too often, it's time for a talk – again, with respect playing a starring role. There's nothing wrong with saying, "I'm super stressed and busy, can you do a load of laundry to help me out?" When Explorers expand their participation in responsibilities, they can also create freedom for themselves, as balanced contributions create a solid sense of being equals.

Respect goes both ways in balanced relationships. Executives can remember that they fell in love with someone who has a higher tolerance for disorder and a lower tolerance for mundane activity. When the dishes need doing, Explorers' attention may be elsewhere, but finding ways to make such mundane things more exciting helps these couples get them done together. A little music and wine can sweeten a household chore into a more pleasant shared experience. In loving relationships, nobody should confuse encouraging more responsibility with demanding it, but both types must participate.

Benefitting From Each Other's Ways

Compromise is crucial to finding a workable way past differences, and drawing lines that are too firm is counterproductive. Below are some tips these twosomes can try.

- Explorers' flexible mindset can be a useful inspiration in this area. When Executives borrow just a little of their partners' open-minded outlook while relying on their natural ability to organize practically, solutions that make sense to both quickly appear.
- Rather than trying to push Explorers uncomfortably into detailed planning, Executives can reveal each part of a plan in sequence, allowing Explorers to

focus more easily on what's in front of them. This also creates a sense of spontaneity that helps Explorers engage naturally.

- Likewise, when Explorers realize they need to step up their contributions to the functional parts of their relationships, they can borrow their Executive lovers' dutiful mindset.

However, the good news for Explorers is that they needn't force themselves into the rigid, organized way of thinking natural to Executives – their partners already have a firm enough sense of priorities and responsibilities. All they need to do is willingly bring their natural energy, adaptable minds, and capable hands to the party. Chances are, Executives can provide some productive, sensible ideas of where Explorers can put these great virtues to excellent use.

Conclusion

Embracing Possibilities

While they tend to be highly effective people on their own, relationships present Executives with wonderful opportunities to grow. Normally, these types feel little pull to open their mind to unplanned change, but love can give them powerful motivation to advance beyond their limits and habits. Partners in balanced relationships don't expect this to happen overnight, but for their part, Executives can push themselves out of a rut, appreciating inspiration and guidance from romantic partners they love and trust.

Executives who give themselves permission to intimately embrace their lovers' differences are likely to find more joy than they have ever experienced. All they need is a willingness to relax and be open – they can maintain their common sense and

drive. Releasing themselves from certain routines may be a little destabilizing at first, but the rewards are tremendous. Executives find their worlds brightened and their minds inspired by loving people with different perspectives.

These types seek to create trust, stability, and successful living – and they're willing to share. While this kind of firm foundation isn't always sought by every type, it's a pleasant surprise when it's discovered. Executives offer lovers support and security that allow them to reach higher and do more than they could on their own. When initial chemistry is followed up by ongoing tolerance and honesty, there's no reason why Executives can't enjoy lasting and balanced love with any personality type.

Additional Tools and Tests

Want to dig even deeper into your romantic relationships? If you have access to the toolkits area of the website, we offer a variety of additional tools and tests to help you explore.

[Get to Know Your Partner](#)

Would you like to get to know your partner a little better? Try this simple, but very fun and effective, game.

[Couple Analysis](#)

A great tool for couples. Learn how your personalities are likely to interact, and how you can connect on an even deeper level.

[Type Guesser \(Romance\)](#)

Are you trying to figure out what personality type your partner belongs to? You may find that this simple tool helps.

[Romantic Fulfillment Test](#)

Grasp the roles that confidence and optimism play in your relationships, as well as what makes someone a good match for you.

[Intertype Test](#)

Do you have a partner? Do you want to understand your relationship better? Learn more about it with our easy Intertype Test.

Loyalty Test

With this test, you will find out how you build relationships and loyalty in four major areas: Romance, Work, Friendships, and Family.

Friendships



Earning Executives' friendship isn't quick or easy – people with this personality type are vigorously exacting, and prefer to connect through standard practices and values more than ideas and feelings. Most of their friends are made not through random encounters, but through consistent contact, such as in class or in the workplace, where they've got the time to get to know and admire each other. These types like to see people's merits proven before granting them their friendship.

High Standards

What makes Executives' friendships grow is the mutual respect and trust that comrades give each other. Functionality and stability are paramount to these types, and friends who reflect these qualities are valuable assets in their lives. They rarely find the orderly predictability they seek in other people, so they especially appreciate friends who are reliable. Executives crave a world where people are responsible, trustworthy, and capable – friendships that offer these values satisfy them deeply.

Comfortable with Detachment

Executives give an energetic form of friendship that revolves around shared commonality, but not much emotional intimacy. They take a brisk, no-nonsense approach to life, and aren't given to social softness or warmth. Trusted friends are useful bridges in this area, showing people with this personality type the direct value of deeper human connection. Through friendship, Executives balance their somewhat brusque outlook with the practical benefits of having good people around.

While they tend to be socially outgoing, these types don't need friendship to feel secure. Executives find people's overt emotions tedious, often disdaining sensitive or inconsistent people, and they're quite comfortable on their own. So, when they do find others who seem worthy, the favor they grant in the form of friendship is significant. If these people disappoint, however, Executives become dismissive – they don't easily give second chances.

Strong as Stone

An uncompromising nature is just one side of the Executive social coin, as their resolute core also provides them with appealing fortitude and energy. They're always ready to use their tireless diligence and intelligence to help their true friends come up with thoughtful solutions. Vigorous, practical, and principled, Executives make excellent friends, if their camaraderie can be won in the first place.

Where Executives' rigidity can hold them back socially is their unwillingness to try new things. They aren't easily intimidated, but also aren't easily impressed or enthused by unproven possibilities. However, Executives do step outside their boundaries if given a substantial reason, and good friends draw them into new things

by demonstrating the benefits. When these types deem others worthy as friends, they also value their judgement, and this opens them up to sampling the unknown.

Commonality and Community

Executives' desire for stability and status is reflected by their social choices, as they like being around those who respect their values and culture. Friendships are likely to flourish in environments that reflect what they've decided on through their own experiences. Of course, what's compatible depends on their personal history as individuals – the only sure thing that they're very specific about is their beliefs.

Executives are socially outgoing in whatever community feels like home, but rarely feel pulled to explore other ways of life. But those seeking to diversify their friendships wisely look for groups formed around common subjects and pursuits, from gardening to gaming to sports. This is an easy way for these types to get to know and better understand people with different views and backgrounds. Sharing an interest means agreeing on at least that one thing.

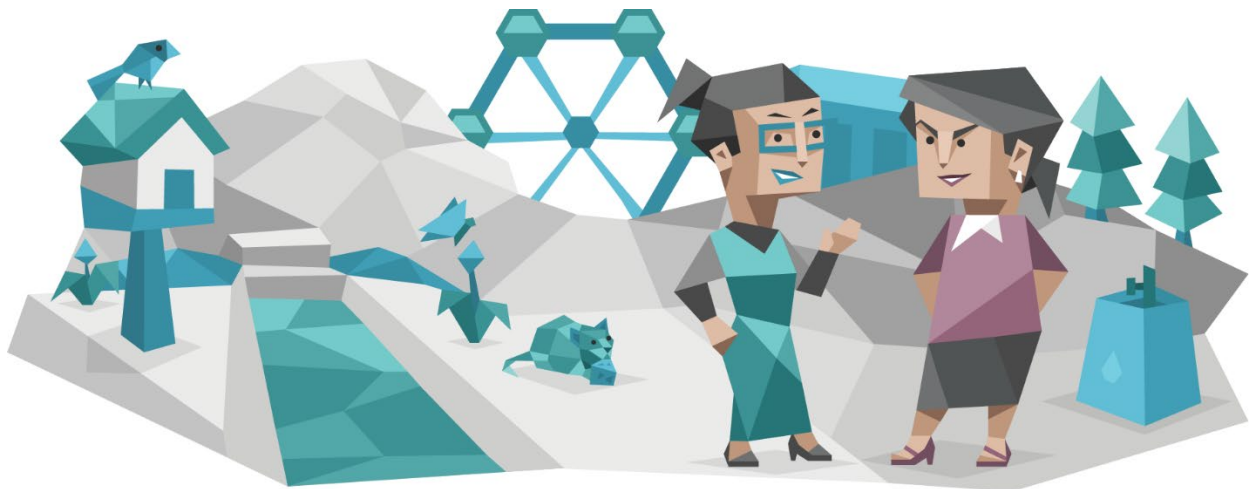
Pleasant Surprises

Executives' exceedingly specific social preferences don't prevent them from building friendships with very different types of people – those people just need to impress them consistently. If there's one thing Executives appreciate, it's finding others who are reliable and capable. These types can't help but respect extremely effective individuals, regardless of how they operate, and it's even better if they also prove to be personally trustworthy.

Executives and Friends of Other Types

Executives can enjoy friendship with almost anyone who meets such essential standards. We'll look at some of the virtues that these types can share with each Role group through friendship, as well as some areas of potential difficulty. Most importantly, we'll also go over some helpful things Executives can do to make friendships work with other personality types.

Executive–Analyst Friendships



Executive–Analyst friendships form easily, as these types have a lot in common. However, the headstrong, often confrontational nature of Commanders and Debaters can challenge Executives' patience. Luckily, Executives are bold enough to match the energetic willpower of these types, and can firmly offer some sensible advice when they get too carried away. These Analysts, in turn, respect Executives' strength of character and admire their steady, level-headed ability. When Executives befriend them, they, in turn, gain gutsy, creative allies to help them overcome life's toughest problems, making for nearly unlimited possible success.

Balanced Executive–Analyst Friendships

Support and Assistance

Not all Analyst friends are so challenging to be around, though. Executives appreciate Logicians' and Architects' quiet, thoughtful natures. They see how these types take the time to figure out ingenious solutions and find their input helpful on nearly everything. It may not always be easy to understand their curious musings, but their calculated ideas appeal to Executives' sense of logic. Analysts' ingenuity bolsters their ideas, and in return, they offer such friends practical steps to help convert their creative thoughts into active plans.

Freedom to Say What They Think

Executives and Analysts share a common problem: they aren't very sensitive to people's feelings, and sometimes use inconsiderate, direct ways of communicating. When dealing with other personality types, this often results in conversational *faux pas*, forcing them to reverse course and confusedly apologize to keep the peace. Constantly having to adjust their words so that they don't offend more fragile people is frustrating – it's as if they're always on a leash and can't be themselves.

In the company of Analysts, however, Executives find incredible freedom of speech. They may be asked to explain their ideas and opinions, but they won't need to apologize for the way they voice them. These types can relax and speak their truest, harshest views of the world together with little chance of bruised egos and hurt feelings. Compared to their attempts to get along with more sensitive personality types, this can feel like a relief. Executives find a dynamic conversational playground among Analyst friends, who are always happy to hear their honest thoughts.

Unbalanced Executive–Analyst Friendships

Disappointing Disconnection

There are challenges, of course – in unbalanced friendship, Executives can find Analysts to be unrealistic and annoyingly focused on ideas rather than necessary action. The fact that Executives operate on the proven, and Analysts like to theorize, is a stumbling block even in social or recreational matters. These two types might live in clashing mental time zones, with Executives focusing on what is, and Analysts on what might be. In unbalanced relationships, Executives may roll their eyes dismissively at Analysts' grand, esoteric plans, and may, in turn, be frustrated by Analysts' utter indifference to their more realistic interests.

To make this disconnection worse, Executives and Analysts both share a neglectful attitude toward maintaining friendships. Once they put in the initial effort to establish a solid rapport, both types may begin to take it for granted, thinking nothing of long silences or absences. This indicates a certain trust in each other, but functionally, such friends may simply drift apart through mutual carelessness and lack of effort. If they don't engage often enough, they miss out on the long-term benefits of the virtues they saw in each other in the first place.

Conflicts of Will

Another likely problem in unbalanced Executive–Analyst friendships is a clash of will. Analysts love to argue their interests and opinions, constantly trumpeting their views and mentally sparring with those who disagree. It's as if these conversations – or arguments – provide them with mental stimulation. Executives also hold firm views and are unlikely to back down, but because they don't share the joy of animated debate, they're quickly irritated by the ordeal of arguing with Analysts.

Sharing anything from political views to opinions on where to eat lunch can become frustrating for both types. Analysts may think Executives are dull-minded, and Executives, in turn, wonder if Analysts are all talk. Executives often just want a decision, not a debate, and may try to steamroll Analysts for the sake of a conclusion. Obviously, this can result in conflict. If these types don't find enough patience to talk things through, they eventually get fed up with each other's strong wills.

Rebalancing Executive–Analyst Friendships

Connecting to Each Other's Virtues

Executives and Analysts can build and maintain healthy connections by tapping into the logical benefits of being friends. Executives can foster realism and grounded practicality – critical strengths that Analysts often lack. Given their reputation for rational thought, Analysts sometimes use oddly narrow reasoning to justify their moves, especially when fixated on an idea. Executives help them avoid getting lost in interesting possibilities, as well as encourage them to be mindful of looming probabilities. Executives might research and respectfully share some solid facts to counter Analysts' wilder ideas in an act of caring support, not criticism.

They can benefit from Analysts' clever, unconventional views, as their tried-and-true practices often prove limited. Times change, and they're always looking to optimize. Occasionally, changing their approach is an unavoidable part of this. Analysts love beating challenges through innovation, and Executives can call on their friends' creativity to help them find answers with their fresh perspective. Frequently requesting and offering input back and forth on everyday matters is a great way for these friends to stay involved each other's lives.

Considerate Honesty

Because of their aggressive intellect, it's difficult to match wits with Analysts, but Executives have the strength to firmly and fairly express themselves. They don't need to argue: if they calmly explain the reason for their preferences, they get results. It can be as simple as saying, "You always want to try new restaurants, but it bums me out when they don't have something I like. I'd go out more often if we could also visit my favorite places." There's no rational argument against mutual respect and consideration in friendships, but they require patient communication.

Consideration goes both ways, and Executives can work to respect Analysts' many ideas and preferences as well. Constantly resisting change or new ideas by saying, "I don't like it, so it's not worth my time," doesn't represent respectful investment in valued friends. They can support their Analyst friends' interests now and then, even if they're somewhat abstract and speculative. They can bring their more reserved rationality along for the ride, and expect to learn a few things.

Thoughtful Support

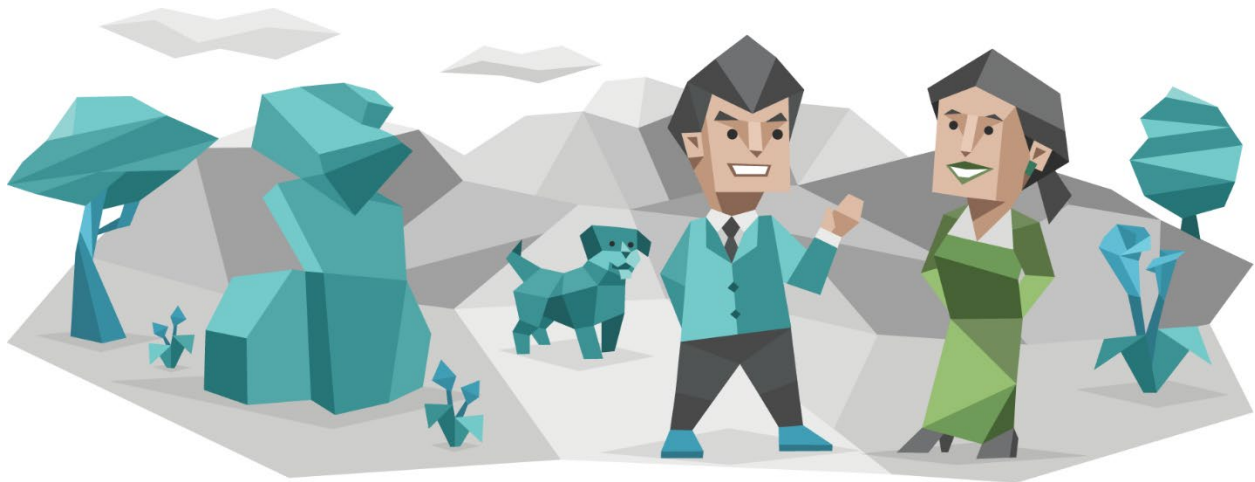
Functioning, balanced friendships with Analysts are certainly rewarding for both sides. Here are some benefits both types can keep in mind while trying to keep their friendships on the right track.

- Executives offer Analysts a sensible ear for their intellectual ranting that helps soothe their frustration with a dysfunctional world. Being dutiful, stable, and proactive is natural for these types, and Analysts need steadfast friends with minds sharp enough to understand them.
- In turn, Executives gain sincere, thoughtful support from their Analyst friends, whose vigorous minds are always at the ready. Analysts lead them to

knowledge they might not discover through their more conventional perspective, but also offer nimble, reasoned reflection in times of trouble.

Finally, Analysts help Executives work through personal problems rationally without prying into their emotions too deeply, and this is a great comfort.

Executive-Diplomat Friendships



Executive-Diplomat friendships aren't always quick fits, but they do hold great potential, especially if shared interests are present. These personality types both want to make the world a better place, and deeply value cooperation, but take very different paths to this harmonious ideal. Executives vigorously implement systems to create functionality for all, and Diplomats create alignment by valuing individuals' emotions and needs. These friendships maintain balance when each accepts the way the other thinks and contributes – each brings a big dose of what the other lacks.

Balanced Executive–Diplomat Friendships

Compatible Values

One of the most rewarding parts of Executive–Diplomat friendships is their cooperation to bring their values into reality. Diplomats never tire of sharing ideas for improving the world, though they often fail to separate true idealism from realistic endeavors. Executives can sift through their bubbling idealism to find ideas that work, and help make them happen. When it comes to order, duty, and certainty, Executives relate well to the methods of Protagonists and Advocates, as the Judging trait offers an overlap in perspective.

Diplomats, especially Mediators and Campaigners, can be overly whimsical, but their creativity intrigues Executives. They make an effort to appreciate their friends' sometimes unusual paths, and find personal inspiration in their active imaginations. In turn, Diplomats in balanced friendships admire Executives' precise minds. Their instant grasp of reality is a refreshingly clear mode of thought to those whose own minds are whirling with many ideas. Patience is required for these very different types to form friendship, but it's a worthwhile effort with a big payoff for both types.

Discovering Knowledge

Executives thrive on knowledge, but despite their boldness, they aren't often adventurous by nature. This results in depth of experience, but not breadth – leaving them relatively unprepared when life brings the unfamiliar to their doorstep. However, Diplomats' empathetic friendship is the perfect vessel for Executives to try new things and broaden their capability. They're unlikely to push Executives into things they strongly disapprove of, as they're very attentive to their feelings. In this supportive atmosphere, Executives can take a few intellectual risks to grow and learn,

knowing that the more they experience in life, the more successful their mastery of it.

The flip side is how wise and sensible Executives can be – they encourage and support their Diplomat friends by sharing realistic alternative ideas for achieving their grand dreams. They appreciate the way Executives forge smooth paths through life, tirelessly turning solid plans into stable reality. Their focused, energetic dedication is a lifeline to Diplomats who feel lost in chaos. When these chums each put their best feet forward, they balance idealism and practicality to notably improve each other's lives.

Unbalanced Executive–Diplomat Friendships

Different Realities

Unfortunately, such friendships may experience friction with the realization that their differing approaches or belief systems are incompatible in certain situations. Executives look to the past for tried and true examples of what works best, while Diplomats happily embrace revolutionary change. In unbalanced situations, Diplomats may become frustrated at Executives' insistence on working toward stability instead of joining them in what they see as progress. Executives see following the rules as an ideal, and in turn, may become disturbed when they see Diplomat friends breaking the rules *for* an ideal. These two types often feel as though they're living in different worlds.

This really hits home when these types express opinions on what is or isn't fair. Executives see fairness in applying reasonable rules dispassionately and equally. Diplomats, on the other hand, like to create fairness through conditional approaches based on moral ideals. Executives may focus more on individual responsibility and

drive to achieve equality, whereas Diplomats often focus on how people can establish equality by helping elevate each other.

Another difference is how Diplomats often chase unrealistic dreams. Executives find this behavior increasingly tiring when those dreams always seem to be on the horizon. These types respect realistic thinking, bold effort, and accomplishment, and are bothered by how willingly Diplomats – especially Campaigners and Mediators – embrace seemingly impossible dreams. Frustration can result if these friends can't reconcile their very different approaches to life.

Upsetting Each Other

The differences that can come to threaten these friendships aren't just about judgement or opinion: watching friends embrace things that seem imprudent, or even perilous, is frustrating for Executives. Whether it's dubious romantic interests, implausible beliefs, or precarious financial habits, Diplomats' sometimes unbalanced, haphazard lifestyle worries characteristically practical Executives. They can feel frustrated when trying to avert Diplomat friends' questionable decisions, as pragmatic logic isn't always persuasive to those who live through emotion.

Unfortunately, Executives can also cause offense when they share sharply cautionary advice, no matter how true it is. They become critical when something seems flawed to them, and to Diplomats, this feels like someone stepping on their dreams. They're hurt by Executives' firm rejection of fantastical possibilities, seeing it as a lack of support. Such unbalanced conflicts threaten these friendships, as either type may become dismissive: Executives can become exasperated and unsympathetically "wash their hands" of the matter, and Diplomats may cease contact with those they

see as fundamentally negative, a common misinterpretation of even the best-intentioned criticism or correction.

Rebalancing Executive–Diplomat Friendships

Explaining Perspectives

Resolving clashing views within Executive–Diplomat friendships requires a different approach from logical arguments. These friends don't need to agree with their lifestyles, but they can explain the adverse effects they feel from each other's behavior. For Executives, this may include functional concerns, and for Diplomats, it's more about feelings. Either way, honesty and respect are key. When Executives learn that their behavior is hurting their friends, reason dictates a change if those friends are truly valued and respected. Here are some ways Executives can approach conflicts with their Diplomat chums.

- When Executives take the time to gently explain why they're troubled, it appeals to Diplomats' sense of compassion, and they act accordingly. It can be as simple as saying, "That doesn't make sense to me. Can we talk things over together, so I can understand you better?" Logical facts aren't as important to Diplomats as their friends' welfare, and if asked respectfully to change their behavior a little, they're extremely receptive. These types needn't always see eye-to-eye to get along.
- The harder part for Executives is comprehending and meeting Diplomats' need for emotional support. An effective approach is to figure out Diplomats' implicit requests when they share their feelings, and give the desired responses. When these types express themselves, they're often just seeking validation and support. So, when Diplomats say, "I'm worried about making

my rent,” the response that best helps them might be, “Everything will be all right because I believe in you,” rather than, “You should move to a more affordable place, so this doesn’t keep happening.”

- Less specific examples include listening and making friends feel valued by offering reassurance or encouraging input. There’s also no harm in asking, “What can I do here to help you?” as Diplomats appreciate any sincere effort. This is also a supportive, subtle way for Executives to get Diplomat friends to consider the practicality of their ideas – how something might or might not be possible.
- Diplomats want attentive sympathy, and Executives can approximate this through deliberate acts of vigorous support. They can also gently tell Diplomats when they’re truly at their limits of emotional understanding or participation in something foreign to them.

In turn, Diplomats can moderate their expectations, and respect Executives by not placing heavy demands on them to frequently engage in emotion or fanciful ideas. While Executives and Diplomats may grow very close, Diplomats can understand they may need to find deep emotional engagement among other friends.

Stepping In, and Stepping Back

Diplomats may be sensitive to criticism, but caring Executive friends recognize when it’s time to offer their advice and help – and boldly step in, as is their nature. Executives can accept that Diplomats are dreamers, but there are moments when a more grounded perspective is vital, even if it isn’t requested. It’s not always easy to intervene, but they risk regret if avoiding emotional confrontations makes them withhold guidance from friends in trouble.

If their advice is ignored, Executives can respectfully retreat, making their ongoing support clear while holding true to their viewpoints. They may have little choice but to accept a continuous stream of questionable ideas and choices from Diplomat friends. If this happens, Executives can take pragmatic solace in knowing that they tried to help, and decline to be drawn in. Avoiding participation in things they can't support helps them maintain healthy friendships with Diplomats, even if they require their stepping back now and then.

Executive–Sentinel Friendships



Other Sentinels are good fits for Executives, as they share an appreciation for dependability and practicality. These friendships support day-to-day activities and general quality of life more than change, ambition, or curiosity. Uncomplicated friendships with other Sentinels reassure and buoy Executives. Having others who are steadfast and sensible in their lives is no small consideration for these types.

Balanced Executive–Sentinel Friendships

Reassuring Steadiness

Executives also find other Sentinels' conventional social leanings appealing, whether such friends are Introverts or Extraverts. Their discussions revolve around grounded matters like work, current life events, and personal interests. Sentinels aren't big on esoteric topics, and consider those who constantly talk about broad, impersonal matters a bit baffling – they like to use the time to catch up with each other. Among Sentinel friends, Executives get a pleasant dose of real life rather than ideological grandstanding.

These friendships go beyond casual compatibility, however. When serious situations and major life events happen, Executives also appreciate how Sentinel friends stand by their side through thick and thin. They offer the same in return, acting as strong, vocal supporters for those who earn their friendship. Executives and other Sentinels stand an excellent chance of becoming each other's best friends for a lifetime.

Stability in Action

Favoring stable foundations doesn't mean that these friends don't care about progress. However, where Intuitive or Prospecting types see a future teeming with endless possibilities, Executives like everything moving firmly in a controlled direction. Those with the Executive personality type may provide more energy than others ask for, but either way, having Sentinel friends with an organized way of living and equally sensible goals helps everyone keep moving forward.

When difficulties arise, Executives are often the first to step forward with a helping hand, and their Sentinel friends respect and sincerely appreciate their ready

devotion. In turn, Sentinels' judicious touch perfect for Executives in times of trouble. Whether offering thoughtful solutions or simply some dutiful, hands-on help, these comrades are cores of support for each other. This creates the security they need to form deep and grateful bonds with each other.

Relatable Differences

Opposing personality traits may be easier for Executives to relate to when other Sentinels display them. Consuls' compassionate Extraversion inspires them toward warmth, as it demonstrates creating structure through personal connections. Defenders' quiet sensitivity is charming to Executives, and their pragmatic, patient acceptance creates a gentle sense of connection. The reserved, thoughtful nature of Logisticians impresses them, as they see how taking the time to contemplate things before acting assures absolute efficiency.

Different Sentinel friends offer Executives doorways to growth, expanding some of their limits while staying soberly grounded alongside them. Shared values focusing on stability, tradition, and dedication make friendships within this Role a good way for Executives to find supportive bonds.

Unbalanced Executive–Sentinel Friendships

Social Problems

While these types are compatible, Executives can fail Sentinels in emotionally-charged situations such as breakups, arguments with other friends, or deaths in their families. Executives don't excel at interpersonal politics or hand-holding, and feel unhappily out of their depth when friends need understanding. Instead of showing warm, consoling reassurance, these types can point out problems in unbalanced

ways and come up with dispassionate solutions, leaving other Sentinels feeling emotionally abandoned.

In turn, being in the middle of such situations can be baffling for Executives. When Sentinels experience sudden, serious problems, Executives may simply not have the emotional understanding to figure things out quickly enough to keep a handle on these situations. This can be extremely frustrating to a personality type that so deeply values control and personal capability. Executives do everything they can to avoid drama in their own lives, so they tend to resent it when friends bring such things to their doorstep.

Mutual Immobility

Executives and Sentinel friends build enjoyable, predictable routines together, but unwillingness to try new things can hold back their advancement on many fronts. Sentinels don't offer Executives much inspiration to make even beneficial changes to their lives, such as moving or going back to school. These friends may even shut out other worthy people who bring ideas that don't easily fit their social order. Instead of embracing the risks of ongoing development, these pals seek to reassure each other that things are OK.

Mutual reassurance provides a sense of comfort and solidity, but does little to motivate improvements. This isn't to say that these friends settle for failure, but they may settle for existing success. Even the most vigorous Executives rarely see the value in spontaneously changing what's proved to be a serviceable routine. Consequently, these friends may not push each other to excel beyond the security of conventional accomplishments. They do each other a disservice if they don't

occasionally step out of such routines together to see what life can offer, and what they're truly capable of when they push their boundaries.

Rebalancing Executive–Sentinel Friendships

Rational Peacemakers

When Executives can't fully empathize with friends' emotional situations, they need not feel ineffective. Instead of artlessly trying to discuss feelings they don't know how to navigate, they can admit their limits while still offering firm support. Authenticity grants these types a strength that's reassuring to upset friends, so it's OK for them to say, "I don't fully understand how you feel, but I am always here for you." Sentinel friends are grateful for such caring that's sincere.

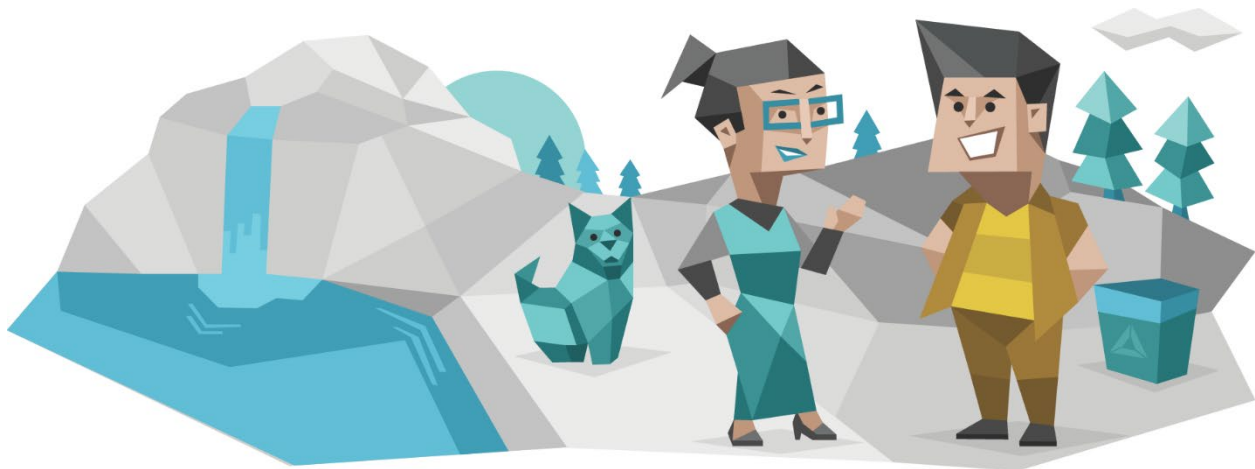
Once emotions have calmed a bit, Executives' detachment becomes an asset to friends in challenging situations. These types can take on roles of impartial observers, and try to help friends see practical moves that ease the situation. If friends are at odds, Executives are very confident and sensible mediators. Their preference for a clear understanding of the facts, and their relative comfort in rendering impartial judgement, helps them to stay fair for all parties concerned.

Sensible Change

Sentinels excel at being responsible, so Executives and Sentinels alike can keep an eye not just on each other's comfort and security, but on what truly benefits each other long-term. These friends wisely advise each other when they're in a rut, and offer ideas when change is needed to create success. When this requires embracing something new or unconventional, they can provide each other a judicious helping hand as well as supportive encouragement.

This applies to recreational pursuits as well as more serious matters, and these friends do well to try things out together. There's no need to leap off a cliff or take significant risks, but sampling new types of fun with trustworthy Sentinel friends leads to experiences that Executives wouldn't find on their own. These types aren't reluctant to take on challenges, and can likewise boldly explore new adventures. Engaging the unknown together, at least occasionally, is a smart way for these friends to explore their potential while sharing some fun.

Executive-Explorer Friendships



Friendships with Explorers are more likely to form through work, class, or mutual friends rather than direct social attraction, but they offer Executives some notable opportunities. Explorers live for the moment and its pleasures rather than long-term stability. At first, this seems reckless to Executives. However, their ability to lose themselves in enthusiasm is a great counterpoint to Executives' careful, methodical planning. These friendships provide a fresh outlook that helps Executives see a broader perspective on life.

Balanced Executive–Explorer Friendships

Zest for Life

Executives benefit from being led into fun and curiosity by their Explorer friends. Though it's not easy, Executives can practice relinquishing control and taking things as they come, especially in recreational matters where little is at stake. Developing adaptability without losing their cool is very useful for these types. They can't always predict what life throws at them. Friendship with Explorers is a wonderful way to practice mastering the unexpected, the unpredictable, and the uninhibited aspects of life.

Offering Guidance

Executives appreciate how Explorers' passion for discovery leads to knowledge, but also see how such carefree enthusiasm can result in unintended consequences. Supportive, tactical advice is where they shine in such friendships. When they earn their Explorer friends' trust, they become a respected voice of caution. While not expecting Explorers to share their sense of moderation, they offer a respectful, steadying hand with just the right amount of reservation to prevent calamity.

Executives who come to trust Explorer friends can also accept their guiding hand to pull them out of their stoic sense of duty into some well-deserved gratification. They have a hard time realizing, admitting, and exploring their heartfelt inner desires. Explorers provide not only inspiration in this area, but practical help when Executives are ready to relax and have some fun.

Surprising Capability

At first, Executives assume that Explorers' more spontaneous style, so different from their rigid approach, isn't very effective. However, they're impressed when Explorer friends pursue things they care about to great success, and overcome challenges on the fly with adaptive tenacity. Explorers might change their minds frequently, but they throw themselves wholeheartedly into mastering interests that are important to them.

When those interests align with Executives' own, they find Explorer friends to be helpful, involved companions. Explorers add a little refreshing excitement to Executives' goals – and lives in general. For example, Adventurers' quiet curiosity introduces them to subtle experiences and knowledge they might miss on their own. They also very much appreciate the practical, hands-on side of Explorer friends. The intent way Virtuosos hone their skills is impressive even to such a capable type as Executives.

Motivation

Executives benefit from the undaunted, open-minded spirit of Explorers as well. The outward-focused vigor of Entrepreneur and Entertainer friends matches their energy, but with uninhibited enthusiasm. What Explorers lack in steadiness, they make up for with zeal, approaching experiences and challenges with a flexibility from which Executives can learn a lot.

In turn, Executives' organized effectiveness impresses Explorer friends, especially when aimed at a common goal. Explorers grab for what they want, and as masters of logical planning and energetic execution, Executives can help them ensure

success. These friends lend each other very different kinds of help to move successfully through life.

Unbalanced Executive–Explorer Friendships

Dangerous Games

There's a dark side to living in the moment, as a lack of consistency and forethought often brings about wild disorganization, social friction, and financial instability. Explorers' uninhibited lifestyle and impetuous decisions challenge Executives' boundaries of acceptance. Being exposed to too much chaos is deeply troubling – even offensive – to them. It's not in their nature to abandon friends, but they're quick to defend the stability of their own lives. They'll ultimately distance themselves if they feel threatened enough.

Explorers rarely understand or respect these doubts and reservations in unbalanced friendships, and either try to push Executives into things or lose patience and act without them. In unbalanced friendships, any idea of steadfast companionship can vanish into thin air when Explorers feel compelled to go in directions that Executives refuse to consider. This mutual disregard causes both types to question their friendships. Explorers resent the lack of support when they want to follow their hearts, and Executives dig in their heels, weary of ever-changing, exuberant disorder.

Disappointment and Frustration

A seemingly minor area where the often-fickle interests of Explorer friends can be very troubling for Executives is planning. Executives demand organization, and Explorers don't exactly operate that way. Friends being late for, altering, or canceling social engagements can be deeply frustrating to Executives. These picky types

become overly-critical when their value of reliability isn't reflected. In turn, Explorers are dismayed by their intolerance.

More seriously, Executives' difficulty with emotions and human connections is worsened in unbalanced friendships when Explorers' attention is easily pulled in new directions. It's hard for Executives to communicate their feelings, even to highly reliable friends, as they dislike showing anything like vulnerability. Being let down by inconsistent people, unfortunately, reinforces this tendency to hide aspects of themselves.

Disappointment goes both ways in these unbalanced friendships, however. Executives offer Explorers little in the way of empathetic support, excitement, or the unknown, and their rigid methods of consideration often hinder adventure and discovery. Executives may not turn out to be the engaged, fun friends that Explorers seek, and Explorers don't put up with disappointment for very long.

Rebalancing Executive–Explorer Friendships

Respecting Limits and Needs

To achieve balance within their friendships, Executives and Explorers need to consciously recognize and accept their differences. These types frequently test each other, but this provides many opportunities for growth. Complaining isn't communication, and both must recognize when it's time to stop wasting energy on silent – or vocal – judgement. Instead, they can start talking about their needs gently, respectfully, and honestly with each other. Here are some ways these friends can grow their bonds.

- When Executives fairly communicate their true limits, Explorer friends can avoid pulling them too far out of their comfort zone. Conventional outings together – perhaps dining at favorite restaurants, shopping trips, or movies – are good ways for these friends to share some fun when Executives have had enough adventure. Explorers are all about indulgence and Executives appreciate familiarity, so they're wise to share some simple pleasures together.
- Likewise, Executives rarely back down from a challenge, and can stretch themselves when Explorers need company doing something exciting. An easy way for Explorers to encourage Executives to participate in such activities is to involve them in the planning, and then make sure they stick to the plan. Executives are a lot more willing to approach new things when the approach itself is well-organized.
- In any case, the importance of the friendships themselves form the common focus, with an understanding that sometimes compromises must be made for the sake of a worthy friend. Neither type needs to lead in a direction they find uncomfortable, but they can try to follow now and then. This kind of consideration isn't automatic or easy for either Executives or Explorers, but it's an area where both types greatly benefit from conscious improvement.

Detached Understanding

There may also be times when these friends are wise to just do their own thing. It may not be obvious, but pulling back and letting others make their own decisions is a sign of tremendous respect from Executives, and true friends deserve that respect. When Explorers engage in something too extreme for Executives to support, they can practice respectful, rational detachment. There's no shame in letting their friends

be wild and free without them for a while. They can hear the stories and laugh together afterward.

Explorers can appreciate this respect, even if it doesn't always come with participation or complete approval. In return, they can respect Executives' limits, and understand that not everyone has as much excited curiosity in the face of the unknown. When Executives need order, Explorers can just wait until they're ready and make another friendly offer later – no pressure. For these friends, respectfully giving each other room to be themselves is necessary, and they can come back together later for something they both enjoy.

Conclusion

Mutual support and shared fun are among the greatest benefits of friendship. These might not seem like top priorities to a type as driven and grounded as Executives, but for all their logic, they're still social creatures. Connecting to other people is an integral part of their journey toward status, success, and happiness. These types know the value of networking, and the efficient strength found in cooperation.

Once they come to truly know other people, their assumptions and beliefs are in for some challenges, but Executives are up for that challenge. Applying their judicious value of fairness is an excellent way for these types to be open to beneficial friendships with people who think and act differently. They're strong enough not just to hold convictions, but to explore other ideas and lifestyles through worthy, capable friends.

Progress aside, Executives who take the time to focus some energy on friendships instead of just life goals also receive a kind of inner fulfillment that's a prize unto

itself. Status and success are genuinely valuable things, but having true friends who respect and appreciate the individuals behind all that hard work is priceless. Executives who invest in their friendships ensure that they always have someone not only to congratulate their triumphs, but also to share laughter, trust, and joy with them.

Additional Tools and Tests

Want to dig even deeper into your friendships? If you have access to the toolkits area of the website, we offer a variety of additional tools and tests to help you explore.

[Type Guesser \(Friendships\)](#)

Are you trying to figure out what personality type your friend belongs to? You may find that this simple tool helps.

[Personal Authenticity Test](#)

Can you be your true self with your friends and family? Let's explore how you feel about your authenticity in those circumstances.

Parenthood



Responsible and Respectable

The Executives' mantra of "hard work, tradition, respect" is best exemplified in their relationships with their children. In many ways, they're the classic 1950s era parental figures – strict guardians of family traditions who have no trouble enforcing the rules and standards they've established while also providing solid, pragmatic wisdom. Often seen as model citizens, these types expect their children to continue the example they've set by being polite and respectful.

Executives have a very responsibility-oriented view of life. They share a firm belief in the idea that one does what one can to contribute to the family and the community. This view is, of course, extended to their children. As soon as they're able, their sons and daughters are expected to contribute in their way, by cleaning their plates, keeping their rooms tidy, and going to bed on time – by maintaining the order of things.

It's not that they have wild, high-flying hopes of perfection for their children. Executives are down-to-earth people, and merely want to see their kids develop into

respected, responsible adults. However, they also want them to be decisive and capable, which can only happen with the chance to make their own decisions – and to face the consequences of those choices, good or bad, with their parents' love and support.

While yielding control may be difficult, Executives can exercise patience and restraint by allowing their children to fall off their bikes, fail tests they didn't study for, or have their hearts broken by unrequited young love. These youthful afflictions provide opportunities for parents to teach caution, resilience, and thoughtful problem-solving skills that can benefit their children for the rest of their lives.

Loyal and Honest

The moment they become parents, these types become unequivocally devoted to raising their kids to the best of their abilities. Their loyalty is unwavering, and they're fully committed to providing everything necessary for their children to be successful in life, though this is very different from giving everything their children want. Using their natural ability to organize and delegate tasks, Executives can create a stable and secure environment where their sons and daughters can truly thrive.

Because their parents are never the type to mince words, Executives' children always know exactly what's expected of them. These expectations are likely to be thoroughly outlined and reinforced consistently – and their parents provide feedback on how well they're meeting these expectations on a regular basis. Though they may not always communicate it sensitively, this feedback is still candid and sincere.

Perhaps the most significant and enduring aspect of Executives' loyal, honest nature is the fact they're modeling these virtues to their children. They expect their kids to value these traits as well, and emphasize this at every opportunity. Consistently

observing and experiencing the benefits of the loyalty and honesty their parents exude instills their importance. Children of Executive parents are likely to respect and reciprocate these often-neglected virtues.

Overly Controlling

With their desire to always do “what’s best” for their children, Executives can quickly spiral into unbalanced, excessively controlling behavior. They’re the personality type most likely to believe they should guide their kids’ education, and the type least inclined to think they need to give children the freedom to develop. This system of beliefs can create a repressive environment, which prevents children from engaging with their naturally curious instincts. Without the opportunity to freely explore their surroundings, pursue their interests, and make mistakes, youngsters can never develop the ability to take the initiative or bounce back from failures.

Unbalanced controlling behavior tends to present itself in negative ways, especially during stressful situations. Executives who believe their children are being particularly difficult may dole out punishments that are harsher than necessary. Even small transgressions can seem like personal affronts to their authority, causing offended parents to become disconcerted. Discipline then becomes their primary tool for keeping their children in line and making sure they follow the rules.

When parental discipline is focused entirely on punishment, children lose out on the opportunity to truly learn from their mistakes. Constant criticism of their behavior, rather than encouragement to improve, often manifests in kids as a sense of defeat. They may think, “Why bother, I’m not going to ever meet their expectations.” When they consistently feel this level of frustration, they may either become withdrawn or begin acting out – feeling that what they do doesn’t matter because they can’t please

their parents either way. Whether children should respond this way or not isn't relevant in this situation. The fact is, they can, and it's up to Executive parents to guide their development sensibly and realistically under the circumstances. Ignoring the facts doesn't help anyone.

Lacking Warmth and Sensitivity

When children need the warmth and sensitivity of emotional support, all the loyalty, devotion, and structure that Executive parents model are of little use. While these types can be sensitive in their way toward those they care about, it's hard for younger children and adolescents to recognize this tough love for the love that it is. These parents may need to rely on more sensitive or empathic partners to fill this role and create balance between clear, rational purpose and a harder-to-define sense of emotional well-being.

Other situations that may inhibit them from parenting as effectively as they would like are those where empathy is needed. Children make mistakes, act irrationally, and routinely test boundaries, making interacting with them incredibly frustrating at times. Executives' lack of sensitivity can cause them to interact with their sons and daughters in less-than-understanding ways, creating a cycle of frustration and anger for both parents and children. Kids with the Feeling trait may especially be crushed by what they perceive to be a rejection of their emotions – or even themselves – and can display this in fearfulness, becoming withdrawn, and acting out.

Creating Learning Opportunities

It's easy to become caught up in controlling behaviors. Children certainly need structure and benefit significantly from organized households. However, excessive control of their environment, combined with unrealistic expectations, can result in

youngsters who are unable to regulate their behavior. Rather than focusing purely on controlling their children, Executives can concentrate on providing them with opportunities to learn how to control themselves.

If there's anything that these parents hope to accomplish, it's to raise children who are hard-working, capable, and responsible, just like they are. The best way to teach these lessons is by modeling, which Executives excel at, and allowing their sons and daughters to learn through trial and error. Mistakes can be made into opportunities to create teachable moments rather than inflicting punishment.

Toddlers may undoubtedly spill their milk the first time they try to make cereal by themselves. Parents who show them how to clean up their spill, and carefully model how to pour milk without spilling, experience less frustration than those who immediately put their little ones in time-out. Not only are they teaching them a valuable skill, but they're also preventing the inevitable meltdown that occurs when toddlers feel they're unjustly punished. This technique takes more time up front, but saves a great deal of time in the future as their children become more competent and confident in their abilities.

Developing Effective Emotional Expression

In addition to creating learning opportunities out of mistakes, Executives who desire meaningful relationships with their children must work toward building strong emotional bonds. Improving their emotional expression, or how they communicate their feelings with others, benefits their relationships with their kids as well as anyone else with whom they're in regular contact. This aspect of personal growth can be daunting, and these types may fight the process by continually arguing against its

merits. Parenthood, however, is a very motivating experience and may provide just the right level of pressure to convince Executives that it's worthwhile.

To improve their emotional expression, they may need to look at whether their communication with their children is overly critical or insensitive. As a dominant personality type, they may inadvertently steamroll their children when trying to talk through their expectations. Kids who either withdraw or act out aggressively when frustrated may feel as though their parents are demanding too of much of them without taking the time to listen to their own needs and desires. Honest, patient listening skills and measured, considerate responses can garner more respect and more positive reactions from children of every age.

Parenting for Each Stage of Development

Each stage of children's growth presents both unique challenges and exciting milestones. Learning how to navigate these stages can seem daunting, but the opportunity to build healthy attachments and create meaningful memories makes it worth the struggle.

Renowned psychologist Erik Erikson proposed a theory of psychosocial development that identified eight stages, five of which take place between birth and 18 years of age. It's important to remember that these stages aren't set in stone, and the ages listed for each stage are approximate. Children develop at their own pace and meet each milestone in their own time. The following paragraphs briefly discuss what to expect at each stage of development, as well as how the strengths and weaknesses of the Executive personality type can affect their parenting at each stage.

Building Bonds (Birth–1 ½ Years)

According to Erikson, the stages of infancy and early childhood last from birth until approximately three years of age. Children in these stages are very dependent on their parents to meet their needs. This is also when the bonds of attachment are created by meeting children's needs, developing trusting relationships, and promoting autonomy.

The priority for infants in their journey to attachment is having their basic needs met. From being fed to receiving affection, they learn to either trust that their Executive parents can provide for them, or they suffer from a sense of mistrust in all their subsequent relationships. If these types are inconsistent in providing for their children, or are especially violent or neglectful – an extreme situation, to be sure – their children can have difficulty creating positive, trusting attachment.

Attentive, affectionate parents, especially those who engage in consistent physical contact such as snuggling or transporting their children in baby carriers on their bodies, can develop trusting, hopeful relationships with their infants and are likely to have little difficulty building comfortable attachments.

Balanced Infant Parenting

Building Reliable Bonds

Executives excel at providing structure for their children and are certainly able to meet their infants' needs in this regard. Reliability is vital in building relationships with infants, and these parents are likely to be very attentive to their babies by dependably feeding, changing, and comforting them when necessary. Most Executives enjoy the infant stage, where their children rely on them entirely for

meeting their needs, and won't hesitate to provide for them consistently in patient and, ideally, caring ways.

As parents, these types have an extreme sense of duty to meet their children's needs, which can be motivating during the extraordinarily draining infant stage. Where some parents may struggle with maintaining energy during this phase, leading to mood swings or other inconsistent behaviors, Executives not only survive this stage but even enjoy it. They can create a foundation for building trust and instilling hope in their infants.

Endless Energy

Sleepless nights are inevitable, and exhaustion is almost certainly guaranteed during this stage. Executive parents have an advantage in this regard, as they're high energy and are the least likely personality type to tire easily. This power can carry them through especially exhausting days.

In addition to having the momentum needed to power through their sleep deprivation, their excess energy, if utilized effectively, can help to insulate them from some of the issues caused by exhaustion, such as feeling anxious, sad, or overwhelmed. While all new parents have these feelings to some extent (and if they're severe or continue for several days, consult a medical professional), Executives may thrive on and revel in the opportunity to make order out of the chaos.

Unbalanced Infant Parenting

Inadequate Affection

Although they're extraordinarily attentive and reliable, parents with the Executive personality type may need to focus on regularly providing intentional affection.

During the infant stage, babies who don't receive adequate physical contact with caregivers can struggle with bonding and trust. In severe cases, infants who go without loving physical contact can experience a failure to thrive, resulting in emotional, intellectual, and behavioral issues that could continue to plague them in future relationships.

Most Executive parents are unlikely to completely deprive their children of physical contact, but they may see interactions with their babies as necessary exchanges rather than opportunities to promote bonding. They may be tempted to let their children "cry it out" when it's time for them to sleep, even though they may respond more positively to rocking or a soothing lullaby. Adapting to their infants' unique needs during this time can be especially frustrating for this personality type who prefers to do things their way.

Struggling with Expectations

In addition to struggling with expressing affection, Executives may have unrealistic expectations of their children during this stage. While they certainly understand their infants' capabilities at this point, they may expect them to achieve certain milestones more quickly than is necessary, or fret that their children aren't hitting milestones "on time." Specifically, they may be more concerned about getting their children to sit up, roll over, feed themselves, or walk before they're truly ready, rather than appreciating their current abilities and engaging with them at their level.

It's certainly exciting to see babies roll over for the first time or sit up on their own. However, trying to push children to achieve these milestones too soon only causes frustration for everyone involved. Just because their infants aren't saying their first words at the same time as their friend's children doesn't mean they aren't as

intelligent. Development, especially at this stage, isn't a measure of parental ability, and both Executive parents and their infants are likely to be much happier and more relaxed if they're allowed to grow and develop at their own pace.

Rebalancing Infant Parenting

Determining Developmental Needs

At this stage, it's important to understand that developmental milestones are approximate and aren't set in stone. Additionally, little ones who attain certain milestones earlier aren't necessarily "advanced," and those who achieve them later aren't always "delayed." Labeling children as advanced or delayed, especially this early, can be detrimental to their lifelong development and self-esteem.

Pediatricians and family physicians are parents' best resource for determining whether they should be concerned about their children's development. These professionals can provide resources that cover what to expect at different stages regarding physical, intellectual, psychological, and behavioral development. Regular appointments with physicians ensure that any issues are addressed as soon as possible, and can help to put Executive parents' mind at ease.

Interacting with Affection

Executives are extraordinarily motivated by a sense of duty to their families and can excel at parenting through the infancy stage if they take steps to overcome potential weaknesses. They're generally hesitant to express their emotions, but innocent children, especially those who reciprocate their feelings through smiles, giggles, and other positive reactions, can bring out Executive parents' sensitive, silly, loving sides.

Reciprocating their laughter, facial expression, and even hand motions encourages bonding and builds the neural pathways necessary for children to learn. Cuddling, keeping their infants in wearable children-carriers, talking in a soothing voice, singing, and encouraging eye contact are additional physical ways that Executives can foster meaningful, deep attachment with their babies.

Testing Boundaries (1 ½–3 Years)

Once they're mobile, young children become very interested in exploring their environment with their senses. Crawling, walking, grabbing items, putting things in their mouths, and verbal communication are just a few of the ways that toddlers learn about the world around them.

During this stage, parents must provide a safe harbor for their children while still allowing them to experience and explore their surroundings. Children permitted to test boundaries yet are still receiving parental support and encouragement can develop a sense of autonomy. Those who are overly restricted, criticized, or made to feel guilty for their desire to test boundaries can ultimately experience a sense of shame and may suffer from feelings of incompetence or low self-worth. These feelings can last throughout their lives, and may eventually jeopardize their ability to achieve goals and develop positive character traits such as reliability or confidence.

Balanced Toddler Parenting

Patient and Supportive

Executives' patience and stamina are especially useful during the difficult toddler years. While this stage can certainly be challenging, these parents enjoy promoting their children's curiosity and independence while still maintaining a safe

environment. They take pleasure in helping their children learn how to pick out their clothes and dress themselves, and how to use and manipulate toys and tools (such as forks and spoons). Teaching their children to become self-reliant and competent are among these parents' greatest joys.

Incredibly supportive, Executives make an ideal “home base” for their toddlers during at this point as well. Their consistency and reliability can ensure that their little ones never feel abandoned, ignored, or unloved. Even though children at this age are incredibly independent, they still crave (and need) trustworthy caregivers who can meet all their needs, and Executives won't disappoint.

Providing Safe Boundaries

Known for running a tight ship, Executives excel at setting up reasonable boundaries that allow toddlers to feel as though they're unrestricted, but still feel controlled by them as parents. The perception they're allowed to play or explore freely is especially crucial for toddlers working to build a sense of autonomy. Something as simple as setting up spaces where their toddlers can color, glue, and paint without worrying about the mess, or allowing them to pick out their own books at the library, can feel incredibly liberating.

Providing a safe, structured environment gives Executives the sense of control they need to remain confident in their abilities. When constructed correctly, this structure can expand and contract based on their children's needs. As their sons and daughters grow and mature, these parents can gradually increase the boundaries they've set to provide for more opportunities and independence. On the other hand, parents can choose to tighten them for children who struggle with limits that provide a level of ambiguity they aren't prepared to deal with. The toddler years may be the

first time Executive parents need to fully utilize their natural ability to determine and successfully create the boundaries their children need.

Unbalanced Toddler Parenting

Authority Issues

On the flip side, this stage can be especially challenging for Executive parents, as they can have difficulty accepting their children's desire to push boundaries. From insisting on dressing themselves (and choosing their uncoordinated clothing) to refusing to eat any form of fresh produce (or any healthy food for that matter), toddlers often seem as though they're challenging their parents' authority at every turn. There's a delicate balance to be achieved between providing a safe space to explore and not overly controlling their children's environment. Toddlers who wish to do things independently can become increasingly frustrated by parents who continually deny them these opportunities.

Parents with the Executive personality type can be offended by kids who appear to challenge their authority or don't display expected behavior, especially in public. Hierarchies are to be respected, especially between parents and children, and when their authority is questioned or ignored, these parents are likely to become frustrated. It doesn't help that their toddlers are likely to acquire a new favorite word they can use forcefully and frequently, "No." Executives don't approve of being challenged and may find this stage of their children's development to be one of the most difficult to reconcile.

Rebalancing Toddler Parenting

Promoting Responsible Independence

Children at this stage seek both security and increasing autonomy, and Executives need to tow the fine line between patiently supporting this desire to explore and upholding essential rules to ensure their safety. Here are some tips these parents can try.

- Finding ways to involve them in household chores, or giving them options such as, “Would you like to wear your red shirt or blue shirt today?” can enhance not only their skills but their sense of autonomy and achievement as well, making them more confident and secure in their abilities.
- It’s easy to become frustrated when toddlers appear to be continually questioning authority, but it’s important to understand the necessity of testing boundaries at this stage. Children need to learn how to act independently and become self-reliant, and they do this by testing their parents’ authority.
- It helps to look at discipline, especially during this stage, as a learning opportunity for kids rather than as a form of punishment.
- For example, toddlers trying to get their parents’ attention may attempt to do so through hitting or yelling. Rather than shouting back or putting them in time-out, Executive parents can first practice engaging with the children through eye contact, crouching to meet them at eye level, hand holding, or hugging.

After toddlers feel connected, their parents can use these opportunities to help their children develop better ways of looking for attention. This can take practice and consistency, and Executives excel at both.

Thirst for Knowledge (3–5 Years)

The preschool years, from approximately three to five years of age, are a prime time for brain development, and little ones accumulate knowledge at an extraordinary rate through constant activity and a seemingly infinite range of questions. Learning at this stage takes place through play, especially the unstructured kind, and lots of social interaction with family and peers. Creativity is also exercised extensively through imaginary play, make-believe games, and stories.

To master this stage, children must be given the opportunity to not only make some of their own decisions, but also be allowed to initiate activities, ask questions (and receive answers), and lead others in exploration play. Youngsters who aren't given these opportunities – or are made to feel as though their constant questions or childish make-believe games are annoying – can experience feelings of guilt, frustration, and a lack of competence. Consequently, they may suffer from poor self-control or a lack of initiative.

Balanced Preschool Parenting

Natural Teachers

Executives are both patient and self-confident, which are valuable traits when parenting curious, active young children. They happily answer their preschool children's seemingly ceaseless stream of questions and take great pleasure in modeling practical skills, such as sweeping or washing dishes. Imparting their knowledge in practical, useful ways is one of Executive parents' greatest strengths.

Practical skills and academics aren't the only topics these parents value – instilling a sense of character into their children from a young age is just as important to

Executives as any set of skills. They teach their children to respect authority, from teachers to elderly neighbors. They insist upon honesty, and are the type of parents who order their preschoolers to not only apologize to a neighbor whose flowers they dug up but also help them to replant those flowers. These parents feel it's their moral obligation to instill these important principles through modeling and consistent reinforcement.

Promoting Confidence

Additionally, these types are incredibly confident in their abilities, and rightly so, as they're especially dedicated, motivated, and competent. These individuals can achieve whatever they set out to do. This is an incredibly helpful mindset to model and pass on to children, especially during the preschool and school years – the stage for increasing both confidence and competence.

As natural leaders themselves, Executives have well-developed decision-making skills and an incredible amount of initiative – qualities that are vital for preschool-aged children to learn. As an often-assertive personality type, Executives parents can actively encourage their children to step up and develop leadership skills. At this stage, they can expect their kids to introduce themselves to other children at the playground, and use their problem-solving skills to deal with any difficult-to-play-with children they encounter. They're unlikely to pander to their preschoolers' desire for them to solve any issues they may face. Instead, Executives can work with them to figure out age-appropriate solutions to their problems.

Unbalanced Preschool Parenting

Lacking Adaptability

Although they love promoting learning, these types may have difficulty following their children's lead during the preschool years. Parents may struggle with the spontaneous needs kids often present at especially inopportune times. As very schedule-driven, timely individuals, they can be annoyed by preschoolers who are more interested in their coloring pages than getting their shoes on when it's time to leave. Temper tantrums and bathroom emergencies can derail the best-laid plans, and Executives who focus on maintaining tight schedules can frustrate both themselves and their sons and daughters.

This lack of adaptability can also manifest as an inability to interact with their children in silly, playful ways. Parenting is serious business for Executives, who may struggle with their children's desire to engage in make-believe play or sing goofy songs, especially if they ask their parents to join in. Spontaneous play isn't Executives' strong suit or something they necessarily wish to cultivate in their children, and they may find it downright annoying.

Occasionally Overbearing

Another area Executive parents can have difficulty with is genuinely embracing unstructured play. These types may fall prey to the idea that free play isn't as valuable as "educational" play or structured activities, and may focus their energy on providing learning experiences rather than allowing their children to take the lead. If they take their love of routine and structure too far, Executives may leave too little room for their children to make the discoveries – and even important mistakes – they need to develop competence and initiative.

This tendency to be overbearing can be especially damaging to children who are Introverted or Feeling types who struggle with social interaction or feel overwhelmed by displays of dominance. Extraverted Executive types may mistake Introverted children's lack of desire to interact with peers at the park as a serious lack of social skills instead of an utterly legitimate personality trait. Preschoolers who cry easily when their parents raise their voices may be seen as "cry-babies" in need of "toughening up." These types may view sensitivity as a weakness to be corrected, rather than a trait that requires a different style of communication from their parents.

Rebalancing Preschool Parenting

Increasing Flexibility

Learning to gauge their children's developmental readiness can be difficult for Executives who have become too focused on timely achievement. Rather than constantly worrying about their children's development, these parents can focus on allowing them to develop them organically. Children don't need an excessive number of play dates, "educational" toys and games, or structured learning periods throughout the day. Playing with simple toys allows them to engage their imagination, the fundamental building block for developing their ability to gain knowledge as they grow.

Being flexible doesn't have to mean all play and no work. One way these parents can promote both learning and autonomy without being overly controlling is to allow their children to define their "lesson" for the day.

- If their kids want to go to the zoo, make a point to ask them questions about the animals they see.

- Seek out answers to any questions they may have about the creatures they're observing.
- If they're playing outside, help them to identify bugs, birds, trees, and flowers in a playful way. Just giving a name to the bird they're observing – "That black and white bird is a magpie!" – is learning.

Children allowed to seek out learning experiences on their own at this stage are much more likely to do so throughout their lives.

Embracing Play Time

To add even more benefit for both themselves and their children, Executives can take time to engage in play. A game of hide-and-seek, sitting on the floor putting together a puzzle, or playing with toys are all great ways to both model the benefits of play and to enhance the parent-child bond. Additionally, unstructured play time is vitally important for children at this stage to gain competence, confidence, and initiative.

Executives must learn to let their kids have plenty of free play time, ideally with lots of time outdoors in nature, without a specific agenda. Even boredom is valuable, as this is when children feel the need to try new things and learn new skills. Preschoolers with this type of freedom can gain confidence in their abilities and be more inclined to intentionally seek out educational opportunities later in life.

Creating Competence (5–12 Years)

The early school years are an important period of skill development for young children. Not only are they still continually absorbing new information, but they're also working on becoming proficient in increasingly complex areas, from relationships to mathematics to athletics. Children who are both challenged and

supported in these areas can flourish in both their abilities as well as their self-confidence. If they don't receive consistent support at this stage, they can begin to feel inferior to their peers and are less likely to develop or work toward achieving long-term goals. On the other hand, if they aren't sufficiently challenged, they may begin to feel overly-confident in themselves and their abilities, and can lack modesty and compassion toward others.

Balanced School-Age Parenting

Supportive and Pragmatic

As they strive to be capable students themselves, Executives can promote obedience, attentiveness, and respect for authority in their children as well. The school years, whether spent in "traditional" educational environments or not, focus on the development of academic skills and obtaining proficiency. Executive parents tend to provide the necessary structure to help their children succeed, whether it's helping with homework, finding a tutor, or even just providing consistent support for frustrated kids.

While very supportive and encouraging of their children, Executives balance out these traits with their focus on duty and pragmatism. They're no strangers to hard work themselves, and can encourage children of all levels and abilities to achieve their personal best. These parents are proud of their sons' and daughters' accomplishments. However, they loathe arrogance, and won't hesitate to call out kids engaging in conceited or pretentious behavior. These pragmatic types expect achievement, and advise their children to focus on the task at hand instead of seeking out acknowledgment for every little accomplishment.

Excellent Mentors

The school years are a time of intense learning, and Executives are natural teachers who have no trouble modeling the skills needed for academic success as well as real-world skills. Ever the pragmatists, Executive parents won't shy away from teaching their children the value of hard work and the importance of traits such as dependability and persistence.

Practical skills are just as necessary as academics, and these parents are likely to take every opportunity to pass on these skills. They can teach even young children age-appropriate ways to help with cooking, cleaning, and home maintenance. In fact, these teaching moments may be one of the primary ways that Executive parents spend time bonding with their children. Working on the car together, showing them how to make cookies, and even teaching them how to do laundry are all fantastic opportunities to model skills and build their relationships with their children. Relationships are built on quality time spent together, and helping their youngsters learn how to succeed in life is unequivocally high-quality time.

Unbalanced School-Age Parenting

Overly Concerned with Achievement

Executives can become overly concerned about making sure that their children are genuinely "good kids," meaning they're successful in school, socially connected, engaged in hobbies, and well-behaved. This mindset can prove especially detrimental to children at this stage by indicating that academic achievement and good behavior are more important than holistic growth or their personal interests. From Scouting programs to swimming lessons, parents may place a great deal of

emphasis on extracurricular activities they believe can help their children be “successful” without realizing they’re overburdening them.

Executive parents who elevate their expectations to this extent may experience emotional outbursts from their children when they become fed up by an excessive focus on how they appear to others rather than how they feel. Conversely, less confident kids may struggle to voice their frustration and, instead of rebelling, can become overly dependent on their parents’ approval. This may result in difficulty setting their own goals and can lead to a struggle to achieve a healthy level of independence later in life.

Critical Without Appreciation

Another area where Executive parents struggle is their emphasis on success over learning “how to learn.” True learning is often a product of failure, which is a hard concept for many parents to grasp. Kids who struggle in math class that, through hard work and time with a tutor, manage to raise their grades from an ‘F’ to a ‘C,’ are learning. Parents who overly focus on success in the form of all ‘A’s on their report card, may not view their children’s ‘C’s as proof of learning, regardless of the great strides they’ve made.

All children are different, and their unique talents, skills, and abilities should be taken into consideration before others criticize their shortcomings. Executive parents can be quick to point out faults in their children’s performance or behavior. They believe that addressing these issues is more important than appreciating or acknowledging their children’s strengths and achievements. They may think, “They’re already getting good grades in English, so why should I worry about praising them for getting an ‘A’ on their paper? I expect that.” This can have a devastating effect on children who feel

their parents only see their faults. They may become withdrawn or start acting out – believing nothing they can do is good enough to please their overly critical parents, anyway.

Rebalancing School-Age Parenting

Constructing Values Together

As much as Executive parents may want their children to succeed in specific areas, it's more important they focus on promoting their overall well-being. They're very devoted to their principles, especially responsibility and duty, as well as their children. Using their devotion, these types can create a definition of success that embraces a more holistic idea of what success truly means. Determining and promoting their personal principles can help them guide their kids toward developing their principles and pursuing their definitions of a successful life. Here are some steps Executive parents can take to do this.

- Executives can start this process by looking at institutions that have played an important part in their lives, such as their faith, their family, or even their alma mater.
- Once they've determined the sources of some of their principles, they can extrapolate the values they learned or developed because of their experiences with those institutions. Their faith may have provided them with a policy of honesty, their family may have instilled a deep sense of responsibility, and an alma mater may have helped to develop their value of hard work.
- These parents may identify dozens of principles that are important to them, but for this process it's best to focus on three to five principles they'd like to emphasize for themselves and their children.

- Once selected, Executive parents should define how they can personally practice and model these values. A sense of responsibility can be both practiced and modeled by taking their children with them to volunteer at a soup kitchen.
- They can practice hard work in their career, but an effective way to model it to children who don't see what they do at the office is to work on a project with their kids. Projects could range from restoring an old car their children may someday drive to learning a language together in preparation for a family trip to a foreign country.

Discovering and acting on such principles can be a daunting process. There are so many outside factors – such as teachers, peers, and even media sources – telling people what they should prioritize. It may be difficult, but Executives who take the time to engage in this process with their children won't only promote their positive values, they'll likely grow closer to their children as well. Once they've gone through this process, parents can rest assured they've done what they can to raise competent, confident children with a firm sense of what they value.

Finding Thyself (12–18 Years)

During this stage of development, adolescents are transitioning from childhood to adulthood and developing their distinct sense of identity. This centers around their understanding of what their roles are in their relationships with themselves, others, and society in general. To determine their roles, teens can begin the all-important process of identifying their personal values and beliefs. Future education and career goals can be made, and relationships can be developed based on how they align with these values and beliefs, making this a pivotal stage for the rest of their lives.

Balanced Adolescent Parenting

Promoting Positive Principles

During this stage of identity development, adolescents need the support and understanding of their parents more than ever. Executive parents can encourage their teenagers' growth by promoting such positive principles as responsibility, integrity, and reliability while providing a stable and loving environment. Although they may struggle with gradually decreasing the amount of control they exert over their children, Executives are still interested in assisting their sons and daughters in the process of personal development to the best of their ability.

Regardless of the struggles they may face during this tumultuous time, these types can remain patient and steadfast in their devotion to their children. Their reliability, both in their attention and promotion of their kids' positive principles, can provide a solid framework that allows identity-seeking teens to venture further into self-discovery while still feeling a sense of stability and love.

Honest and Dependable

As Holden Caulfield, the protagonist in J.D. Salinger's classic novel, *The Catcher in the Rye*, points out, there's very little that adolescents hate more during this idealistic stage than phonies. Executives also loathe dishonesty, and are at their best when they can provide frank, forthright information. Their no-nonsense approach, applied not as criticism but as a way of responding to questions and giving advice, makes teens feel like they're being treated more as adults, and with more respect.

If these parents can maintain this same frank, yet patient pragmatism when their kids come to them with something dire – getting pregnant, getting suspended or

expelled, or even a rough breakup – they can establish themselves as a dependable source of stability and wisdom when their children need it most. As chaotic and terrifying as some of these situations may seem, Executive parents can tap into their confidence and dependability and focus on aspects of these situations on which they can follow through.

Unbalanced Adolescent Parenting

Overly Traditional

Parents with the Executive personality type may have difficulty accepting certain aspects of their children's newfound identities during this stage. Their strong principles often coincide with a preference for "traditional" roles, and teenagers who push the boundaries of these roles too dramatically could both shock and frustrate Executives. Making sure their children's values align with their personal and family principles is of utmost importance to them.

They base their expectations of childhood on their past experiences, and societal changes that take place with each new generation can be both confusing and frustrating. Their adolescent children may appear almost unrecognizable as they attempt to determine if the principles and traditions they were raised with truly represent who they hope to become. With their principles challenged, Executives may believe that their children have abandoned their values, making them feel as though they have failed as parents.

Intolerant and Unforgiving

Executive parents can be both intolerant and unforgiving of the mistakes their teens are bound to make. While all parents struggle with the challenges presented during

the adolescent years, Executives can effectively shut down their relationships with their children with their lack of tolerance. Experimentation is prevalent throughout this stage, with adolescents doing anything from trying alcohol to engaging in sexual activities. While they must establish firm rules, these parents must also be open to forgiving their teenagers' indiscretions and focus on helping them learn from mistakes.

Criticism and constant reminders of any missteps they may have made can certainly breed resentment in their sons and daughters. Rather than forgiving their transgressions and helping their kids deal with the resulting consequences of their actions, Executives may focus on holding those mistakes over their children's heads as reminders of their failure. Often, they believe this is the best way to be sure that their teens won't repeat these mistakes. Unfortunately, unconstructive criticism comes across as mean and unfair at a time when children most need understanding and context to help them learn from their struggles.

Rebalancing Adolescent Parenting

Modeling Personal Growth and Understanding

Understanding is vital during this stage, as their children's needs can change, and their independence can grow with each year. Constant rebalancing of responsibility and expectations are required as adolescent children strive to become more capable, responsible, and mature. It can be difficult for Executives to decrease the amount of control they exert over their kids – not necessarily because they view them as incapable, but because they genuinely believe they know best. It's helpful for parents at this stage to encourage their children to develop their own personal values – here are some ideas Executives can try.

- While they can draw from family values to do so, kids should be allowed to privately focus on embracing values that are meaningful to their individual journeys.
- Most importantly, Executives can take such opportunities to engage in some self-reflection as well, perhaps even taking time to rediscover old hobbies, find a club or class to join, or become more involved in a community group or project.
- Modeling is the best way to pass principles and values to children, and parents can benefit from focusing on their personal growth, showing what productive, happy, and responsible adults do with their time.

Engaging in Active Listening

Finally, Executive parents should practice listening to their children's needs, thoughts, and concerns in open, non-judgmental ways. Adolescents who are struggling to define themselves need understanding and acceptance in addition to the boundaries their parents provide. Mistakes and failures promote growth, and parents can use them as learning opportunities instead of points of criticism. Executives can use active listening provide both the support that their children so desperately need as well as the stability and structure they naturally exude.

- Actively listening to their teens and withholding comments and judgments – especially while their children are speaking – is the first step toward understanding.
- Withholding judgment can be difficult, especially when Executive parents feel they “know what’s best.” However, taking time to see things from their children’s perspective, and remembering how different that view is thanks to their ages and unique personalities, is an incredibly important skill to develop.

Teens who feel accepted for who they are can gain the confidence necessary to face the many challenges their future can undoubtedly hold.

Conclusion

Parenting is one of the most challenging experiences that anyone can face, regardless of their personality type. Executives have unique strengths and weaknesses they can leverage to build positive, proactive relationships with their children. There's tremendous potential for personal development that takes place when becoming a parent, and Executives can gain a much deeper understanding of themselves and others if they use this opportunity to do so.

The advice provided above is based on general growth stages for children and basic strengths and weaknesses that many Executives share. All children are different, and parents are the best judges of what their children need. The advice above should be used in ways that work best for each family without adding additional stress, frustration, or burden. For special situations, such as behavioral or medical issues, it's best to consult with professionals such as pediatricians or pediatric psychologists to come up with plans that can work best for everyone involved.

Additional Tools and Tests

Want to dig even deeper into your role as a parent? If you have access to the toolkits area of the website, we offer a variety of additional tools and tests to help you explore.

[Parenting Styles Test](#)

Whether you have children already or hope to become a parent in the future, this test offers you useful insights into your parenting style.

[Type Guesser \(Parent\)](#)

Are you trying to figure out what personality type your parent belongs to? You may find that this simple tool helps.

[Type Guesser \(Child\)](#)

Are you trying to figure out what personality type your teenage child belongs to? You may find that this simple tool helps.

Academic Path



Executives learn best in environments that apply the following three principles: structure, efficiency, and pragmatism. They thrive when these three principles are combined in the classroom – but are likely to struggle if even one is absent. By identifying their strengths and weaknesses, they can become very effective learners.

How Executives Learn

Structure

Students with this personality type prefer instructors who clearly define themselves as the leaders of their classrooms. Executive students trust their teachers are there because they have proper certification, training, and experience. In turn, they dislike classes being handed over to the students, such as those heavy on group discussion and opinion.

Executives' ideal instructors set goals and clear objectives, but if they feel it's necessary, these types set their own. Even if the tasks assigned are routine and

repetitive, they don't mind if there are clear reasons for them. They thrive on timelines and benchmarks they can achieve through dedicated studying.

Efficiency

Unlike other personality types, studying is something Executives do *very* well. They utilize traditional learning methods like rote memorization and flashcards and are likely to dedicate time outside the classroom to mastering the topic at hand. Their ability to sit down, study, focus, and then execute what they've learned is unmatched by most other types.

This laser-like focus is attributable to this personality type's no-nonsense attitude about work. Executives strive for excellent results – while fun-loving and sociable, they take their studies seriously. Perhaps the quickest way to irritate these students is to goof off or slack off when there are important tasks to be completed. They demand competence from themselves and aren't afraid to demand it from others.

Because Executives are so focused on their work, they're likely to leave emotions at the door. This doesn't mean they're unaware of others' emotions – they're likely to pick up on peers feeling sad or angry – but caring about them is more of a delayed reaction. How they and others feel comes second to accomplishing goals, and Executives are honest and don't sugarcoat this. When criticized in turn, they don't view it as a personal attack. If anything, they'd be more uncomfortable with doing something wrong and no one correcting them to “spare” their feelings.

Pragmatism

In academics, their overall goal is to one day occupy stable, prominent roles in society. Often, this means a traditionally revered career – doctor, congressperson,

and editor-in-chief – or as leaders in broader fields such as mathematics, communications, and the physical sciences. They also understand that opportunities are more readily available to students who graduate from well-established universities. This drive to one day be traditionally successful is the source of their strict study habits and focus while they're young.

Executives scan for how things “should” be, and are adept at spotting inconsistencies and failings. They're likely to find conflicting topics like art, philosophy, and other liberal arts subjects to be less appealing – these types don't relish debate for its sake in the same way as Analysts. If they do find this material interesting, they're still reluctant to pursue it, given their pragmatic focus (the exception is history, for its usefulness in understanding its modern-day context.) Regardless of their opinions on these subjects, however, they tolerate them to honor academic requirements. In any environment, Executives always work to deliver reliable results. They strive to be diligent students, no matter how uncomfortable they may feel.

Balanced Learning Habits

Fulfillment in the Community

Executive students learn so they can be contributing members of society. These exacting types take pride in supporting the established order and do what's necessary to keep things stable. They build on the foundation society deems successful, try to fit into their culture, and help mend things where they can. They learn what is necessary to fill an existing gap or follow a path that society considers not just acceptable, but prominent.

However, they understand that while it's important to meet societal standards and expectations, it's equally important to fulfill their personal needs. This can manifest

in adults who are active community leaders, but also take time for an hour-long, once-a-week cooking class to learn how to properly braise a turkey.

Responsible Work Ethic

Executives subscribe to a rigorous work ethic and are known to keep working without breaks. They dislike the idea of not fulfilling their commitments and obligations (even if they didn't ask for them) and don't dismiss deadlines lightly. They complete all necessary tasks with diligence.

They also are likely to acknowledge the importance of good health to a balanced life. These students do what they can to turn in excellent work, but avoid pulling all-nighters and skipping meals. They evade such self-sacrificing methods by creating schedules that commit the effort needed to succeed, but also to eat and relax.

These students also aren't against letting loose occasionally. Executives take their duties very seriously but are happy going out with friends, even the night before a class, if the outing is reasonable. This is especially the case if the course is an elective they already have a good grade in. As the saying goes, "Everything in moderation, including moderation." Even if they allow fun to infiltrate work at times, they can rest easy knowing that the education system rewards students like them.

Allowing Innovation

Proud to be reliable, competent students, Executives achieve this by working within pre-existing structures and following traditional methods. This doesn't mean that they're completely against the unconventional – just that they take it with a grain of salt.

In the classroom, these types experiment (or allow experimentation to take place) with new methods if they show promising results, plausibility, and the likelihood of being better than their current ones. Despite their reluctance, they can find balance with the understanding that innovation sometimes leads to better things.

Unbalanced Learning Habits

Rigid Learning Style

Executives adhere strongly to well-established concepts and vetted learning methods. They may even go so far as to completely reject innovative methods, mostly to avoid the frustration they're likely to provide. Instead, they may rely on well-practiced techniques, with all the efficiency of experience, rather than something new and untested that shows promise.

This unbalanced approach can lead to a struggle with changing circumstances and expectations in teaching styles or subject material. Physical science courses may be a natural fit for these students: they establish base principles, then build on them procedurally in organized ways. However, if teachers cancel lab days, switch to “cooler” experiments at the last minute, or make other unexpected changes, Executives may struggle to keep up.

If they take it too far in this unbalanced manner – and decisive minds certainly can – these students may reject entire fields because of one bad experience with an inconstant instructor.

Learning for Status and Expectations

There are two broad types of motivational focus – internal and external. Internal motivational focus is based on what people want from life, while the external type is

based on what society tells them they *should* want. If students follow the latter to the exclusion of the former, their personal needs remain unfulfilled, leaving them educated but hollow. Executives who ignore classes they find interesting just because they don't fit their chosen majors can miss out on hobbies, friends, and even some resume-builders that show a range of interests – a surprisingly essential component of the interview process.

Expectations can emerge from internalizing a lifetime's external demands of meeting goals set for them by others, or from the real-time needs of family, community, and even school officials. They may lose their sense of independent decision-making, or even lose their characteristic decisiveness later in life. Adhering to expectations may work for some Executives if the demands aren't too exacting, but rigid and excessive expectations can lead to disappointment and perhaps the loss of a sense of individuality.

Both obligations and expectations give a sense of certainty, and there's rarely any doubt about how people should conduct their lives in their presence. But this assurance can come at a high price for Executives: a life lived more narrowly than needed, and experiences missed along the way.

Rebalancing Learning Habits

Learning for Personal Fulfillment

When weighing what they want against what society tells them they want, Executives may prioritize the latter. This unbalanced approach can lead to them feeling unfulfilled and, at times, resentful. To avoid this, these students can try these steps toward focusing more on meeting their internal needs.

- They can start by taking courses that are fun but “unnecessary” to their academic career. This should be doable, as these types aren’t afraid of occasionally bold moves if they’re sensible as well. They’ll move cross-country – for a lucrative career. They’ll buy a house – that’s well-priced in an otherwise expensive neighborhood. They’ll get married quickly – if they meet the person of their dreams). When changes make sense, they’ll take the leap.
- When it comes to academic boldness, granting themselves happiness is sensible, too, as everything else hinges on it. They might learn about a subject they thought was interesting in elementary school, yet also ties into their general course requirements. Having an interest in the stars when young can translate to fulfilling a science requirement with an astronomy course, even if their major is accounting.
- By making small changes, Executives can gather the courage to take a particularly big leap – like going to a university they enjoy but isn’t particularly prestigious. They can even reason that society’s expectations demand self-determination and flexibility – and what better way to prepare than by using their interests to diversify academically?

Growing for Efficiency

Accepting innovation is what allows growth. From growth comes experience, which ultimately leads to efficiency. However, Executives tend to subscribe to the idea of, “If it’s not broken, don’t fix it.” They may be unwilling to try new methods to shake the foundations of their academic career, whether they be alternative studying habits, allowing another student to take charge of a group project, or even changing their major.

To grow, to explore, and to continue learning, Executives need to become comfortable with the idea that “new” isn’t synonymous with “inefficient.” They shouldn’t be afraid to test out whether that new high-tech calculator is as good as their old, faithful TI-83 rather than immediately writing it off. They could audit a new course and decide afterward if consequent courses in the discipline are a good fit for them.

It’s the fear of failure or frustration that stops Executives from exploring. Remembering that failure speaks only for what’s explicitly tried, not for all things new, reveals a way of thinking that more broadly applies the value of learning. Rejecting learning experiences because they’re hard just isn’t a balanced approach to knowledge. However, wise Executives also know that when they do fail, it can be an indication that it’s time to move on.

Executives in High School

Even as teenagers, Executives are typically ideal students. They have an unmatched work ethic, are dedicated to turning in excellent assignments, and enjoy learning within the constructs of an established institution. While other students are off sulking or clowning around, these types flourish in the structured learning environment that is high school.

Executives tend to be “leaders of the pack” in high school – being mother hens in their social group, or taking control of team projects in class. As teens, they’re more likely than their peers to know what they want from their academic career, and how to achieve it. Their assertive nature can be a powerful tool in the high school arena.

However, they can be intolerant of those who don't conform. Another area to work on is their strict adherence to the belief, "Working time is meant for work." Because of this, they may not fit into the more fun-loving high school scene and may avoid most teenage rebellion, an underappreciated phase of establishing independence.

In high school, Executives may benefit from their need to meet expectations. However, this benefit could also be their most significant challenge.

Balanced High School Learning Habits

The Path of Least Resistance

Efficiency is one of Executives' greatest strengths. They see a problem, gather information, decipher the clearest path to implementing the solution, and then do what they can to execute the plan. In high school, this could look like something small – studying for 30 minutes each day after school for a test that's two weeks away to achieve optimal results. On a larger scale, it could be deciding to be class valedictorian because it can make them more appealing to their dream university.

Executives, even in high school, actively avoid time-consuming obstacles, especially long arguments. While they're comfortable with confrontation, they're more comfortable with cooperation. They pick the path of being caring and patient with their classmates, even if it can be just as easy for them to steamroll others. The reason these students do this can be summarized in the adage, "You can catch more flies with honey than vinegar."

Arguing over moot points or dealing with a classmate's hurt feelings, instead of focusing on the project at hand, isn't appealing to Executives. That's why they choose

to walk the path of least resistance by considering the emotions and viewpoints of others, even if it appears more difficult at the moment.

Peeking Outside the Box

These students excel within systems that enforce structure and rules. This is why high school, in all its regimented glory, can be an excellent place for Executives. However, it takes a balanced approach to understand that life outside the walls of their school is far more complicated than third-period social studies ever let on. They know that for all their strengths, there are also weaknesses that have the potential to worsen after graduation.

To cover their bases, these masters of working “inside the box” can decide to peek past its confines and consider the option that other methods can be more effective. Executives aren’t closed off to the idea that their way could be wrong, but what they do need is proof of it.

In high school, this manifests in these students taking a moment to consider the perspective from opposing classmates, or testing out new subjects rather than just assuming they won’t like them.

Levity in the Classroom

Executives have a reputation for being killjoys, but that’s not the case at all. They can be as fun-loving, silly, and bubbly as anyone else. Things become an issue when it comes to work and play – where others want to mix the two, Executives don’t. Therefore, they can be easily irritated by classmates who goof off rather than focus on the task at hand, while classmates may think they’re too buttoned up.

Executives with a balanced approach know that work and fun can coexist. While they're focused on getting the job done, they also understand that others don't have the same sort of tunnel vision when it comes to work. Rather than following their inclination to say, "Forget it," and plow through all the work themselves, they instead figure out a way to communicate in a mutually beneficial way. This isn't to say that they let things slide easily. They can allow a short amount of time for peers to joke and laugh, before gently reminding everyone that there's a task to complete.

Unbalanced High School Learning Habits

Doing Only What's Expected

Executives are dutiful and committed, driven to meet the expectations placed upon their shoulders. While this often works in their favor, it can also turn against them. They may be so focused on meeting requirements they miss out on doing things they enjoy.

Being good students involves meeting specific benchmarks, but it's also about finding joy in what is learned. Unfortunately, these types may find that they've lost that joy on the path of meeting others' expectations. Take, for example, those consumed with studying for a standardized test. Of course, they'll do well and earn stellar scores that qualify them for college. But they'll also wonder if any of the information learned has any personal value. This may be more the fault of the education system than the students, but Executives have an obligation to themselves to learn beyond what society tells them is important.

Since they run the risk of not discovering things they enjoy, they may never let themselves find their passion or specialize while they're still in high school. This, in turn, could lead to steeper challenges in higher education or the workplace. While

there's nothing wrong with taking the well-tread path, Executives should take care to understand themselves.

Rigid Responsibility

One challenge that Executives face in high school is that they possess a certain rigidity. When it comes to work, these students leave their emotions at the door and expect others to do the same. They may see explanations from their peers as contemptuous excuses.

When they have an unbalanced, hard-nosed approach to school work, Executives may have trouble with their fellow students. Since upholding standards is a large part of their motivation, seeing other students disregard rules or even take breaks may upset them. There can be mutual frustration – these types can see their peers as lazy and unwilling to work hard, and peers can see Executives as uncompromising, perhaps even as bullies.

Even when they don't intend to push their peers around, that's how it appears when well-intentioned Executives try to force their work ethic and standards on others in an unbalanced manner.

Fighting for Control

Executives like to manage things, but what happens when they encounter those who don't want to be led? Students with the Executive personality type may opt to make others conform to the best of their ability – or cut them out entirely. This unbalanced approach can play out in many ways: harsh criticism, strict exclusion, or merely finding reasons to report out-of-sync students to their teachers.

These types can't see why others wouldn't want to go down the established path. They may even see it as an insult to their competency, reliability, public image, and sense of fair play. This unbalanced approach can lead to their taking offense that they should work so hard and others so little, while everyone manages to pass in the end. Executive students can be swift and harsh in venting their frustrations.

Rebalancing High School Learning Habits

Utilizing Patience

Because teenage Executives take their work seriously, they may feel frustrated with the ruffians and slackers in class. They may think to themselves, "Why can't you just do the work?" or "Is it so hard for you to sit quietly in class and listen?"

If troublemakers genuinely disrupt Executives' learning or the learning of others, they're more than capable of letting their irritation be known. Before acting, though, they should consider the perspective of the disruptive students, or their outside situations, and then decide if there are issues to address. The disruptors' actions could be due to misunderstandings or miscommunication, or they might be acting out or missing deadlines because of complicated home lives. Always keeping patience in mind, Executives can try the following when dealing with problematic classmates.

- They can channel their pragmatic fairness when distributing the work, and holding others accountable with clear goals.
- They can also make group study a priority, which can help keep others on task by creating a sense of group purpose.
- Opportunities for mentoring, and the chance to offer a plan with mini-goals to keep everyone on track, can also help.

Mixing Work with Play

These students want to make sure there's a distinction between work and play. For Executives, the goal is often the only thing that matters during a project, and they find those who aren't willing to work toward the goal just as quickly or efficiently to be extremely aggravating.

To balance this, Executives can factor some downtime into their studies and group work. Suggesting 15-minute breaks for every 45 minutes of work is a good start. Studies have found that most people have a hard time concentrating on their work after 30–45 minutes and that continuing past that time can lower productivity and work quality. This isn't just a matter of work ethic, but a valid limitation of the human brain.

Despite this fact, Executives are inclined to push past their limits, even taking on others' work. However, doing this isn't fair to young Executives, or to the other students who then miss out on opportunities to learn (or fail) for themselves. Setting up a group plan creates natural accountability measures, and can help Executive students maintain a lower-stress approach while still getting results.

Beyond Expectations

Young Executives operate well in areas where expectations are clear, and they work diligently to perform for those they care about – parents, mentors, teachers, friends. They place immense pressure on themselves to succeed for themselves and others. However, there's a vast world of unique expression beyond the boundaries of these underlying cultural assumptions. Clinging tightly to expectations can be both limiting and exhausting. The high school years can start the journey of self-discovery that

lasts a lifetime, and releasing the grip of expectations can strengthen the early stages of this discovery process.

Consistently impressive performance according to standards is a good thing. But to grow, students with this personality type also want to balance this by adding activities they enjoy. The high school environment allows them to begin building a sense of who they are, and to find personal passions. Below are some questions to find out what those passions may be:

- As a child, I thought of becoming_____.
- Most people don't know this about me, but I enjoy _____.
- I am the go-to person when my friends need help with _____.

Once there's some sense of what fills high school Executives with a sense of purpose and enthusiasm, they can begin to explore in practical ways. They might talk to a guidance counselor about what activities correspond with their interests. They can join clubs where there are enjoyable activities and like-minded individuals. Finding others in the community who might be willing to mentor them – a guitar teacher or ski instructor, for example – can give them access to a skill, but also someone more experienced in general.

In high school, even steadfast Executives are likely to change their minds and their professional aspirations. Interests aren't permanent, particularly in adolescence. These students can give themselves permission to be flexible as they decide directions and passions. Having a sharper image of who they are as people, both through self-awareness and experience, they can start to determine what meets their goals: the workforce, or higher education.

Work or College?

Go to college, or go into the workforce? This fork-in-the-road decision plagues all young adults as they prepare to leave the swaddling comfort of high school. While personality type isn't the only factor that goes into making this choice, it can be an important variable. The question many Executives have is whether it's more practical to enter a trade early to begin establishing their lives, or to bolster their future security by obtaining a degree.

Core to their consideration is cultural expectations, especially regarding what they perceive as societal success. They can find themselves hard pressed to defy a family full of college graduates. If the choice is available, they're more likely to pick prestigious (but perhaps expensive) universities over more economical community colleges or trade schools – unless those options are themselves part of family or community pride.

Either way, it's important for Executives to know that they have choices available to them. So, what are some things they may consider when making this decision?

Balanced Decision-Making

Understanding the Path

By the time their high school graduation rolls around, many teenage Executives decide on what careers they want to pursue. If positions that meet their career goals are immediately available – say, taking over the family restaurant – then they may jump in. Using the same example, they're also just as likely to balance taking over the family restaurant while taking business courses at the local university.

On the other hand, they're likely to go to universities that provide suitable learning environments for their ideal careers. If they decide to be, for example, a congressperson, they'll choose a school that's produced other reputable government officials.

Most importantly for Executives, a balanced decision is based on not only the school's societal standing but how they feel about it – not to mention the broader career path that pushes them there. Of course, they want to attend well-respected universities, but they also want to feel they can fit in enough to participate in their campus communities.

Understanding why they want to do what they're doing can also provide a more definite sense of what the future holds. Executives regard risk with some caution, but a balanced approach helps them realize when they've spent enough time considering, and when it's time to take bold action.

Unbalanced Decision-Making

Risk of the Unknown

The idea of leaving what they know for an unknown future can be terrifying, so Executives ground themselves in the established – but an unbalanced approach can take this too far. They may assess a situation, but assume anything new at all is risky, and find it lacking any assurances.

Fear of the unknown can force Executives into early, entry-level work and keep them there, whatever ambitions they may harbor. They don't necessarily stay because they want to or because they like their work. Instead, the choice of the road less traveled may seem too stressful, and they opt for the comfort of the familiar.

A risky path has no outcome that guarantees where they'll end up, and they don't know if they'll waste their resources pursuing something that means nothing in the end. The risk Executives fear is that they won't succeed – or that, in their success, they won't be able to rise to new responsibilities. Home and work may appear to be safer harbors, and school as a mere hiding place from transitioning to the working world. They may choose safety, and consequently miss professional and personal opportunities.

Adhering to the Checklist

Risk and cost are both a part of growth. There's a difference between choosing prudently and choosing from limited options, and if a checklist becomes too rigid, the first can become the second. In their diligence, Executives may too quickly eliminate anything outside of overspecific criteria. Because of this, they may miss opportunities that can otherwise benefit them.

It may be important to remember that college, especially when entered in young adulthood, offers more than a diploma. It's often students' first exposure to independence, and those who move away from home learn to take care of themselves on a new level. Ideally, different institutions and programs encourage college students to think for themselves to varying degrees.

Keeping this in mind, Executives on a college tour (which they'll no doubt take) should choose a university based on how well they fit into the environment, and not just on the prestige of the institution. Ultimately, it's better to have a positive college experience that shapes them for the rest of their lives than just an Ivy League name to fall back on.

Selecting for Others

Executives may choose to go to college because it's traditionally the path family members have taken, or what their community tells them is the best route. Even if they have in mind a career that doesn't need a college degree, they may not want to go against the grain. They can foolishly spend time, money, and enthusiasm because of this.

When these students defer this decision solely to others' opinions, they set themselves up for passive roles in their own lives. Executives who don't include their independent opinions in their work or college decisions may be disappointed in themselves later and wish they'd taken a stronger stand. Denying themselves this first significant opportunity for deciding their unique life directions sets up patterns that can be difficult to break.

Rebalancing Decision-Making

The Value of Risk

There's a certain degree of perfectionism among Executives, and they may have it in their minds that failure just isn't acceptable. Their fear of risking the unknown is often part of protecting their reputation for success. Taking a reasoned risk is different from choosing a reckless one – it means taking action that could be rewarding enough to outweigh the chance of failure. Those who unshackle themselves from demanding perfection take risks necessary for greater rewards. Choosing their paths, despite the unknown, can lead to the reward of personal satisfaction.

Executives can take the following steps to unlink from perfection and excessive risk avoidance:

- *Make the unknown known.* While this is, of course, impossible to achieve one hundred percent, Executives can get a little closer by talking to people who have had different experiences with entering college and making choices about work or college. If real-time conversations aren't possible, there are over three million responses to the YouTube query, "Why I decided to go to college." For a more concrete look, examining job listing requirements in a desired line of work can provide a clear answer quickly.
- *Voice concerns.* Talk to a trusted someone who is likely to be objective. If still in high school, guidance or college counselors may be helpful. Older family members or family friends might be able to lend an ear and some of their experience. Those who listen may be able to offer solutions, examples from their personal decision making, or just provide an audience for venting.
- *Attitude check.* Examine personal attitudes about failure and what it means. Few failures leave a permanent mark – more often, they teach and show that people are moving forward and challenging themselves. By assuring themselves success – eliminating the risk of failure – Executives hold themselves back. This attitude is a choice, but by embracing future options, it doesn't have to be a permanent choice.

Allowing Checklists to Evolve

Executives' college checklist can be fraught with limitations, whether self-imposed or imposed by others. Expanding one's options is a creative act that reaches beyond assumptions and explores possibilities outside of the obvious. Executives are likely to protect their decisions and beliefs, and that's fine. But novel options might also fit into the list and expand it. Or, there may be completely different alternatives worth exploring. Either way, Executives working to rebalance must make the decision that

they owe it to themselves to explore all practical options, rather than assuming no others exist.

Executives can start exploring some options beyond the obvious by identifying a choice, and some beliefs about that choice. What makes this option viable? Why is it a choice to begin with? This list should be as detailed and comprehensive as possible.

With this analysis in place, they can ask themselves whether there are options worth exploring or beliefs that are useful that didn't make the cut. What would their opposite type – many of whom carry on very successful lives by any measure – come up with? It's possible that nothing practical may arise from this exercise, but it also carries minimal risk to try.

Finding Personal Value

One of Executives' best traits is that they're honest. If they honor this trait, it may temper the influence that outside forces have on their decision-making. Their internal motivations are likely to be more consistent over time, and being honest with themselves means finding answers within and aligning the best ones with society's standards. These students are more likely to find their unique directions if they consult themselves first, and it's the least they deserve after all their hard work.

When choosing a direction after high school, Executives can explore the following questions with one- or two-sentence responses, remaining as concise as possible.

- When do you feel most engaged and enthusiastic?
- When did you overcome a difficult challenge successfully?
- When have you felt you were "in the zone?"
 - What were you doing at the time?

- What were the principles you followed?
- What did you do to reach your goal?
- Did you feel personally satisfied by your accomplishment?
- Bearing in mind the challenges you face now (and possibly in the future), how can you build on what you know works?

Answers to these questions are likely to demonstrate Executive students' interests and passions, providing a place to begin exploring the future. Those who commit to something they believe in are likely to see it produce results more effectively. It's a relatively short step from discovering their interests to developing an action plan that uses them well.

Executives in College

College autonomy may disorient Executives at first, as it does most young adults. Separated from their friends and family for probably the first time in their lives, they no longer have the structure on which they've come to depend. This new independence places them out of their element, but this is likely temporary as they search out new benchmarks to pursue.

Balanced Approach to College

Conscientious and Responsible

Considering they spend their young lives looking for guideposts to direct them, these types can find structure in university life in the form of clubs, study groups, or campus positions. If they can't find an organization that meets their needs, then they can take it upon themselves to create one – a young accounting major who's

perturbed by the lack of community in her field can tap into her Executive traits and create an Accounting Society to bring accounting majors together.

Course choices in college are like the subjects these students chose in high school. They excel in any detail-oriented work that needs widespread delegation and follows established protocol, such as political science, business administration, engineering, and law. For them, subjects aren't nearly as important as their application and purpose. These types like the most direct path to their goals. Executive students aren't generally attracted to less traditional courses, so they're unlikely to be found in a women's studies course or a survey class of radical political movements. Their interests tend to lie in more bedrock courses – perhaps something their parents took a generation earlier.

These responsible students strive to set themselves up for success. Executives read, and even study, their course syllabi (unlike their peers) like religious manuals, and treat them as welcome frameworks to hang their college lives from. They avoid classes at eight in the morning if they know it's difficult for them to get up early. They turn in quality work exactly when it's due. In a sense, they trade in the rules of high school for an updated set of rules for college. Unlike many other types, they don't flounder in their new environment, but instead find the well-worn path that's worked for those who have gone before them, and begin their journey by following in their footsteps.

Gathering the Tools for a Good Life

Although some college students decide to party their four years away, this is far removed from healthy Executives' intentions. Their main reason for choosing higher

education is simple – to receive the certification or degree required to advance them toward their chosen career and carry out their life plans.

College is an arena for personal experimentation for some, but these students see it more as a hardware store from which they can acquire the tools needed to build a stable, steady future. They utilize college resources to the best of their abilities – campus services, career fairs, their professors, and, of course, information geared toward making advantageous academic choices. For them, college is all about forming strong foundations.

These foundations also include those of the social variety. Executives are inclined to join social communities – Greek life, for example – because the prospect of making strategic connections with their peers is very appealing. They don't do it for friendship, necessarily, but because it's another tool to utilize for success.

Unbalanced Approach to College

Lost in the Halls of Education

In high school, grown-ups carefully directed students' activities, but the autonomy found in college presents a sudden radical shift from such micromanagement that can overwhelm young adults. It's common for first-year students to succumb to feelings of depression and disorientation as they attempt to navigate the brave new world of higher education. It's reasonable to see why Executives may indeed feel like lost souls when pushed into this more unstructured environment.

In college, all work is in some sense independent work, and guideposts and supports are less available. For many of these students, it may be the first time no one's explicitly told them what to do. For those who are too dependent on external

structures, the early years of college can be painful and disconcerting. Executives hate feeling ineffective, and a challenging start in college may be indistinguishable from that feeling. If they aren't careful, it might set the tone for the rest of their stay.

Overload and Drudgery

In their desire to set solid foundations while in college, it's natural for Executive students to overload themselves. Whether it's the pressures of the school's requirements or the expectations they pile on themselves, sooner or later, those who haven't learned the art of balancing self-care and responsible behavior become overwhelmed and stressed.

In high school, their capability to stress themselves out may have been lessened by smaller workloads and fewer expectations. In college, however, Executives have free rein to express their perfectionism within their chosen courses and activities. They can also add stress to their lives by pushing for too much detail and making excessive demands of themselves. Such demands include not cutting themselves slack when they make mistakes, overworking to achieve and maintain high grades, and pushing themselves to meet high social expectations.

As the weight becomes heavier and heavier, Executives continue to smile dutifully, even as they begin to falter under pressure. Despite their compliant smiles, this stress can erode not only their effectiveness but also their morale. They're likely to push through and succeed anyway, but success drenched in stress may not make the ordeal any less miserable for them. Instead of a rewarding experience, their college years can soon represent drudgery and regret.

Rebalancing Their Approach to College

Finding their Way

Executive students tend to seek out the structure they need and find examples of success to use as precedents to follow. Finding their way may come naturally, but a lot depends on their maturity level. Younger students may need more help than older students entering college. But the truth is, it may be difficult for these stoic types to ask for the help they need at any age.

If Executives find themselves stressed out by higher education's lack of structure, they may want to make alliances with other students, preferably more experienced scholars. Some colleges offer mentoring programs where older students take new ones under their wings. Joining campus organizations can also be a place to see how others navigate the autonomy.

Reshaping Unreasonable Expectations

Just as they may have had issues with taking breaks in high school, Executives in college may be unwilling to deal with the root of their stress – meeting unreasonable expectations, like maintaining a perfect grade point average while taking a full course load of rigorous classes *and* working a part-time job. Any objective assessment would call such a schedule an unrealistic burden.

The first step to dealing with massive expectations is to acknowledge they've created an unreasonable situation for themselves. One simple way to check is to ask, "Would I ask someone else to do all these things? Would I wish this schedule on my best friend?" While they may project their expectations onto others at first, their more rational side is likely to give an objective answer. (The correct answer is that such

schedules can prove to be soul-sapping burdens which shouldn't be wished on anybody.) For Executive students, making realistic assessments is an important step in goal-setting.

These students suffer in silence because they believe they should be able to handle everything expected of them. They view meeting expectations, no matter how unreasonable, as a duty, so they grit their teeth and bear the pain. However, to be better-rounded individuals, it's necessary to understand that it's okay *not* to be okay sometimes. Pain, discomfort, and emotional stress are early warning systems that alert people to change course or suffer further damage to their well-being. Executives help themselves when they learn to treat these warnings with respect and heed the information they provide.

Becoming literate in the language of one's feelings can be as simple as raising awareness. One method involves setting random alarms on phones or watches to go off at unexpected intervals. When the alarms sound, make a note somewhere with the answers to two questions:

- "What is my current feeling?" Discouraged? Tired? Hopeless?
- "What is the feeling telling me?" The feeling of discouragement can foreshadow an impossible afternoon filled with too many arduous tasks.

Many dutiful people learn to ignore their feelings. Bringing them back into the conversation can help Executives deal better with unreasonable expectations and consider their well-being more often.

Lifelong Learning

For Executives, “learning” is very much about gaining applicable real-world skills to create and maintain stable lives, including serving the people and organizations they respect in improved ways. These types tend to continue to learn if doing so supports the lives they hope to build.

Balanced Lifelong Learning

Reaching Outside the Comfort Zone

Mature Executives recognize that there’s knowledge outside of the scope of their experience and education. To become better at what they do and who they are, they understand they may need to increase their knowledge from time to time. There may be occasional reluctance because learning means change, and that isn’t always comfortable for them. However, with experience comes the understanding that growth takes place outside of one’s comfort zone.

Having Time to Learn

As these types get older, obligations grow and time becomes a precious commodity, making it easy to become completely swept up in maintaining what they’ve built. Finding time to learn something – even if it offers a tremendous benefit – can become challenging. Making time to become “better” may seem like a luxury.

Executives who carve out time in their busy lives to pursue new information or skills can make themselves more effective, and perhaps their lives more enjoyable as well. While work and personal obligations are important, so is finding room to incorporate new skills into their everyday routines. Novice cooks may need to take some time out

of their day to learn the skills to produce nutritious meals at home from scratch, but the health benefits and enjoyment factor can make it all worth it.

Learning New Skills to Complement Old Lives

Executives don't learn new things for the sake of novelty, but because they can apply them to practical aspects of their lives. They take the time to examine life and wonder how they can enrich it for both themselves and the people around them.

This preference for practical learning can manifest itself in pursuits like taking an automobile maintenance course so they can handle minor car issues on their own. Or, by picking up carpentry, they can create simple furniture pieces to pass on to their children. If they learn how to grow a vegetable patch, they can use their produce in healthy meals.

Enrichment learning may seem like “extra” to many busy Executives, but such pursuits add texture and dimension to lives, and, when balanced, without interfering with effectiveness. It's not about novelty or an attempt to tamp down boredom. It's about taking a good life and making it even better.

Unbalanced Lifelong Learning

No Time for Learning

Those who decide they're too busy to learn something new may be robbing themselves of personal and professional growth. In this changing world, neglecting professional development can mean the loss of a promotion or even a job. (Losing a job would certainly solve the problem of being too busy.)

As far as personal growth, one of the issues that Executives often face is the vague sense that they're just cogs in a machine. Some lose their sense of individuality and, consequently, personal value. Learning the right things can help them distinguish themselves from others and give them a stronger sense of their uniqueness.

Settling and Stagnation

These types often choose contentment and reject change as a threat to it. When deciding on a direction in life, they may decide against something new as a way of leaving "well enough alone." Unless there's a very compelling reason to take a course or to pursue a new direction in learning, they may forego it to protect what they know. What others see as a type of stagnation, Executives see as a form of maintenance. They may not see the value of disrupting their routine by learning to grow a garden – there's always the supermarket, just where it's been for years. Shaking up their predictable lives with new information can be difficult and perhaps even threatening.

If their level of contentment is high enough, they might believe that there's nothing else of value for them to learn. They may question what they need to add to the lives they already respect and value. Consequently, they can miss out on so much.

Rebalancing Lifelong Learning

Finding Time to Learn

Time may be the most significant obstacle in Executives' academic development, with other obligations distracting them from learning. However, it's important for these types to carve out time and put themselves first on occasion. Creating space for self-care can help lower stress and improve their overall mood. Taking time to grow in

stimulating ways can be a healthy part of a stress management program. They can begin by committing at least an hour a day to learn or practice a skill they enjoy, incorporating the hour into their routine.

- Those who like to relax and watch television for a couple of hours at night can also use that time to practice knitting or sewing. (It may take an additional hour or two to learn the technique.)
- College level courses are now streamed through many devices and can be entertaining – learning and relaxation available in one place.
- Crafty people teach artistic and artisan skills throughout YouTube. It's a miraculous age for pursuing lifelong education, and it's rare that an hour or so can't be found to enlarge a life. There are many ways for the willing individual to fit learning and growth into even the busiest day.
- There can also be a social aspect to learning, and the right classes might involve meeting new people and making it well worth finding an hour a week to learn. Single Executives may be especially interested in this aspect. Combining one's social life with learning (or vice versa) can deliver two wonderful things in one package.

Varying the Routine

Being “set in your ways” isn't necessarily a bad thing. However, there's always room for improving upon an existing routine. Executives can begin this by picking a relatively mundane task – take, for example, a walk. Rather than taking the same path every day, they can choose a different way every other week – a walk on a forest trail, a walk through the city, a different route through the neighborhood. Even a small variation can loosen up the tight grip an existing routine has on life and begin to open new vistas of learning.

Using their small excursions, Executives can then adjust their routines based on what they liked or disliked. They can decide in the end not to change their old routine at all if that's what suits them better. Or, they apply this exploratory spirit to other parts of their lives. There's always a new experience to have and new things to learn. It doesn't have to be earth-shaking or life-changing. Learning can be beneficial without being too disruptive.

Conclusion

Education can mean a lot of things to a lot of people. For Executives, it's a way to advance their goals in life and contribute to society, but it can be so much more if given a chance.

The challenge isn't so much in the hard work of learning. It's more managing expectations and finding a reasonable pace so that learning doesn't become soulless drudgery but a rewarding experience. For Executives, such balance involves blending their sense of duty with expressions of their unique selves – a balance that's entirely achievable.

Additional Tools and Tests

Want to dig even deeper into your academic path? If you have access to the toolkits area of the website, we offer a variety of additional tools and tests to help you explore.

[Thirst for Knowledge Test](#)

What is your interest in gaining knowledge? How does your desire for learning affect your life? This tool will help you explore that.

[Academic Exploration Test](#)

Do you ever wonder what areas of study might suit your personality? Find out which subjects might be the most satisfying for you.

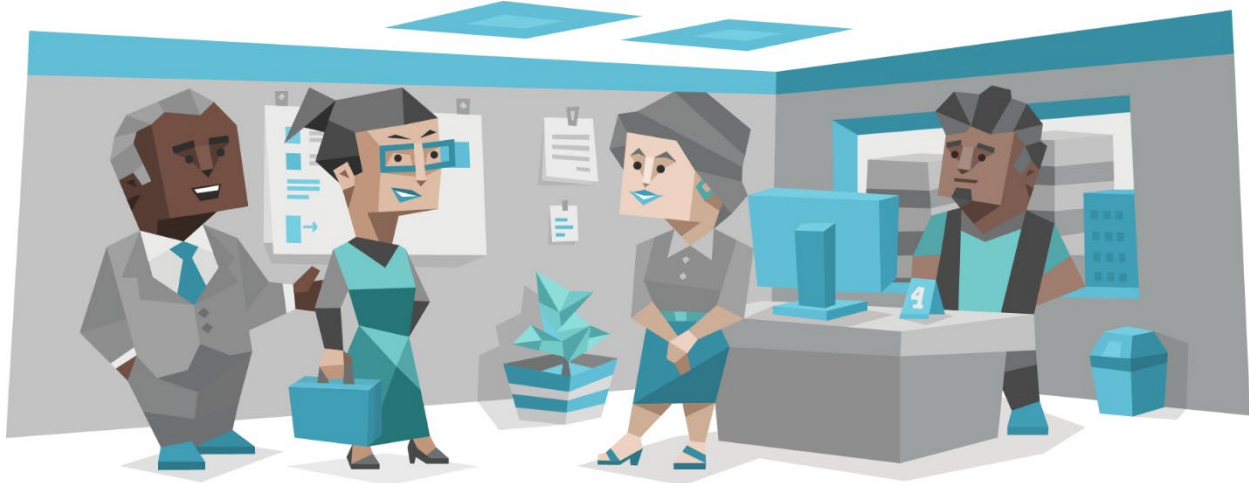
[Perfectionism Test](#)

Perfectionism is a desire to be remarkable and outstanding in everything you do. Let's see what role it plays in your life.

[Type Guesser \(Academic\)](#)

Are you trying to figure out what personality type your classmate belongs to? You may find that this simple tool helps.

Professional Development



Designating these types “Executives” wasn’t something done casually and, indeed, it fits them well. In business, executives (small “e”) organize, delegate, and ensure that groups meet goals successfully. Whether as the heads of major companies, small department managers in tiny businesses, or as directors of entrepreneurial enterprises, Executive types shine when they shape goals and lead others toward their completion.

This doesn’t necessarily mean Executives must only do jobs with words like “executive” or “manager” in the title, but they do find themselves most at home steering endeavors toward success. Regardless of their actual job titles, they always possess a drive to meet goals. Often, Executives start in the rank and file of companies, and then work their way into leadership positions. To everyone else, this transition can seem sudden and effortless, but Executives know that it was likely something they strategized to achieve. However fast it happens, they earn it.

Mission Accomplished

If Executives have a catchphrase, it would be a triumphant, “Mission accomplished!” Nothing is more gratifying for them than guiding their crews from concept to reality. They analyze a goal, break it into the tasks needed, and organize their teams to deliver. As Observant types, their targets are realistic and concrete, and they know when they meet them because Executives design their goals with clear metrics in mind.

However, these types won’t micromanage beyond a loose strategy. They focus more on the outcome than the means. How their teams arrive at a goal isn’t as important to them as reaching it. They cautiously choose trusted people to join them, and because they expect much from their well-chosen teams, others can expect much from Executives.

Focus Over Feelings

Those with the Executive personality type may come across as so focused on tasks that they neglect the feelings or welfare of others. They can appear hard-nosed and uncaring, but in many cases, nothing is further from the truth. The jobs they choose and the styles they adopt aren’t always “warm and fuzzy,” but from their perspective, professional growth and success is something they believe they share with the people in their lives. Providing material benefits for themselves and the members of their group means a lot to these types.

Under their sometimes stern exteriors dwells a healthy impulse to make their world a better place for the people in it. Executives are natural team builders and work best in this context. In their enthusiasm to meet goals they insist their teams do their best,

and sometimes this necessitates taking a strict stance. Their intent is benevolent, and their goal is to coax others to do better.

Jobs and Skill Sets



Let's look at some specific jobs that tend to fit Executives well. This list is by no means comprehensive, as these types can succeed in any career they choose. By the same token, even "suitable" jobs may not be ideal for all Executives. Individuals must determine what careers are the most appropriate for them, including what meets their needs and brings them both professional fulfillment and personal happiness.

Suitable Workplace Roles

There's no definitive list of jobs that fit any type exactly, and exceptions always exist. However, this short list of industries shows where typical Executives might feel at home. It provides an excellent place to start thinking about potential areas of professional interest.

These jobs provide Executives with opportunities to exercise their strategic and analytical skills. Each requires a strong work ethic, and many involve a focus on projects and project management.

- Logistics
- Office Administration
- Asset Management
- Accountancy and Audit
- Law
- Military
- Data Analysis
- Medicine and Hospital/Clinic Administration
- Education (Particularly administrative positions)
- Banking and Finance

Less Suitable Workplace Roles

Just as there's no limit to which careers Executive can enjoy, there's no specific area they cannot. However, certain jobs may present compatibility issues, and it's not always about what industries they choose as much as their roles in them. For example, empathetic hand-holding outreach on the front lines of a substance abuse treatment organization might strain this type's skillset, but they can absolutely shine in a clerical or organizer role in the same workplace. Likewise, their patience might be stretched when dealing with customers in a restaurant, but as a line cook or head chef, they may be a force to be reckoned with.

Executives have a mighty energy and often see things in very clear-cut terms, so environments without clearly defined rules or hierarchies can be frustrating.

Anything that requires these types to constantly juggle irrational vagaries, uncontrollable results, or hyperbolic emotion may be unpleasant. Executives thrive in systems, even if they must craft these systems themselves, so an environment that doesn't support structured ways of doing things leaves them little place to invest their energy. They're usually happy to give abundant effort to an employer, but if their enthusiasm is stifled in any way, it may rankle them – all they want is a chance to succeed with vigor. Some work environments Executives may want to be wary of committing to include:

- Jobs with no clear path of promotion or advancement.
- Jobs which reward employees based on arbitrary factors rather than objectively measurable performance.
- Teams without a clear authority figure or arbiter.
- Workplaces with lax discipline (rules that are stated but not observed), especially with weak management.
- Workplaces unwilling to implement improvements
- Jobs without tangible productivity goals – Executives prefer benchmarks for their success.
- Workplaces with an excessively psychosocial or emotional atmosphere – Executives may want to avoid a “high school” environment where personal feelings and “he said, she said” gossip are rampant.

There is no job in which Executives cannot excel if they choose, but choosing wisely according to their personal preferences and strengths can make the process a lot easier – and much more enjoyable.

Workplace Cooperation Between Roles

Understanding how Executives tend to behave is one thing – getting along with myriad colleagues effectively, across a variety of personality types, is another entirely. Now we'll dig deeper to determine how Executives can best find happiness and efficiency with their coworkers.

Executive–Analyst Cooperation



Executives and Analysts share a rational approach to life and find they have much in common in the workplace. Executives are likely to use their analytical leanings to create precise goals along paths that others have already established. Their Analyst coworkers scan for ways to improve systems and methods, and are likely to see their endeavors as challenging puzzles needing to be solved. While Executives may not have the same interest in the broader vision, they eagerly latch onto Analysts' visions if they end up where they want to go.

Balanced Executive–Analyst Cooperation

The Same, But Different

Stepping back and looking at these two types from a wider perspective, Analysts are likely to create the mold into which Executives eventually fit. They like to shake up systems and frameworks to make them better. However, much can be said for stability, and Executives can play a role in taming change that's too haphazard or scattered. They slow things down enough to allow the people involved with the system time to adjust to change. One offers a broader way of thinking. The other domesticates it to fit the real, practical world.

Moderating Influences

As moderating influences, these two types can contribute to each other's work in significant ways. They're both interested in meeting goals effectively, essentially sharing the same vision, which adds value to their work relationships. Cooperation between them is the product of accepting they both offer something of value that leads to the same end – effective outcomes.

Where Analysts offer innovative solutions and visions, Executives are masters at organizing their implementation and bringing them to reality. A sincere collaboration between these two personality types is a crossroads where ideas become achievements and old ways transform into more effective new ways.

Unbalanced Executive–Analyst Cooperation

Experimentation and Caution

Tensions are likely to mount if Analysts change things too casually. Executives prefer proven solutions, and they need time to test new ideas before accepting them. These types see anything too original as introducing chaos into their trusted strategies. Analysts, however, are less likely to focus on the risks associated with experimentation. They may even indulge in experimenting simply for its own sake, providing no measurable contribution to the goals at hand. Consequently, Executives are likely to reject them soundly.

Executives may label Analysts as loose cannons with wild ideas. In turn, Analysts might think of Executives as uptight enemies of innovation. When they frame their relationships as adversarial rather than collaborative, they can stop being useful to each other, and the larger enterprise becomes weaker due to lack of cooperation.

If one type is subordinate to the other in Executive–Analyst work relationships, either type maintaining a stubborn allegiance to a particular focus can be problematic. Automatically taking a position without giving a full hearing to any alternate views can be counterproductive. Very real and negative results may happen when there's a power difference, such as a lack of promotion, a lack of basic respect, low morale, and even job loss.

Overabundance of Rationality

Despite their aforementioned differences, Executive–Analyst work partnerships still pair two very similar types. Both rely on rationality. Effective solutions motivate each

type. Both are capable of neglecting the more human aspect of their endeavors in favor of accomplishing determined goals.

Neither of these types is humble in their approach to life. Without a devil's advocate, these types can potentially barrel down the wrong path, tapping into each other's confidence and siphoning off energy and support. Executives stand firmly in their convictions of the right way to do things, while Analysts often flaunt their intelligence. Either form of pride may close off any input from third parties, denying them some valuable information.

Rebalancing Executive–Analyst Cooperation

Breaking a Stalemate

If Executive and Analyst coworkers find themselves in conflict too often, they may need to define for themselves what the other offers. In the heat of battle, it's easy to downplay the value of coworkers who aren't in agreement. Reminding themselves of each other's value may restore balance. But more than a "touchy-feely" approach, these types need to quantify real results or potential results for each to take this assessment seriously. Doing so not only breaks the stalemate, but can also help these coworkers revisit some strategic human resource possibilities they might have forgotten.

Here is one way these types can approach chronically contentious relationships at work:

- Take an inventory of each other type's success (or measurable movement toward success.) This inventory should be real profiles in productivity and not

merely a list of qualifications. Reciting qualifications may impress, but they don't necessarily speak to effectiveness and results.

- Once the inventory is complete, review how much of the material on the list is still relevant to future work and goals.
 - What have these Executives (or Analysts) done, or are doing well, and how can this be applied to the job at hand?
 - Where do these coworkers' interests overlap?
 - How can they strategically tap into each other's skills or strengths to be even more effective as a team?

In the busy workaday world, it can be easy to forget things that were once appreciated. Sometimes it takes a moment of paying attention again to rebalance a team.

Bringing In Fresh Perspectives

When Executives and Analysts become too insulated by their similar styles, they need to discover methods to open their shared processes. Actively seeking out a wider range of ideas can help craft a more robust strategy. In-house town hall meetings that are open to all can expand points of view (if they're in a position to organize them), or simply eating lunch with a wide variety of people can accomplish the same.

It's easy to develop stereotypes of people with different approaches and dismiss them based on those stereotypes. When this happens, the best-case scenario is that it's done unconsciously. However, sometimes individuals more actively reject others based on differences. Executives and Analysts who develop an "echo chamber" at work can examine any stereotypes of others and explore their biases. Rounding out

their ideas with the varied ideas of others, even if it makes them uncomfortable at times, can contribute to their general effectiveness.

Executive–Diplomat Cooperation



The Pragmatic Doer Meets the Idealistic Dreamer

In classic advertising, there's an old aphorism: "A good ad sells the sizzle, not the steak." This distinction is sometimes apparent when Executives and Diplomats work together. Executives manage the steak, which deals with an essential concrete product or service. Diplomats add the human element and strive to touch the emotions or sensibilities of coworkers, consumers, or clients, thus providing the sizzle. Executives ground Diplomats in the reality of concrete tasks and measurable goals. Diplomats, on the other hand, help Executives experience the more "human" features of an endeavor. When the pragmatic doer meets the idealistic dreamer, interesting collaborations can occur.

Balanced Executive–Diplomat Cooperation

Complementary Perspectives

Another useful dynamic when Executives and Diplomats work together is also a common feature when Intuitive types team with Observant types. Executives prefer dealing with specific details and concrete realities, while Diplomats pull back and engage the sometimes less tangible big picture. Understanding this difference, each balances the other with equally valuable perspectives.

While Executives are busy with quotas and hard numbers, Diplomats can remind them of things like employee morale and alignment with company missions statements. Both can be vital perspectives needed for creating well-rounded success. Learning to incorporate both into a single endeavor can promise more enduring triumphs.

Unbalanced Executive–Diplomat Cooperation

Realistic versus Idealistic

To Executives, Diplomats' approach of catering to the emotional needs and sensibilities of those impacted may appear to be quirky and "soft." Such lofty idealism may seem outside the scope of their practical goals. Meanwhile, Diplomats may see Executive pragmatism as hard-hearted and lacking in empathetic connection to those in their orbit. Executives, in their opinions, are cold guardians of a rigid system. Either may roll their eyes whenever the other expresses things that give them their strength and employable value.

Clashes can occur when Executives pursue efficient and rational directions, but their plans cross Diplomats' sense of right and wrong. Because they focus on outcomes

more than processes, Executives can become baffled when intangibles like fairness and job satisfaction influence Diplomats more than hard metrics. Diplomats can obsess over processes if they believe they impinge on the rights and welfare of others to any extent.

It all comes down to degrees of emotional intelligence. Diplomats are fluent in the language of emotions and treat them as being greatly significant. As social creatures, Executives are surely familiar with feelings, but aren't as fluent as Diplomats and they don't allow them to have the same impact that Diplomats do. Diplomats feel comfortable making decisions based on affective considerations, while Executives are less inclined to do so.

Attention to Detail

Conflicts can arise between these types over either their respective attention, or lack of attention, to detail. If some coworkers appear 10 minutes early for work, and others are 10 minutes late, it's easy to guess which are Executives and which are Diplomats. It's not that the Diplomats purposely thumb their noses at the system by rebelliously arriving late. It's just that the item "arrive on time for work" may not top their unconscious priority list. However, there's no doubt that punctuality is high on Executives' list of priorities.

These differences aren't limited to arriving on time. There are many ways they show up in a workday, such as protocols, for example. Diplomats are more likely than Executives to ignore the chain of command. If they see an opportunity to advance their humanistic agenda, they can take it right to the top rather than send their idea through their more immediate supervisors – possibly knowing it might be tabled at

that level. Jobs are unique in the protocols and details they emphasize, and while you can count on Executives to honor them, Diplomats can treat them more loosely.

Executives rely, in part, on rules, protocols, and exacting behaviors as parameters to use in defining their purpose and direction. As managers, they may be unwilling to cut tardy Diplomats any slack. Diplomats may view Executives' response as "nitpicking," condescending, and lacking substance. If these Diplomats are subordinates, conflict can rise to a substantial level that includes reprimands and perhaps even termination. If the two types are on a peer level, their respective styles of handling details can be endlessly annoying and strain their working relationships.

Rebalancing Executive-Diplomat Cooperation

Searching for Common Ground

People sometimes draw cartoonish, two-dimensional profiles in their minds to represent others they don't fully understand. Multidimensional Executives and Diplomats are more alike than not. Many of their goals are likely similar. While their differences may occasionally impact their ability to work together, they're both values-based individuals, even though their principles take somewhat different forms of expression. In the end, they both come to work to earn a paycheck and fulfill their ambitions.

Executives want to create a stable world where they can live responsibly, take care of those they love and respect, and meet the material needs of all. They may not always verbalize it – instead, they opt to demonstrate it. Diplomats, likewise, seek an idealized version of this, where people realize their potential and have all their needs met. For them, it's physical, spiritual, and emotional, and they may wear their hearts

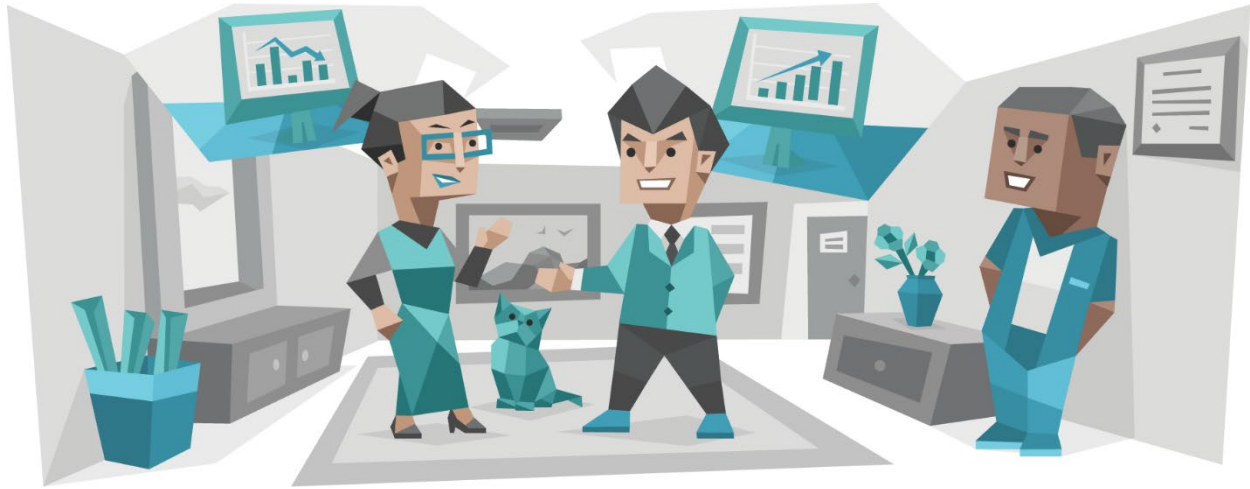
more prominently on their sleeves. Essentially, it's the same desire approached differently.

Toward True Cooperation

Reframing their approaches as different paths to the same results can help Executives and Diplomats restore any lost cooperation. To accomplish this, each must recognize there's no superior path to the results they seek. Each potentially contributes in valuable ways. (The amount of such valuable contribution isn't determined by type alone.)

Working together, the two types can practice active listening, so they comprehend fully what each other is saying and has to offer. There's no room for dogmatism. Declaring, "This is the right way to do it," or "This is the wrong way to do it," without some understanding that there can be options outside of this binary choice is likely to kill collaboration with Diplomats. However, Diplomats offer their own binary choices based on moral right or wrong. Active listening – with the goal of understanding all nuances – helps dispel black-and-white thinking. Broader understanding opens the door to genuine cooperation between these types.

Executive–Sentinel Cooperation



Working with other Sentinels appeals to Executives' pragmatism, a characteristic shared by all types in this Role. With Sentinel peers, they can avoid some of the issues they face with less practical colleagues.

Balanced Executive–Sentinel Cooperation

Sharing a Sense of Mission

Executives and other Sentinels honor efficiency, details, and protocols. These mutually supportive relationships reinforce and respect each other's diligence. As Executives ascend (as they typically do) to leadership roles, they can rely heavily on other Sentinels to help them meet their goals. They can feel confident their Sentinel cousins understand their objectives, and this like-mindedness can foster a sense of cohesion.

Executives and Sentinels, sitting together in the lunchroom, tend to discuss down-to-earth matters. Their conversations flow easily because they share fundamental values. Work is serious business to both types, and among other things, they can

discuss how projects are progressing. They can talk about the strengths and weaknesses of their coworkers. (They may base their judgments on coworkers' effectiveness, but they're just as likely to measure them against set company standards.) These discussions revolve around "what is" rather than "what if"– topics about concrete matters that lead to material results steer their conversations.

Sharing a Sense of Style

Whether they're leaders or not, Executives find other Sentinels similarly attached to successful outcomes. They share a belief that the path to superior results is clear and direct. If they're problem-solving, they might prefer using Occam's razor as a guide – *the most straightforward solution with the fewest assumptions is to be considered first.*

For example, if the number of widgets produced in a day is too low, they may look at the physical machinery and assembly process before they consider more complex things like morale, production algorithms, and other less concrete considerations. They may eventually need to consider intangibles like morale, but if there's a simpler answer, they're likely to discover it quicker than types who are more likely to spend time considering complex solutions first. In other words, their shared pragmatism rules their evidence-gathering and decision-making, often to their advantage.

Executives and Sentinels obviously think in similar ways, narrowing any potential gap between stylistic approaches. Without Executives having to translate their style, as they would with a type which employs a different process, their work with other Sentinels is more streamlined.

Unbalanced Executive–Sentinel Cooperation

Inflexibility Breeds Boredom

Like-minded coworkers can be a pleasure. However, they can also help create an insular environment. Pairing with a similar type can also result in a tedious abundance of the same thing. For Executive–Sentinel collaborations, the tedium plays out mainly through their established expectations and lack of flexibility.

Aegis of Standards

While embracing established methods promotes stability, being unreceptive to new ideas bodes poorly in the modern business world. Few businesses have remained as they were 20 years ago, and they'll be unrecognizable 20 years from now. Too many Sentinels in a room can potentially slow down innovation – and, consequently, productivity – to a snail-like pace.

Executives and Sentinels may support each other in rejecting necessary innovations. They can show an intolerance for others who introduce unorthodox methods too quickly. Executives can approve of even the most novel concept if they're confident it brings positive results. However, too much combined Sentinel reverence for tradition can render new ideas and methods a threat to their established ways of operating, at least initially.

Leaders who depend on those too similar to themselves may discover such advisors are a cluster of “yes men” who are less likely to offer constructive criticism or useful pushback. The costly luxury of having a room full of like-minded individuals can lead to a lack of needed change. Welcome to the dreaded echo chamber.

The Problem with Occam's Razor

While the simplest solution is often the best, Occam's razor falls short when more complex solutions are needed. Eliminating the simplest solutions first can be time-consuming and ineffective, especially when answers are urgently needed. When there's a tyranny of style, with an Executive-Sentinel majority insisting on their concrete methods, there may not be enough intellectual diversity.

Obviously, this isn't about an ancient problem-solving principle that Sentinels might prefer. It's about the value of different approaches. As mentioned before, there are various tools for different jobs. Too much dependence on a single personality style leads to inefficiency and lower productivity. It goes even beyond the previously discussed "yes men" to the problem of stagnation caused by shutting out other necessary talents.

Rebalancing Executive-Sentinel Cooperation

Opening the Discussion

Support from Sentinels can empower Executives, but so can recognizing such relationships have limits. Helpful alternatives may exist just a step outside of Executive-Sentinel coworkers' comfort zone. Here are some things both types can keep in mind as they take that first step together.

- Rebalancing may be as simple as considering a current set of options may be too narrow and making a deliberate decision to add diverse voices to the conversation. In fact, sometimes the best collaboration occurs between those with opposing ideas.

- Inviting dissenting voices to the table is difficult. People enjoy others agreeing with them. However, if dissent is needed, an invitation isn't usually required – they're probably already there. They may be sitting silently in the background because of a rigid work culture. Sometimes, they're simply ignored.

Creating a more accepting environment or developing an individual attitude of openness can bring these devil's advocates out of the shadows. When Executive- and Sentinel-dominated groups prioritize the search for right answers over the comfort of being agreed with, valuable alternate voices begin to feel welcomed.

Experience New Methods

It may not be enough to open themselves to new ideas – it can take learning new methods of looking at things or adopting new techniques and skills. Executives are fairly facile at accepting the new, but Sentinels as a group like holding on to methods they know, and can influence their Executive cousins.

Executives who spend too much time with fellow Sentinels at work can avail themselves of training opportunities that explore new methods and techniques whenever possible. Discovering the riches to be found in the constant flow of new technologies alone can continuously enrich the skills of Executives and other Sentinels.

Executive–Explorer Cooperation



It's easy to get the impression that Executives and Explorers are complete opposites. Executives are likely to view Explorers as impulsive and irresponsible. Explorers likely see Executives as rigid and unadventurous. These might be unbridgeable gaps between the two types if they didn't share a deep respect for practicality and mutual attention to concrete matters. They both gather information from the world more directly and are less encumbered by the theoretical, with which they have little patience or interest (although they may claim they do.)

Balanced Executive–Explorer Cooperation

Practical and Tangible

Executives and Explorers most often complement each other when things go wrong. Executives look for results and solutions to problems. They aren't always concerned with the methods – as long as they aren't too unorthodox. When established procedures fail, and they call for improvisation, Explorer coworkers are irreplaceable. They think on their feet and are masters at solving everyday concrete puzzles, providing the results Executives desire.

Independent

Executives are expert delegators who prefer to either develop, or be part of, a team which someone winds up and releases to run like clockwork. This fits Explorers precisely, since they prefer to work without interference and excessive restrictions. They crave independence.

However, Explorers must earn their free rein from Executives – and, luckily, this resourceful personality type has little problem proving themselves to their managers or their teams. If left to their own devices, Explorers typically pour themselves into their work, paying attention to mastering the situation.

Unbalanced Executive–Explorer Cooperation

Tight Ship versus Free-Form Solutions

Executives may appreciate Explorers' clever, spontaneous solutions that save the day on occasion. However, there are limits, and they can reach a point where enough of Explorers' less-than-stringent regard for the rules becomes too much. Rules represent stability to Executives. There's nothing more important to them than their department's or company's ship remaining upright. Explorers who take too many liberties can begin to represent a serious threat to their overall steadiness.

If Executives are their bosses or managers, they can clamp down excessively on Explorers. Such excessive attempts to pull them into the fold and micromanage them can damage sound working relationships by ignoring the strengths Explorers bring. Tightening the reins may be an ill-advised solution.

Should Explorers be in charge, Executives can feel things are a bit chaotic. They may continuously look to their Explorer leaders to enforce order, and then deal with some

disappointment when they don't. Executives can lose respect for Explorer managers they view as being "sloppy" with protocols. They may even feel condescending toward their undisciplined superiors. Similar dynamics occur when there's a lateral relationship between Executives and Explorers.

Losing Autonomy

Executives can provide a strong tempering influence on Explorers' need for independence. But there are rules to follow, and if Executives sense a laxness on the part of Explorers, they may overcompensate by micromanaging.

When Executives challenge Explorers' autonomy, there's the possibility of failure on many levels. Constantly contentious relationships are never good in the workplace, and Explorers who feel trapped always look for ways around obstacles – or develop exit strategies.

Rebalancing Executive–Explorer Cooperation

Courageous Exchanges

Courageous Executives can look for ways to learn from Explorers' attitudes. Professional growth comes from trying things outside of their comfort zone, and Explorers' love of change, new stimulation, and independence can help Executives broaden their perspectives a little if they occasionally go along for the ride with them.

Likewise, Executives can help willing Explorers become more attuned to accepted procedures. Whether they approve of them or not, there are always established expectations in business. Executives can help them get a handle on them should they wish to climb the ladder to higher positions or take their job skills to new levels.

The Explorer Two-Step

Executives who work with Explorers can think of this experience as a kind of dance. Dancing with a partner usually assumes enough flexibility where each dancer anticipates the moves of the other, yet there's some structure maintained in their movements. The delicate dance of knowing when to assert boundaries and rules, and when to let Explorers try unorthodox moves on their own, is essential for Executives who work with them.

When it matters, Executives can enforce protocols. When it's not that important, they can loosen up a bit. Again, this doesn't mean a wholesale disregard for the rules, but Executives can find that, when it comes to Explorers, exercising a little more flexibility and taking a bit more of a risk can pay off at times.

Conclusion

Executives value their careers and professional experiences in profound ways. Organizing and goal-setting that result in solid accomplishments help them find meaning in their lives. While they may enjoy success and savor the perks that go with it, those are just ways of keeping score and highlighting their accomplishments. While they may want to remind others of their shared success, they remind themselves as well. On a deeper level, their primary concern at work is their contribution to their companies, their families, and their communities.

Those who learn to include diverse personality types and styles in their work lives find that they don't just add more talent to their collaborations. Learning their professional strengths and weaknesses, and those of other personality types, can help Executives find a way to navigate work and life more effectively.

Some have said that when individuals come to the end of their lives, they're unlikely to think of all the hours spent at work as a highlight in their personal journeys. This may be true for most, but it might not apply to Executives. For them, their work is likely to be a defining part of what they happily consider as their legacies.

Additional Tools and Tests

Want to dig even deeper into your professional development? If you have access to the toolkits area of the website, we offer a variety of additional tools and tests to help you explore.

[Job Preferences Test](#)

Among the most important things you decide in life is how you're going to make a living. Discover which job fields fit you best.

[Job Burnout Test](#)

We've all heard the term "burnout." But what does it mean to you? This test will guide you as you take a look at how burnout affects you.

[Career Values Test](#)

What should your job look like for you to call it "ideal"? What aspects matter most to you? This tool will help you answer these questions.

[Leadership Styles Test](#)

What is your leadership style? There is no right or wrong answer to that question. This test will help clarify your preferred approach.

[Leadership Styles II Test](#)

The second part of our Leadership Styles test will explore your desire to be a leader and willingness to delegate power.

Motivation Test

On average, we work for about 90,000 hours over our lifetime. With that in mind, it's helpful to figure out exactly what motivates you.

Ambition Test

How eager are you to succeed, and at what cost? Ambition can be a double-edged sword – explore how it works in your case.

Professional Authenticity Test

When at work, are you acting in a way that is consistent with your true self? Explore difficult questions about authenticity with this test.

Goal Orientation Test

What's the underlying motivation you feel when confronting a challenge? See which of the Goal Orientations influences you most.

Type Guesser (Workplace)

Are you trying to figure out what personality type your coworker belongs to? You may find that this simple tool helps.

Final Words



The Power to Help

Some Extraverted types like Executives often seek a pinnacle position for themselves, and given their drive and capability, it's not unusual for them to earn such status in life. But, a high place can be a precipice with unique opportunities and pitfalls; balance is required. One of the most worthy and balanced uses of power is to help others avoid misfortune and act on their own potential. Executives become admirable mentors and protectors when they unconditionally extend their energy and wisdom to others in aid instead of judgement.

Being a positive force takes commitment, and while emotional connections aren't always easy for Executives, they maintain a deep sense of dedication to their beliefs, including responsibility to other people in their lives. Sharing their energetic sense of practical efficiency is more than a personal ethic for these types, it's a form of love. Executives who become facilitators of well-being achieve more than just a high position, they gain genuine respect and appreciation, and a rewarding place in their community.

The Foundation of a Happy Life

It's not a bad thing that Executives love to establish order, putting things, events, and even their feelings into a context that makes sense. Creating a stable structure gives them a feeling of security, and a sense of continuity – when Executives organize life, they can see choices and consequences, and it gives them the ability rearrange things and change themselves for the better. These types benefits from a foundation of order not because they want to stand still, but because a firm stance lets them move powerfully – like a runner bracing before taking off.

There's nothing wrong with thinking that things should be a certain way, if that "should" reflects goals like freedom, happiness, prosperity, and love for themselves and those around them. For these types, a very important cornerstone in the foundation of a happy life is a balanced decision on what happiness looks like. Executives' drive is wonderful, but force itself doesn't guarantee happiness, as without harmony, it can lead to constant conflict. But, when Executives' vigorous drive and steely will are combined with respect for others – and their own feelings, needs, and limits – their potential for growth and happiness is limitless.

The Road Ahead

We've covered many different topics in this profile, and we hope that the chapters have offered insight and answered questions about the Executive personality type. We hope that readers will now find it easier to understand other people and their perspectives. This profile isn't meant to be read just once. When trying to understand another person better, or struggling to understand oneself, another read-through can offer fresh insight.

Furthermore, spend some time on our [website](#) – for example, by exploring our [articles](#) or [additional assessments](#). If you lead a team, our [Team Assessments](#) can help you understand its unique dynamics. There is a wealth of inspiring advice and information on the website, and we strongly recommend that you take a look. If you have some spare time, consider lending us a helping hand by taking additional [surveys](#) or simply [sending us a message](#) and sharing your thoughts about this profile or the website in general. We would love to hear from you.

We wish the best of luck to all Executives. What matters most in Executives' lives is that their paths through life reflect who they are, deep within. Reflecting on values, dreams, and ideals often reveals the right path through life by clearing out superficial distractions. Our lives are often too full of troubles, conflicts, and worries. By working to better understand each other, we can make our relationships, communities, and world more aware, more genuine, and more peaceful.

Until next time.

Addendum: The Puzzle of Personality

Often the very first question people ask after completing our personality test is “What do these letters mean?” We are of course referring to those mysterious acronyms like INTJ-A, ENFP-T, or ESTJ-A. As you may have already learned from the Type Descriptions or articles on the website, the five letters of these acronyms each refer to a specific trait, with certain trait combinations forming various types and type groups. But before we discuss those traits in depth, let’s explore their historical foundations.

The Historical Detour

Since the dawn of time, humans have drawn up schematics to describe and categorize our personalities. From the four temperaments of the ancient civilizations to the latest advances in psychology, we have been driven to fit the variables and complexities of human personality into well-defined models. Although we are still some time away from being able to do that, the current models account for our most important personality traits and can predict our behavior with a high degree of accuracy.

Personality is just one of many factors that guide our behavior, however. Our actions are also influenced by our environment, our experiences, and our individual goals. On our website, we describe how people belonging to a specific personality type are likely to behave. We outline indicators and tendencies, however, not definitive guidelines or answers. Significant differences can exist even among people who

share a personality type. The information on this website is meant to inspire personal growth and an improved understanding of yourself and your relationships – not to be taken as gospel.

Our approach has its roots in two different philosophies. One dates back to early 20th century and was the brainchild of Carl Gustav Jung, the father of analytical psychology. Jung's theory of psychological types is perhaps the most influential creation in personality typology, and it has inspired a number of different theories. One of Jung's key contributions was the development of the concept of Introversion and Extraversion – he theorized that each of us falls into one of these two categories, either focusing on the internal world (Introvert) or the outside world (Extravert). Besides Introversion and Extraversion, Jung coined the concept of so-called cognitive functions, separated into Judging or Perceiving categories. According to Jung, each person prefers one of these cognitive functions and may most naturally rely on it in everyday situations.

In the 1920s, Jung's theory was noticed by Katharine Cook Briggs, who later co-authored a personality indicator still used today, the Myers-Briggs Type Indicator® (MBTI®). Briggs was a teacher with an avid interest in personality typing, having developed her own type theory before learning of Jung's writings. Together with her daughter, Isabel Briggs Myers, they developed a convenient way to describe the order of each person's Jungian preferences – this is how four-letter acronyms were born.

Of course, this is just a very simplified description of the Myers-Briggs theory. Readers interested in learning more should read *Gifts Differing: Understanding Personality Type* by Isabel Briggs Myers. As we define personality traits and types

differently in our model, we will not go deeper into Jungian concepts or related theories in this article.

Due to its simplicity and ease of use, the four-letter naming model has been embraced by a number of diverse theories and approaches over the last few decades, including frameworks such as Socionics, Keirsey Temperament Sorter, Linda Berens' Interaction Styles, and many others. While the acronyms used by these theories may be identical or very similar, however, their meanings do not always overlap. One of the reasons behind such a lengthy introduction is that we want to make it clear that there is no single definition assigned to these type acronyms – each theory defines them in their own way and it is entirely possible that if you meet five people who all say “I am an INFJ”, their definitions of what INFJ means are going to differ.

Types vs. Traits

Regardless of its structure, any type-based theory will struggle to describe or characterize people whose scores lie near the dividing line. A different way to look at personalities is through the lens of a trait-based rather than a type-based model. What do we mean by that? Instead of creating an arbitrary number of categories and attempting to fit people within them, a trait-based model simply studies the degree to which people exhibit certain traits.

You may have heard the term Ambivert, which is a perfect example in this case. Ambiversion means that someone falls in the middle of the Introversion-Extraversion scale, being neither too outgoing nor too withdrawn. Trait-based theories would simply say that an Ambivert is moderately Extraverted or moderately Introverted and leave it at that, without assigning a personality type.

A trait-based approach makes it easier to reliably measure correlations between personality traits and other characteristics – for example, political attitudes. This is why trait-based approaches dominate psychometric research, but that’s more or less the only area where these approaches are dominant. Because they don’t offer types or categorizations, trait-based theories don’t translate as well as type-based theories into specific recommendations and takeaways. Assigned categories such as Extravert or Introvert may be limiting, but they allow us to conceptualize human personality and create theories about why we do what we do – something that a more scientifically reliable but colorless statement, such as you are 37% Extraverted, simply cannot do.

Our Approach

With our NERIS® model, we’ve combined the best of both worlds. We use the acronym format introduced by Myers-Briggs for its simplicity and convenience, with an extra letter to accommodate five rather than four scales. However, unlike Myers-Briggs or other theories based on the Jungian model, we have not incorporated Jungian concepts such as cognitive functions, or their prioritization. Jungian concepts are very difficult to measure and validate scientifically, so we’ve instead chosen to rework and rebalance the dimensions of personality called the Big Five personality traits, a model that dominates modern psychological and social research.

Our personality types are based on five independent spectrums, with all letters in the type code (e.g. INFJ-A) referring to one of the two sides of the corresponding spectrum. You can see where you fall on each scale by completing our free personality assessment, NERIS Type Explorer®. This approach has allowed us to

achieve high test accuracy while also retaining the ability to define and describe distinct personality types.

Five Personality Aspects

This section will describe five personality aspects that, when combined, define the personality type: Energy, Mind, Nature, Tactics and Identity. Each of these aspects should be seen as a two-sided continuum, with the “neutral” option placed in the middle. The percentages you would have seen after completing the test are meant to show which categories you fall under, and how strong your preferences are.

Let us now go through the personality aspects one by one:

Introverted vs. Extraverted

More Than People Power

When considering people who are Introverts (I) and Extraverts (E), it's natural to go straight to the more social aspects of these personality traits. However, they are more than this. These traits are also defined by their broader response to their environments, which includes other people but isn't exclusively about them.

Introvert (I) Personality

Strength in Reserve

Introverts are well-suited to many situations. A tendency to be reserved helps these personality types to pace themselves. They're likely to listen to others more carefully. Very introspective, Introverts enjoy more focused “alone time” – leading to more and

deeper insights. And, while sometimes too sensitive to their environments, this often helps them pick up cues more quickly, making them great at reading many situations.

However, this same reserve means that Introverts tend to find outside stimuli like noise, motion, or intrusive lighting frustrating. Some of this can be an invigorating change of pace – too much unsettles them and drains their energy. These personality types often prefer to be in their own space where they can adjust their environments. Add a human factor to this sensitivity – for example, insistent conversations where they're expected to be just as insistent – and it can exhaust them. They need time alone to regather their energy and restore their calm.

Introverts' reserved, more solitary nature presents challenges, as many societies favor Extraverts and their bolder approach. But it helps Introverted personality types to take things slowly, cautiously, and with less fanfare. Fortunately, if they're willing – and create the time to recharge on their own – most Introverts can handle society's strenuous demands.

In fact, many successful leaders and entertainers come from their ranks, often remaining humble and avoiding an unnecessary spotlight in fame. The Introversion personality trait never needs to disqualify those who possess it from pursuing a goal.

Extravert (E) Personality

The Power of Engagement

Extraverts are interested in engaging with their environment, and they feed off the responses of the people and events around them. They enjoy pushing limits and seeing what the world can do. This all depends on many other factors and life's

natural limitations, but Extraverted personality types lean toward taking the initiative and relying on the world around them for validation.

While all of this is noble and often admired in society, it can also become unbridled. Extraverts may put too much value in their engagement with those around them. Being with others can be so important to these personalities that they often find it difficult if they're stuck alone. Boredom comes too easily. This can lead them to do things simply for excitement rather than thinking through more subtle but important considerations. Becoming the center of attention – at any cost – might be too appealing.

However, when they suitably address these challenges, Extraverts are forces to be reckoned with. People with this personality trait tend to advance projects important to them quickly, whether personal or professional. They often choose to lead when given a chance – and can be dynamic in that role. Their outgoing energy can be vital to a social gathering, and their liveliness can be contagious. And there always remains a sense that people are important to them.

Intuitive vs. Observant

Thought at Every Scale

Our second personality scale includes the Intuitive (N) and Observant (S) styles. These traits describe what people are more likely to do with the information gathered from the world around them. Intuitive personality types rely on imagining the past and future potential of what they see. Those with the Observant style are more interested in observable facts and more straightforward outcomes. They prefer to avoid layering too much interpretation on what they see.

Being Intuitive doesn't mean someone can't be practical, and being Observant doesn't mean a lack of imagination. They both use their minds and their physical senses well. The difference is the spin they put on their experiences – it's where their thinking goes after an encounter with their environment. If Intuitive personality types appreciate Observant types' practicality, and Observant personality types appreciate Intuitive types' imaginative perspective, they can complement each other in ways that make for unbeatable partnerships.

Intuitive (N) Personality

Eyes on the Horizon

People with the Intuitive trait prefer to exercise their imaginations as they seek new ideas and possibilities. They live their day-to-day lives just like any other personality type. But while that's happening, their minds tend to point inward while at the same time gently focusing somewhere beyond the horizon. Their lives are ones of questioning, wondering, and connecting the dots in the "bigger picture," and they love the theoretical. They often ask, "What if?" and ponder the possibilities the future might hold.

But Intuitive people aren't always the most practical, preferring instead to give things deeper meaning. There may be a long wait as these personality types allow their imaginations free rein. They may also leap in too quickly to more complex matters. An entire theory can come together in moments, leaving others confused. In either case, they can appear out of touch to the Observant individuals in their lives. For some Intuitive folk, there may be some truth to this observation.

That said, when there's a need for innovation or a different perspective, people with Intuitive personality types can usually step up and provide a new direction.

Practicality can sometimes be overrated, especially when a situation calls for serious change and “coloring outside the lines.” This is where Intuitive people shine. They bring interesting dimensions to life beyond everyday ideas – and take those who decide to go along with them.

Observant (S) Personality

Do What Works

The phrase “real-time” was created with Observant individuals in mind. They’re most in touch with what occurs in front of them, in the present. This doesn’t mean Observant personality types have no regard for the past and future. But they view both from the perspective of how each influences their present actions. This makes them focused and practical people. They mostly root their thinking in the actionable, tangible, and useful. But make no mistake, these personalities can be creative within that realm.

One challenge people with the Observant personality trait may face is a too-narrow perspective. They may reject far-reaching solutions in favor of something more obvious. By continuing something that appears practical at arm’s length but doesn’t fit the bigger picture, they might reduce their hard work to busywork.

People with the Observant trait are often a steadying force that tends to get things done. Their energy is very “hands-on” in the sense of working on real things in real-time. While they’re often smart people, spending a lot of time sitting around and pondering possibilities doesn’t cut it for Observant personality types. They want thoughts and talk to lead to action.

Thinking vs. Feeling

How to Think and Feel About the Thinking and Feeling Traits

Our third, Nature scale reveals the extent to which we value emotions or rationality more when considering options. Does a person tend to use the Thinking (T) personality trait, which relies on the head, or the Feeling (F) trait, which relies on the heart?

But let's not oversimplify. Think of it instead as you might your hand preference: A left-handed person leans more heavily on their left hand, but they still use their right hand, albeit less. We can apply the same approach to a person with a dominant Thinking trait or a dominant Feeling trait – they aren't without some qualities of the non-dominant trait.

Thinking (T) Personality

"How Does This Help?"

When presented with a decision, people with the Thinking trait typically lean on objective information. Knowledge is their indispensable tool. Once these personality types gather the facts, they test their alternatives against logic and reason to see which decision, by those standards, proves the most effective or realistic. They generally manage their relationships by employing fairness and effectiveness as their primary method of dealing with others. Their passions are born of respect.

Whatever value people with the Thinking personality trait place on relationships, they can still dismiss emotional responses, either their own or those of others. This is often because of their discomfort with emotions, which don't always follow the rational path they value. Sometimes, emotions just puzzle them. But that doesn't

mean they have hearts of stone. They often feel in deep, profound ways – they would just rather not decide matters from that place. And, perhaps unfortunately, they may see those who do as weaker decision-makers.

Personality types with the Thinking trait are likely to evaluate things almost relentlessly. This isn't as bad as it sounds. They aren't satisfied if they believe something is not well thought out – they revel in the brilliance of an elegant plan. This makes them great to have around when critical thinking and impartiality of any kind is the focus, and this makes them immensely helpful for sorting out ideas and methods. Their primary filter is, *"How does this help?"*

Feeling (F) Personality

"Who Does This Help?"

People with the Feeling (F) trait follow their hearts and emotions – sometimes without even realizing it. They may show it to different degrees and in different ways, but however they do it, Feeling personality types tend to be caring, compassionate, and warm. These concerned people can be highly protective of those they care about – whether that is their immediate family or remote populations in need.

However, people with the Feeling personality trait often find they become excessive in their concern for others. They may easily burn out – or cause others to – when they become too involved. These emotionally aware individuals can become depressed if they feel they haven't been as selfless in life as they imagine they should be, or if those they have helped seem to fall down regardless.

Feeling personality types' concern for others typically affects all their endeavors. This can be practical and close, as with family, friends, and colleagues. Or it can be broader, as with world peace, ending hunger, and giving the disadvantaged a boost.

But this reliance on feelings doesn't mean there is no logic – theirs is just a different logic. They see that emotions can't simply be waved away, so feelings and the welfare of others shape their lives more than stark facts and cold objectivity. Weighing things this way makes these personalities valuable to have around when the big question is, “*Who does this help?*”

Judging vs. Prospecting

Crossing the Finish Line (By Whatever Means)

The Tactics scale, which includes the Judging and Prospecting personality traits, reflects how people plan and deal with the options they have. But this definition doesn't just concern what individuals write in their day planners. It's much broader. These traits answer questions like, “Do you prefer spontaneity or certainty?” “Do you feel more comfortable acting only with all your ducks lined neatly in a row? Or does a certain amount of flexibility or chaos excite you and prove motivating?” “Do you need more choices or fewer?”

Judging (J) Personality

Making Things as They Ought to Be

People with the Judging (J) personality trait feel most comfortable when the course ahead is well-marked. They would rather come up with five backup plans than deal with events as they come. Preferring to consider their options ahead of time,

personality types with this trait prefer clarity and closure, sticking with the plan rather than going with the flow. It's as if Judging types always keep a mental checklist. When they cross something off their list – or even start an item on their list – they consider it complete and not open to reconsideration.

The downside is, if they take this too far, those with the Judging trait sometimes come across as rigid. However, most are not unreasonably stubborn. It's important to remember their need for structure always is a preference and reality often calls on them to respond in unforeseen ways. Too many surprises in a row can leave these personality types frustrated and stressed. When this happens, they can still be relied on to develop a plan (and a contingency plan), but however well they handle the unexpected, they rarely enjoy it.

Judging individuals tend to have a strong work ethic, putting their duties and responsibilities above everything else. To them, rules, laws, and standards are the key to success. They can be too dependent on these measures, whether applied to themselves or others. But the intent is almost always one of fairness and results.

Prospecting (P) Personality

Figuring Things Out as They Go

Prospecting (P) individuals are much more flexible when it comes to dealing with unexpected challenges. This flexibility helps them seize unexpected opportunities as well. These personality types tend to react to their environments rather than try to control them, helping them to make their own luck in whatever the world delivers. People with this trait hold that life is full of possibilities.

All this opportunism can lead to impulsive decision-making, though. At the same time, they can be overwhelmed by the sheer number of options on their radar. People with the Prospecting personality trait can be slow to commit to something because of uncertainty or the potential of everything else. If they don't moderate this trait, indecision or a lack of conviction can be a problem. They can seem unfocused. What was important to them one week may be forgotten the next.

Despite those concerns, this personality trait can offer a great deal of creativity and productivity. Theirs is almost a stream of consciousness quality. In many ways, it's like these types are constantly brainstorming as their minds create a web of options. This can be a powerful tool for finding solutions. And if they aren't satisfied with something in their lives, it's easier for them to let go of it and choose something else. This can lead to serial passions that keep Prospecting individuals stimulated as they explore the buffet of choices always before them.

Assertive vs. Turbulent

Confidence, Achievement, and You

The Identity scale, made up of the Assertive and Turbulent personality traits, affects all other scales and indicates how confident we are in our abilities and decisions. Identity triggers the way we react to the things life constantly throws at us. How do we respond to success and failure? Criticism or feedback from other people? Unexpected events that suddenly change many things or everything? Even the unknown future?

Assertive (-A) Personality

Calm in the Storm

Assertive individuals are self-assured, even-tempered, and resistant to stress. They don't worry too much, but this is different from apathy. They aim for goals and want successful results, but they typically won't let nervousness color the path to their accomplishments. They're unlikely to spend a lot of time thinking about their past actions or choices. According to Assertive personality types, what's done is done.

However, problems may arise for them if their confidence turns into overconfidence. Assertive individuals may gloss over problems or details that can interfere with their goals and desired results. They may lean toward assuming all will be positive. Assertive people also sometimes presume they are free to do much more than others would allow or tolerate. If overconfident, these personality types may come to believe their confidence overshadows what others want.

But their confidence remains. It can help them move forward where others might hesitate. People with this personality trait report more satisfaction with their lives. They feel more assured of their abilities to handle the difficult and the unexpected. Through this lens, they often create the kinds of success that matter to them.

Turbulent (-T) Personality

Power of Stress, Activate!

Turbulent individuals are success-driven, perfectionistic, and eager to improve. They are always trying to counterbalance their self-doubts by achieving more. Just as they push themselves to become better, they're as likely to push their projects or efforts

in the same direction. Turbulent personality types tend to notice little problems and often do something about them before they become larger ones.

There are potential downsides to all this attention and achievement. Always feeling the need to do more, to have more, and to *be* more, Turbulent individuals can also get caught up in endless thoughts of criticisms, slights, or regrets. This can either bog them down or motivate them to do better. Their sensitivity to potential problems can be useful – unless that’s all they think about and the problems clutter their attention. Turbulent personality types may compulsively scan for what might go wrong instead of keeping their eyes on more positive targets – on what could go right.

Careful and attentive people are always important to society and keep it safe. At the same time, a fear of stagnation can bring about great change. Turbulent individuals beautifully cover both. When these personalities balance their worries and concerns with positive action, they’re likely to prove themselves to be of great value.

Type Groups

Now you know what each type consists of. But how do they fit together?

Our system has two layers: the first (inner) one defines our Roles, the second (outer) one – our Strategies.

Roles

Personality theory is a study of similarities among people with shared traits and how these traits might be expressed through behaviors and attitudes. Traits are the most fundamental part of our framework and include characteristics like Introversion or

Thinking. The next level contains personality types, in which four of the traits are combined and sorted to create 16 personality types. Roles, simply put, are the next level. At the Role level, the 16 types are divided into four groups.

Which personality types belong to each Role depends on two shared traits that they have in common. While all traits influence behaviors and attitudes, the two traits that determine a Role are shared by only four personality types and instill in them some unique, matching characteristics.

Those with the Intuitive trait (Analysts and Diplomats) are paired with the Thinking/Feeling traits because the Intuitive trait focuses on internal processes like thinking and feeling. While they may ultimately play out in the external world, they are primarily inward-looking.

In like manner, those with the Observant trait (Sentinels and Explorers) are paired with the Judging/Prospecting traits. Judging and Prospecting, while they have their internal aspects, are more likely to be played out in the external, concrete world of action and doing. Sentinels with their Judging trait are likely to bring order to their worlds, while Explorers with their Prospecting trait are likely to instill spontaneity into all the actions they perform.

The four Roles are primarily used when they are more likely to explain concepts in a clearer, less complicated way than involving all 16 personality types might. Using Roles this way is particularly warranted if the topic consists of a trait or traits that are a prominent part of the core traits of the various Roles – such as when Intuitive or Observant have a greater influence. But use is not limited to just that. They're like shorthand when Role commonalities suffice in talking about a subject.

In summary, Roles are just another level of the same theory, with each of the four containing four personality types. Those within a Role share a combination of two prominent traits and, therefore, share some similar characteristics.

The Role layer determines our goals, interests, and preferred activities. There are four roles:

Analysts – Intuitive (N) and Thinking (T)

Thinkers, Not Robots

The personality types in the Analyst Role – Architects (INTJ), Logicians (INTP), Commanders (ENTJ), and Debaters (ENTP) – are known for their love of rationality. Because they share the Thinking trait, these types often aim to make decisions with their heads rather than their hearts. But Analysts are far from being robots. Their Intuitive personality trait energizes their imaginations, helping them to come up with creative strategies and motivating them to explore things deeply – whether that’s an intellectual pursuit, a new interest, or even a crazy scheme or thought experiment.

These personalities are driven to understand and create. They have no problem switching between speculative musing and tactical problem-solving. Of course, these broad abilities need to be honed – and, when appropriate, they need to lead to action. Otherwise, Analysts’ active minds can give them a false sense of accomplishment.

These types often love ideas and speculation more than the realities of follow-through. As a result, they risk being outpaced by those who simply sit down and do the work. This can earn these types a reputation for being “armchair analysts” – and, at times, Analyst personalities may forget that they actually need to test their ideas in the real world.

Driven by Curiosity

Analysts are innately curious. This helps them to ensure that their ideas are workable, rather than just clever. These personality types have a strong drive to learn, and they want to find out things for themselves rather than accept received wisdom. These types may be found stockpiling books, questioning teachers, spurring debates, or driving conversations in forums across the Internet.

Analysts are also relentless self-improvers. Once they've recognized a flaw, they apply all of their rationality, imagination, and desire for results to make it right. Especially when it's balanced with self-understanding, this drive can enable Analyst personalities to push the boundaries of what's possible – no matter what anyone else may think.

Socially Selective

Analysts can have a reputation for being lone wolves. These personality types don't necessarily care about befriending everyone they meet, and they definitely don't surround themselves with random people just for the sake of having some company.

Given a choice between spending time with someone incompatible or spending time alone, many Analysts would choose the latter. And they may not be so subtle about it. 71% of people with Analyst personality types say they're good at shutting down unwanted conversations – far more than any other Role. This brusqueness can make Analysts seem rude, unapproachable, or antisocial, particularly to types that value social harmony.

That said, it's important to note that only 17% of Analysts actually describe their ideal social life as “mostly by myself.” Much greater numbers – 30% and 41% respectively

– say they’d prefer to have a few good friends or a partner and a few good friends. As a result, it’s inaccurate to view these personality types as antisocial.

Instead, it makes sense to view Analysts as socially selective. Like other types, they crave social connection. But these personalities won’t feel socially fulfilled by spending time with just anyone. They want to surround themselves with people who really get them – even if it takes effort to find those people. That might be why 46% of Analysts say they actively seek new friendships – which is more than any other Role except Diplomats.

Independent Minds

Analysts have little patience for following in others’ footsteps. 58% of these personality types describe themselves as “very independent” – far more than any other Role. Independence isn’t just a characteristic of these types – it’s an important part of their self-image.

This mindset shows up vividly in how Analysts approach academic and professional settings. These personality types are questioners, reluctant to take anything on faith. And “anything” includes what their teachers or bosses say.

From the outside, this might look like a lack of respect. In our Teachers Survey, Analysts were far less likely than other Roles to say they admired their past teachers. And this mindset persists in the professional sphere as well. 43% of Analysts in the workforce say they would be better than their boss at their boss’s job – again, far more than any other Role. Analyst personalities are also far less likely than other Roles to express admiration for their bosses.

But does this represent a lack of respect? Maybe – but this choosiness might well have other roots. Analysts tend to hold themselves to high standards, and they often hold the people around them (bosses and teachers included) to these high standards as well. In addition, Analyst personality types tend to care a great deal about learning and professional success. 85% of Analysts say they have a strong desire to be an important and successful person.

It makes sense, then, that these personality types hold their teachers and bosses to rigorous standards. After all, an Analyst with a poor teacher or boss may be less likely to become successful. Of course, Analysts – just like anyone – will almost certainly find themselves faced with a less-than-stellar teacher or boss. As a result, figuring out how to navigate these situations is an important part of their development.

Problems? What Problems?

You know who talks a lot about their problems? Not Analysts. In fact, 83% of Analysts say that most people complain too much about their problems.

But that doesn't mean that people with these personality types don't *think* about their problems, and they certainly don't shy away from challenges. 61% of Analysts say they're excited by the idea of being responsible for solving problems, and 85% say they enjoy tackling difficult challenges.

A core strength of Analysts is their faith in their problem-solving abilities. Analyst personalities tend to express the highest intellectual self-confidence of any Role, and this gives them the willingness to try their hand at things that may be hard. Taken too far, this can turn into cockiness – which is rarely an asset, whether in relationships or in other spheres. But as long as Analysts balance their intellectual self-assurance

with their innate curiosity, these personality types can find success and even enjoyment in the face of challenges both large and small.

Diplomats – Intuitive (N) and Feeling (F)

Longing for Connection

Diplomat personality types – Advocates (INFJ), Mediators (INFP), Protagonists (ENFJ), and Campaigners (ENFP) – care about helping and connecting with others. They prioritize being kind and generous, and in general, they'd rather cooperate than compete. Empathy seems to come naturally to these personalities. It can almost seem as if their hearts and minds resonate with other people's emotions.

These types aim to understand themselves and others. They often have deep insights into human nature, and they can use these insights to influence the people around them. Fortunately, Diplomat personality types tend to do this with care. They are sensitive to other people's feelings, and they want to nudge the people around them in positive directions.

Striving for Change

Diplomats have a deep belief in the ideals of humanism – altruism, compassion, and understanding. These personality types believe it is possible to create a kinder world, and they strive to do so every day.

The Intuitive trait fuels this optimism. Paradoxically, though, it also makes these types hyper-sensitive to wrongdoing. This sensitivity provides Diplomat personalities with the motivation they need to tackle injustice, which is important. If left unchecked, however, this personality trait can trigger self-righteousness or single-mindedness.

In general, Diplomats are motivated by principles rather than practicality. This helps them to stay true to their big dreams and ideas. That said, these types may have trouble enacting plans that are pragmatic rather than passion-driven. Diplomats can be tempted to ignore day-to-day tasks in favor of their big dreams and ideas. As these personalities mature, however, they often learn to balance these necessary tasks with the big-picture thinking they enjoy.

A Higher Purpose

Among friends and family, Diplomat personalities can range from quietly caring to brightly gregarious. Unfortunately, their open hearts can make them vulnerable when others are inconsiderate. That said, these types wouldn't have it any other way. Someone must trust first, and Diplomats will almost always volunteer.

These personality types see magical beauty where others see the humdrum of daily life. This trait attracts many Diplomats to creative expression. These types can be passionately inspired by music, writing, cuisine, theater – or many other creative pursuits.

Diplomats want to bring progress and beauty to the world around them. These types are led by a sense of higher purpose, and they care about serving the greater good. As a result, activism, spirituality, healing, and volunteering are common interests for these personality types.

The Need to Belong

For Diplomats, authenticity and connection aren't just buzzwords. These concepts – which might seem vague or wishy-washy to other types – form the bedrock of

Diplomats' lives. This explains why relationships matter so much to these personality types – and not just *any* type of relationship, but rather real, meaningful bonds.

When asked about their ideal social life, only 8% of Diplomats would like to spend most of their time alone. Instead, the majority of Diplomats express a desire for a partner and a few good friends. These personalities may also worry more about loneliness than other types, with nearly two thirds of Diplomats saying they worry about being lonely in their old age.

For many Diplomats, a central challenge of their lives is to balance their need for authenticity with their need to belong. More than any other personality Role, Diplomats say that the need to belong often motivates them to do things they otherwise wouldn't. This sort of behavior might not bother other types, but it poses a real dilemma for Diplomats. Being fake can feel literally painful to these types, who long to be loved and accepted for who they are, not for their ability to fit in.

For Diplomats, an important part of self-development is learning to be real – even if they fear that doing so won't make them popular. The irony is that many Diplomat personalities only feel a deep sense of belonging and connection once they learn to approach relationships as their whole, true selves.

What is Success, Anyway?

If your life goals are to earn pots of money, land an impressive job, buy a fancy car, and be better than everyone else – well, you're probably not a Diplomat.

But that isn't to say that Diplomats don't have their own type of ambition. 85% of Diplomats say it's important to them to make a lasting impact on other people, outside of their family and closest friends. In other words, these personality types

want to make a lasting difference in the world – which is no small feat. This might explain why Diplomats are second only to Analysts in saying that they sometimes set impossibly high standards for themselves.

Perhaps because they have such a lofty view of success, Diplomats are the Role least likely to consider themselves successful. It's important to note that the great majority of people with these personality types still say they'd be upset if they never became successful. As a result, many people with these types may feel as if they're constantly striving toward ideals and expectations that they'll never meet.

To address this sense of inadequacy, many Diplomats find they must let go of comparisons to other people. 79% of Diplomats say they consciously compare themselves to others either often or very often. By releasing these comparisons, Diplomats can free themselves to do things their own way, in their own time – rather than fretting over whether they're successful yet.

Time to Leap

You know that expression, “Leap and the net will appear”? Diplomat personality types can fall into the trap of thinking they've leapt – metaphorically speaking – when they're actually still perched at the ledge. Because these personalities have such active mental lives and imaginations, they can forget that thinking about starting a business isn't the same as actually starting a business, or that watching videos of dancers isn't the same as throwing themselves into a pirouette.

For many Diplomats, the secret to tackling their greatest challenge is simply to take action. Of course, that's easier said than done. The majority of Diplomats say they overthink simple tasks – so you can only imagine how much they might overthink major life decisions or their most precious dreams.

Fortunately, Diplomats tend to have a deep intuitive sense of what is right for them. Many of these personality types find that by tuning into this wisdom – and honoring it – they can find satisfaction and meaning in their everyday lives, no matter what challenges arise along the way.

Sentinels – Observant (S) and Judging (J)

Character and Competence

Sentinels – Logisticians (ISTJ), Defenders (ISFJ), Executives (ESTJ), and Consuls (ESFJ) – are cooperative, practical, and grounded. They feel comfortable with who they are, and they take pride in their good character and their competence. These personality types seek order, security, and stability, and they tend to work hard to maintain their way of things. This leads to a deserved reputation as the cornerstone of any group or organization, from family to church to the office and the factory floor.

Careful and consistent, Sentinel personalities tend to be self-motivated. This means that they rarely need external inspiration to be productive and focused. They work hard and aim never to let anyone down, and they expect other people to embrace this same ethic as well. Given a choice, these personality types prefer to collaborate within a clear set of rules. Following proven methods makes more sense to them than swanning around in search of innovation. Their motto is, “If it works, don’t break it.”

Steady Progress

That said, Sentinels are hardly unimaginative. They simply take inspiration from the past rather than the future. These personality types remain loyal to established best practices and traditions, whether that’s the best way to make a pizza crust or the

most efficient way to write an algorithm. This enables them to make steady, consistent progress – which is exactly what they enjoy. Sentinels would much rather guide a single project to completion than start (and abandon) a flurry of interesting ideas.

Sentinel personalities thrive in environments that have clear hierarchies and rules. Whether or not they're in a formal leadership role, they care about setting a good example, and they gain great satisfaction from guiding a well-functioning group. This can make them excellent teachers, managers, and community officials, as well as caring parents and hosts.

Guidance and Wisdom

In their personal lives, Sentinels want to offer stability and wisdom to others. They see it as their duty to give their families safe, happy lives that prepare them for the real world. An appreciation of strong relationships allows these personality types to share generously with those they respect and love. Sentinels feel bolstered by having reliable people in their lives, and they make sure they hold up their end of the bargain. Birthdays, dinner parties, and camping trips are delightful events under their enthusiastic direction.

These personality types are happiest without drama – though they can occasionally be stubborn. In particular, inconsistent people can test Sentinels' patience. It can be difficult for Sentinel personalities to accept people who lack their conscientiousness. Fortunately, they often serve as engaged and caring mentors to those who wish to grow in that direction.

Love and Care

Sentinels are the personality Role least likely to say they fall in love easily – but don't let that fool you. Sentinels may not spout love poems, but they do express affection and admiration – they just do it a little differently than other personality types. Sentinels often show their love in practical ways, such as checking the tires on their partner's car or making them a nutritious dinner. To other types, these actions might not look romantic, but Sentinels do these things with love and care.

In all of their relationships, Sentinels want to make contributions. This attitude informs how they treat not only their nearest and dearest but also their acquaintances, neighbors, and coworkers. These aren't the personality types who neglect their responsibilities or leave the office kitchen a mess – in fact, they're often the types who quietly clean up other people's messes, both literal and metaphorical.

Of course, Sentinels wouldn't *mind* being recognized for the ways they help others, but these personalities rarely demand attention. Instead, they work behind the scenes to make everyone's lives run as smoothly as possible, even if that means taking on unglamorous tasks like remembering to buy toilet paper or handling their family's income taxes. They may not be obvious with their feelings, but Sentinels do care and care deeply – you just have to know how to spot it.

Due Diligence

Sentinels have a core set of principles that they bring to their academic and professional pursuits. These principles include diligence, honesty, and respect. The result is that Sentinel personality types tend to work hard, striving to meet deadlines, and generally get things done. This can be seen even from a relatively young age –

Sentinels are far more likely than other Roles to say that they developed productive work habits in school.

These personality types have a clear vision of what it means to do things “right,” and they take great pride in living up to these standards. Sentinels are rarely willing to cut corners and do shoddy work – even if doing so would help them get ahead. They are less likely than any other Role to say that they could compromise some of their principles to advance their career.

Above all, Sentinels stand out for their ability to stick with their work until it’s done – even if the work is tedious or rote. These personality types are far less likely than others to say that they often abandon work in favor of doing something more interesting and fun, and they’re also less likely to say that they get distracted from what they’re working on. For Sentinels, productivity is a bit of a superpower – and they get great satisfaction from exercising their ability to get things done.

Planning Ahead

Sentinels know the value of a well-made plan. Compared to other Roles, Sentinel personalities are far more likely to say they’d rather prepare for problems rather than tackle them as they arise. And Sentinels aren’t afraid to think up every contingency that might arise – as long as they can do something to avert disaster, that is.

Of course, we can’t prepare for everything – although if anyone could, it would be a Sentinel. Like everyone else, these types must occasionally face unforeseen problems. Learning to roll with the punches, so to speak, is an important part of their personal development. Over time, Sentinels can learn to distinguish between when they should stick with their plans and when they’d do well to change course. And

when they do so, these personality types can press through even the most challenging of circumstances, bringing together determination and adaptability.

Explorers – Observant (S) and Prospecting (P)

On the Fly

Explorers – Virtuosos (ISTP), Adventurers (ISFP), Entrepreneurs (ESTP), and Entertainers (ESFP) – tend to be self-reliant and quick-thinking. These personality types don't mind handling uncertain situations on the fly – in fact, they live for those types of situations. Explorers' flexibility helps them to adapt to the moment, even if they don't feel particularly prepared.

These types tend not to be obsessed with precise detail – unless they're really in the zone, in which case they can muster a level of precision and focus that would make a seasoned engineer blush with envy. Usually, they prefer workability and usefulness to perfection. Explorer personalities enjoy learning different tools and techniques, from rotary saws to sheet music to emergency response strategies.

Living for Change

Explorers can change their minds with minimal regret or second-guessing. People in this Role dislike monotony, and they may stray from their obligations in order to try new things. If these personality types sometimes leave business unfinished, let clutter build up, or misplace important things – it's because they've moved on to something fresh.

These types enjoy being free of obligations, where they can indulge themselves or their interests on their own time. They love delving into something interesting, but their interest tends to wane as soon as something becomes "mandatory." An

Explorer personality might design and build their own dream house, but end up procrastinating on simple repairs after a few years.

Social Ingenuity

This free-form attitude can make Explorer personalities socially dynamic as well. Their spontaneity draws them to appealing strangers and interesting experiences. When things get in the way of a good time, they apply their ingenuity to get around it. Explorers want to see what happens next!

Explorers enjoy being on the leading edge of things – whether that means having the latest technology, trying out fashion trends, or checking out the newest restaurant in town. Many Explorer personalities enjoy sharing these findings with others, and they take pride in introducing their friends and loved ones to the latest and greatest things. The result is that time spent with Explorers is almost never boring or repetitive – and Explorers wouldn't have it any other way.

Explorers in Love

Explorer personality types have a reputation for constantly being on the move – and some people might wonder whether this restlessness applies to their romantic relationships as well. According to our research, however, relatively few Explorers (32%) say they're easily bored by romantic relationships that are stable and predictable. In fact, Analysts and Diplomats are significantly more likely to agree with this statement.

So, what *are* Explorers like in romantic relationships? First, Explorers are slightly less likely than other Roles to say that falling in love scares them. These personality types thrive in unpredictable situations, and what is falling in love if not unpredictable? The

early phases of a relationship are energizing for these types – full of new experiences and fresh discoveries.

It's true that Explorer personalities are somewhat more likely than other Roles to avoid commitment. Still, the majority of Explorers – 63% – say they usually seek commitment in their relationships. And overall, Explorers are slightly more likely than average to say that intimate relationships have increased their maturity more than anything else. So, while Explorers might have a reputation for being commitment-phobes, it's clear that these personality types see the deeper value of long-term relationships – and, more often than not, this is exactly what they're looking for.

Doing the Work

Explorers are highly spontaneous, connecting with their environment in a way that's almost childlike in its wonder and sheer fun. But when they need to work on something that's frustrating or unexciting – well, that can prove something of a challenge.

This may show up in how Explorer personality types approach their academic and professional lives. Explorers are slightly less likely than other Roles to say that they developed productive work habits in school. They're also less likely to say that it was easy for them to do well in school. Many school environments are relatively prescriptive, filled with required courses and standardized curricula. As a result, Explorer personalities often find themselves forced to sit through classes that just don't excite them – which, for these types, can be unmotivating. Unfortunately, this can persist in their professional lives as well – after all, most jobs require at least some degree of routine, unglamorous work.

This isn't to say that Explorers are slouches – far from it. When they're working on something they're passionate about, these personality types can move heaven and earth. And, over time, they often find ways to deal with the necessary evils – in other words, the unexciting tasks – that make work and life run more smoothly.

Perhaps it's most accurate to say that Explorers look for ways to balance work with leisure. They're the Role least likely to say they make themselves finish all of their tasks before they allow themselves to relax. While some personality types might brand this behavior as laziness, this isn't necessarily the case. Explorers' ability to balance work with fun can help them avoid burnout. Ultimately, this can help them to enjoy more fulfillment – and yes, a surprising degree of productivity – in their lives.

The Power of Risk

51% of Explorers say they take risks simply for the fun of it – far more than any other personality Role. This might sound reckless, and indeed it can be. But, done responsibly, risk-taking can be one of the best ways to learn new things, solve tricky problems, and grow as people. As Explorers know, we can only make so much progress in life if we stay in our comfort zones.

As long as they temper this trait with a degree of self-control, comfort with risk can be one of Explorers' greatest strengths. It can motivate them to open up in their relationships and empower them to seek out new academic and professional opportunities.

These personality types don't resign themselves to the "lives of quiet desperation" that Henry David Thoreau famously wrote of in *Walden*. Instead, Explorers can use their own brand of bravery to free themselves from conventionality and create lives that work for them.

Strategies

The word “strategy” suggests a course of action. In our use, Strategy describes how personality types act in response to the world around them and how they might choose to accomplish things.

Strategies express themselves primarily in two ways: social style and resistance to stress. Social style entails how other people factor into an individual’s Strategy and to what degree. One example might involve whether a person prefers working in a team or alone.

Resistance to stress includes the degree of impact that a stressful situation might have on an individual and their efforts, as well as how resilient they might be when trying to restore themselves after a challenging event. An example of this might involve whether a person quits after a jarring setback or presses forward.

The Energy aspect (Introverted/Extraverted) brings to each combination a social piece. When individuals pursue their goals or satisfy their needs and wants, to what degree will they involve other people? Do they want to achieve things independently, or are they collaborators and team players? Extraverted personality types often wish to have more people around, and Introverts tend to prefer doing things more independently.

But the Energy aspect also speaks to risk and taking leaps of faith. Extraverts tend to be more adventurous, and they are brimming with enthusiasm for the activities in their lives – especially if they involve other people. Introverts feel a pull toward lone activities and are usually calmer and quieter, preferring quiet and solitude or smaller, more intimate groups when possible. Introverted personality types are not as interested in adventures as their Extraverted counterparts.

The Identity aspect (Assertive/Turbulent) describes levels of confidence and resistance to stress. It helps us understand what might motivate someone. Are they being pulled along by their self-confidence, or are they pushed to excel because they are perfectionists focused on preventing mistakes and failures?

Assertive personalities are much less likely to worry about things – even results. Their motivation may involve boldly realizing the potential that they assume they have. They are less concerned with the opinions of others and may stand up to their critics – not to impress them but to “correct” them. Turbulent personalities are self-conscious, cautious, and perfectionistic. They may go one of two ways. They may push themselves to high levels of success to avoid disappointment in themselves, or they may opt out of doing something because of the potential for stress and the chance of failure.

In summary, Strategies combine the Energy aspect and the Identity aspect. Together, they describe how individuals respond to life and reflect their preferred ways of doing things. When merged, the Energy and Identity personality traits influence many areas of life, including social preferences, confidence, stress, and risk-taking, to name a few.

The Strategy layer shows our preferred ways of doing things and achieving goals. There are four strategies:

Confident Individualism – Introverted (I) and Assertive (-A)

Substance Over Superficiality

Confident Individualists tend to trust in themselves. They enjoy their own company and don't mind spending time alone to pursue their interests. Over time, this can give these personalities an impressive range of skills and interesting ideas.

But these types take pride in their skills for their own sake, not to impress others. They tend not to see the point in social displays and bragging. While they're proud of who they are, these personality types don't always feel the need to prove themselves to anyone else. They prefer substance to superficiality and personal honesty to playing along.

Confident Individualists are motivated by their inner world rather than outside expectations. They're opinionated, but they aren't excessively worried about what others think. These personality types express their thoughts unapologetically. They're rarely pressured into agreeing with others – even if agreeing would be more convenient.

Self-Assurance and Self-Reliance

If left unchecked, this relaxed self-assurance can lead to complacency. These personality types' live-and-let-live attitude goes both ways: They don't push others to change, and in return, they don't particularly want anyone to push them to change. At times, Confident Individualists may miss information and opportunities that challenge their views because they simply don't place much importance on others' approval.

In their personal relationships, these types tend to be strong and honest. Their loyalty and affection are genuine rather than forced. These personalities only express respect and care if they really feel them. Fortunately, if they do feel them, they see no reason to hide how they feel.

No matter how strong their relationships, these types also value self-reliance. They can handle difficult situations well because they tend to be emotionally secure and resistant to stress. Although these personalities rarely seek the spotlight, their quiet examples of determination and honesty can be nothing short of inspiring.

Confident Individualists in Love

Confident Individualists tend to be a bit choosy about their closest confidants. This is especially true when it comes to finding a romantic partner. Perhaps because Confident Individualists know how to find contentment and fulfillment even when they're single, they're in no rush to settle for a partner who's less than a good match.

These personality types may also be less likely to stay with a partner who lets them down. Confident Individualists are less likely than any other personality Strategy to say they often give second chances to those who fail to fulfill commitments to them. Again, perhaps because of their strong intrinsic sense of worth, these types don't necessarily feel compelled to stay in a relationship that isn't working out.

Confident Individualists are the Strategy least likely to say they believe in soulmates. They're also the least likely to say they know a lot of couples whose marriages they envy, or would aspire to have. And it might not come as a surprise, then, that they're the most likely to say they don't want to get married.

It would be inaccurate, however, to assume that Confident Individualists are lone wolves with no interest in committed intimate relationships. The majority of these personality types – 79% – *do* express an interest in getting married. A similar percentage say they're unafraid of being committed to a single partner for the rest of their lives. It's true that Confident Individualists are independent, and they probably won't get into a relationship just for the sake of being in a relationship. That said, these types often do have an interest in romantic connection – they just want to find the right person before they become attached.

Unlikely Leaders

Confident Individualists bring their love of independence into their academic and professional pursuits. They're more likely than any other Strategy to say that learning as part of a group is distracting rather than helpful. As you can imagine, group projects can be frustrating for these personality types – whether at school or in the workplace.

This isn't to say that Confident Individualists *can't* work well with others – far from it. But if given a choice, these types would prefer to operate independently and figure things out on their own. At school, these personalities may be drawn to independent study opportunities. At work, they may try to develop a specific area of expertise that allows them to make their own decisions and do most of their tasks on their own.

From this description, Confident Individualists might not sound like natural leaders, but that isn't necessarily the case. Just over half of these personality types say they're inclined to seek out leadership and management roles. This is well less than their Extraverted peers, but it's still a majority. In addition, nearly 70% of these types say

they have excellent leadership skills. A quick look at famous Confident Individualists includes real-life leaders (Bill Gates) as well as fictional ones (Gandalf).

Confident Individualists tend to hone their ideas and skills on their own, and they often prefer to work alone. That said, these personalities may be willing to take up the reins of leadership if that's what is necessary to turn those ideas and skills into real-world progress.

The Right Mindset

Confident Individualists are more likely than any other personality Strategy to say that control over their mindset is the most important factor in determining their happiness. On average, they rank their mindset as a more significant factor in their happiness than their financial situation, their friends and family, their job, or their health.

This statistic reveals a great deal about Confident Individualists. These personality types believe in their personal effectiveness and their individual worth, and they know how important it is to maintain this mindset. As long as they balance this self-conviction with a willingness to learn from others, Confident Individualists' positive mindset can become a self-fulfilling prophecy, helping these personalities to not only achieve great things but also find lasting happiness.

People Mastery – Extraverted (E) and Assertive (-A)

Bold and Confident

Personality types with the People Mastery Strategy are known for their ability to handle stress. This helps them to act boldly and maintain confidence, even in the face of challenges or criticism.

Thanks to this confidence, people with this Strategy feel energized and at ease in social situations. They seek social contact as well as stimulating and challenging experiences. These personalities like traveling to see things, people, and places, and trying something new – even things they don't end up liking can be exciting for them.

Nothing to Prove?

If they don't keep themselves in check, though, People Masters can become too confident. These personality types tend to be insulated against self-doubt and the need to prove themselves. As a result, they don't always test, or even consider, their own limits or ambitions.

Taken to the extreme, this can create a pattern of comfort-seeking. They may even roll their eyes at people who chase more intimidating goals. At the other end of the spectrum, these personality types can ignore sensible caution, landing themselves in extraordinary and dangerous situations.

At times, People Masters may not be considerate to those who aren't able to maintain such a comfortable boldness. But this doesn't have to be the case, by any means. By taking others into account, these personalities can actually help to draw other people out of their shells in a way that's energizing and empowering.

Finding Balance

Fortunately, most People Masters fall somewhere in the middle. Ideally, they embrace healthy ambition while finding social fulfillment and connection. Social interaction plays a big part in People Masters' happiness. Although these personality types are self-confident, they still appreciate praise and recognition. They don't need

people's approval, but they still crave friends and loved ones with whom to share their lives.

These types may be opinionated, but they don't always worry about having others agree with them. This can help these personalities to be moderate even in disagreements because their ego and confidence aren't at stake the way they often are for Turbulent Strategies. People Masters are not fond of grudges, and at heart, they want to bring people together to make things happen.

These types often stand out for their charisma and self-assurance. As long as they don't use their talents to steamroll or put down others, these personality traits can be quite appealing. These types have little fear of rejection, and they love including others. This can make these personalities wonderful friends, loved ones, and colleagues, who always aim to energize those around them.

People Masters in Love

According to our research, People Masters seem to fall in love a bit more frequently than the other Strategies. They're also less likely to say that falling in love scares them. It's easy to imagine why this is the case – People Masters' Extraversion leads them into situations where they're likely to meet new people, and their Assertive personality trait helps them to feel confident about the prospect of new relationships.

Some might wonder whether this would make People Masters less reliable than other personality types when it comes to being a good partner. Is it possible that these types' self-assurance would make them complacent or uncommitted once they're actually *in* a relationship? Not necessarily: About half of People Masters say it's necessary to go out of their way to please someone they love, and this response

puts them on par with other types. In addition, People Masters are the Strategy least likely to say that long-term commitments make them anxious.

In other words, although People Masters' confidence and social ease might make them sound like players, these types can be as committed and eager to please their partners as anyone else. And being in a relationship with a People Master can be a wonderful thing – even for people who are completely different. After all, People Masters' social energy and their can-do take on life can be infectious in the best possible way.

Speaking Up

People Masters don't tend to filter their opinions. These personality types say what they think, and they think what they say. As with nearly any trait, this can be a strength or a weakness.

People Masters are often seen as straight-shooters who can be trusted to speak honestly. In academic and professional settings, many teachers, classmates, colleagues, and managers appreciate this quality. After all, if used appropriately, candor is a powerful way to connect with other people. The “what you see is what you get” nature of a People Master personality can be refreshing, whether in the classroom or the workplace.

But there's a difference between being candid and being rude – and at times, People Masters may toe that line. In academic settings, this can put them at odds with their teachers and classmates. And in professional settings, these personality types may gain a reputation for being inconsiderate, arrogant, or even ruthless.

Learning to speak honestly *without* speaking over other people is a step on many People Masters' path to personal development. Fortunately, once they master this balance, People Masters can unleash the many gifts they bring to their schooling and their work. In particular, People Masters can excel at dealing with awkward or tense interpersonal situations – whether that's getting a group project back on track or delivering bad news to a customer in a straightforward but considerate way.

Going for It

79% of People Masters say they see problems as opportunities. These personality types trust themselves to tackle hard problems – *and* to gain insight and experience from the process. Ideally, this conviction becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy, with People Masters taking on ever harder challenges and learning important lessons along the way.

What sets People Masters apart isn't just their confidence, however. It's also their willingness to team up with others. These personalities know that we tend to be more effective when we collaborate and ask for help. People Masters can be especially good at creating opportunities for the people around them to use their strengths. And that may just be one of the secrets to People Masters' success.

Constant Improvement – Introverted (I) and Turbulent (-T)

Sensitive Souls

Constant Improvers tend to be sensitive and introspective. They are often deep individuals who enjoy having their own space and freedom. In general, these personality types feel more comfortable on their own than mixed up in the judgment of the real world.

This may be because they share the two personality traits most representative of sensitivity to their environment – Introversion and Turbulence. As a result, they may find it stressful to deal with tense environments or new situations. In these moments, Constant Improvers can be deeply uncomfortable – although they may not want to let on how they really feel. In reaction, these personalities might retreat inward, react defensively, or try to escape the situation altogether. Alternatively, they might give up their own wants or needs in an effort to keep the peace.

Driven by Doubt

Constant Improvers tend to experience self-doubt. They have a strong drive, but it comes paired with a strong fear of failure. These personality types invest a great deal of their identity in their successes. As a result, even a minor misstep or embarrassment can be crushing.

On the upside, this vigilance offers these personality types a knack for sensing trouble. This can be quite useful in situations that need to balance risk and reward – whether a financial investment or a romantic opportunity. When faced with a potential risk, these types look for ways to prevent problems. Although it slows them down in the short term, this approach can prevent longer-term issues.

Constant Improvers direct much of their attention toward their personal interests. They strive to master hobbies, careers, or new means of self-expression. This level of dedication can create impressive, beautiful results.

People with Constant Improvement personality types can be perfectionistic, dedicating tremendous time and energy to their pursuits. Unfortunately, if they put too much pressure on themselves, this approach can backfire. For example, Constant

Improvers may feel forced to abandon an endeavor because a single detail doesn't line up right.

Reality and Romance

At times, Constant Improvers may experience a nagging feeling that something is missing from their lives. It's worth noting that often this really is just a feeling, not a reflection of reality. These personality types have it in their nature always to be seeking something more – even if their lives actually are going just fine.

But as Constant Improvers assess their lives, wondering what might be missing, they may find themselves focusing on their romantic relationships – or lack thereof. These types are significantly less likely than their Assertive counterparts (also known as Confident Individualists) to say that they enjoy being single. And these personalities are more likely than Confident Individualists to say they often construct an ideal partner in their heads when they're single.

Although Constant Improvers may find themselves longing for romance, they don't necessarily find it easy to start up a relationship. They're less likely than other personality Strategies to say that they usually take the initiative in asking someone out. This makes sense, given that Constant Improvers can feel hesitant about putting themselves out there – and asking someone out is an incredibly vulnerable position to be in.

This might sound like bad news, but it doesn't have to be. As they grow and mature, Constant Improvers often learn how to transform their feeling that something is missing into positive energy – and by doing so, they not only discover gratitude for the good things in their lives, but also become proactive about making helpful

changes. This mindset shift can empower these personality types to find fulfillment in their relationships – as well as in every other aspect of their lives.

The “Right” Career?

Constant Improvers’ longing for “something more” extends to their professional lives. Just over a quarter of these types say that their career is a great fit for them – a rate of agreement that is less than the other Strategies.

This doesn’t necessarily mean that Constant Improvers are in the wrong careers for them – although they might wonder if they are. More than half of these personality types say they often think about switching careers, and they’re more likely than the other Strategies to say that they feel stuck in their current job.

This restlessness doesn’t have to be a bad thing. In fact, restlessness can be an incredible motivator to do great things. The trouble comes when Constant Improvers feel trapped: wanting to make a change, but suspecting they’re unable or helpless to do so. This feeling can have a number of roots, such as self-doubt or a general worry that other people don’t “get” them.

As in other areas of their lives, Constant Improvers who pursue personal growth often discover that their feeling of helplessness is exactly that – a *feeling*. This can be a powerful discovery. In its wake, these personality types are better able to harness their personal and professional strengths and deal with their feeling of “stuckness.” This may take the form of finding a new career, or it might involve advocating for themselves in their current workplaces so that they get more of their needs met. Either way, Constant Improvers often find that they have more agency in their professional lives than they’d realized.

The Strength of Sensitivity

In general, Constant Improvers care a great deal about what others think of them. This can trigger insecurity, to be sure, but when kept in balance, it can create some truly wonderful traits. These personalities are often curious about and sensitive to others' feelings. This can make them excellent listeners, friends, confidants, and partners.

Some types might think that sensitivity is synonymous with weakness, but Constant Improvers know that isn't the case. These personality types often exemplify how sensitivity and vulnerability can be hidden strengths. Their attunement to their own struggles and insecurities can help them to bond deeply with others. It can also motivate them to act with kindness and compassion.

Although they may not always realize it, Constant Improvers offer the world a wealth of gifts. Once they learn to trust themselves as much as they trust others' opinions, these personalities can shine.

Social Engagement – Extraverted (E) and Turbulent (-T)

Boldly Sensitive

Those with the Social Engagement Strategy are an interesting group. In some ways, Extraverted and Turbulent personality traits conflict with each other. Extraversion leads to risk-tolerance and boldness, and Turbulence leads to self-doubt and sensitivity.

This can mean that Social Engagers tend to do what comes naturally first and think about it later. In this way, they are almost an exaggeration of their underlying personality traits. This may sound like a bad thing, but it doesn't have to be.

Social Engagers venture into the world with enthusiasm. They enjoy being the center of attention and enjoy social status. At times, this may mean that they hide their true selves to impress other people, pretending to be someone else in order to be liked. Fortunately, Social Engagers' genuine interest in others often shines through, helping these personality types to create authentic connections with the people around them.

Social Engagers in Love

Romantic relationships aren't always the easiest – hence Shakespeare's observation that "the course of true love never did run smooth." You might think that Social Engagers' self-doubt would cause them to play it safe when it comes to the rough waters of love, but that isn't the case. These personality types tend to dive headlong into relationships – they're more likely than any other Strategy to say they fall in love easily. And they're also less likely to say they enjoy being single.

Social Engagers are far from passive about their romantic lives. These personalities care deeply about pleasing their partners – in fact, they're the Strategy most likely to believe they need to go out of their way to please the people they love. Social Engagers are deeply devoted, willing to pour all of their affection and care into their partner.

But not everyone is willing – or able – to do this in return. Social Engagers may feel it acutely if their partner doesn't seem equally affectionate or devoted. This can be especially challenging because these personality types care so deeply about receiving praise and admiration. As a result, they might feel hurt by a partner who is reserved in expressing their affection.

As they go through life, many Social Engagers discover that not everyone is as expressive as they are – and that's okay. These types may need to use their social

acumen to connect with the ways their partners *do* share love. For example, they may realize that their partner expresses affection through physical touch, spending time together, or even helping out around the house. Once they attune themselves to the ways other personalities demonstrate their love, Social Engagers can find incredible fulfillment and joy in their romantic relationships.

Working It

Social Engagers may find themselves drawn to lines of work that involve plenty of human interaction. The service industry can be a natural fit for these personality types, as can nearly any job that involves helping customers solve problems. Social Engagers are energized by the opportunity to talk with others, and they're especially invigorated when they can tell that they've actually made someone's day a little better.

This isn't to say that Social Engagers are anything less than ambitious. In their own way, these personalities do care about being successful. Everyone has a unique definition of "success," of course, but many Social Engagers feel especially successful when they receive recognition, such as awards, promotions, or positive feedback on their work. These types tend to be motivated by a desire to impress and please others – not only because they enjoy praise, but also because they genuinely value the good opinion of their bosses, coworkers, and customers. And of course a salary increase is always nice, too.

Social Engagers' ambition and desire to please can make them wonderful employees and colleagues. At times, however, these personality types often discover a need to pause and make sure they're being true to themselves as well. Their personal development path may lead them to consider their own values and needs – and make sure that their professional lives line up with these values and needs.

That said, these types know that their career is just one aspect of their lives. 74% of Social Engagers say they're always looking for new hobbies to get into – more than any other personality Strategy. Whether those hobbies include volleyball, viticulture, or volunteering, these types care about being well-rounded. Paradoxically, this well-roundedness can help them to find more enjoyment in their careers as well as in other aspects of their lives.

The Highs and the Lows

Social Engagers can experience highs and lows – sometimes within a matter of minutes. Their Extraversion can push their Turbulent need for success into overdrive. Meanwhile, their Turbulent personality trait can trigger almost instant self-doubt. Although these types are capable of taking quick action in a way that seems decisive, they may find themselves plagued by uncertainty afterward.

As they grow, many Social Engagers learn how to use this unusual combination of traits to their advantage. Their Extraversion can help them move past the self-doubt that comes with the Turbulent trait, enabling them to expand their comfort zones even when it isn't easy. Meanwhile, their Turbulent trait can help them to be more considerate in their boldness. The result is that these personality types can hold many contradictory traits in harmony, being both fun and responsible, active and reflective.

This push and pull can be stressful, but it's part of this Strategy's charm. These personality types chase their goals relentlessly, but they also indulge their desires and seek out fun. Thanks to this balance, they can lead happy and fruitful lives – sharing adventures and accomplishments with others whenever possible. Whatever direction these personalities pull, they are sure to pull the crowd with them.

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